some things (only god can forgive)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/48761527.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warnings:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings, Rape/Non-Con

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Human, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Heavy Angst, Past Child Abuse, Past Sexual Abuse, Past Rape/Non-con, fallout from trauma, Dissociation, Anxiety, Panic Attacks, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Disordered Eating, Suicidal Thoughts, Homicidal Thoughts, Therapy, Paranoia, Depression, Self-Loathing, trial, Recovery, Communication, POV Alternating, Eventual Happy Ending

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Part 3 of things you could never say

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by Morag

Summary

Adora doesn't say what she talks to her therapist about. Catra doesn't tell her what she talks about with Emily, either. They develop a system for starting sessions, practicing all the stuff she's supposed to do when she gets angry or starts to go numb. Listening to her breath and feeling the chair under her and stuff like that. Emily says she'll need that for the trial.

Notes

The "please girls go to therapy" fic everyone has been asking for. It's still going to be rough but they're going to come out better than they went in.

This is designed as a sequel to *if loving you kills me (i would die happy)*, and I don't know how comprehensible this is without that. Reading the other fic in the series, *all you had to do was stay*, is recommended because the events of that fic will be referenced, but I think context will be enough if you haven't read it. Like the last two, this will update weekly, but now on Sundays.

Please read the tags, this fic is about recovery but is still going to get quite dark. Proceed accordingly.

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The therapist says her name is Emily. She has a whole basket of things to fiddle with on the low table between them, stretchy strings and spinning fidgets and stress balls. It reminds Catra of the stuff they had in the decompression room in elementary school. Maybe Emily has a rice bin, even though Catra's way too old for it now.

"Who was in the waiting room with you?" Emily asks, because Catra's life is this random woman's business now.

"Adora," she says, and she sounds cold and robotic like her name isn't etched into Catra's bones somewhere.

"You seem close," Emily says. Her voice is kind of flat too. "Who is she in your life?"

Adora said she still wanted to be her girlfriend. That's what she said to the receptionist when they checked in, *my girlfriend has an appointment too*. Catra wants to believe her when she says that isn't going to change, but that was so much easier to do that when she had anything to offer as a partner. She half-expects Adora to give her a scrunched apology face an hour from now, after her therapist has explained why she's being insane for even considering keeping her. Adora never thinks she deserves as much as she does, and that's the only reason she's willing to settle for whatever rotten thing Catra is.

The nerd asked a question. Catra flickers through all the words she and Adora have ever used to describe who they are to each other. They probably couldn't go back to pretending they were sisters if they've had sex, even if apparently Adora hated it. Glimmer and Bow say they're Adora's best friends and that never mattered before because Catra was something better.

"My roommate," she tries, and it sounds brittle and dead instead of detached.

Emily asks about what she likes to do for fun and Catra begrudgingly shows her the puzzle she was working on in the waiting room. Emily spots DECLARE immediately, and when Catra says she already found that one Emily says, "Wait, give me a sec," and she asks if Catra found VALANCE. She doesn't even notice that her shoulders have relaxed as they find a few more words, until Emily asks if she plays these with Adora and they jump up again as she remembers why she's there.

"Just ask what you actually want to know," Catra says, heart in her throat.

Emily tilts her head a little and Catra holds eye contact even though it itches. "A lot of my clients prefer to build rapport first, but if you're ready to talk about why you're here, I'm listening."

Then Catra has to look away, chest pounding, and she should have answered her stupid question about word games or whatever. When Adora said she had an appointment for today, she'd said, *you have to talk, for therapy to work. Be honest about what's happening in your head. It's really hard*. She wanted Catra to agree to try and Catra did, like an idiot.

"Adora wanted me to come," she says, and if she crosses her arms she can make fists under her elbows.

"Did she tell you why?"

She's already had this conversation. But it was with Adora, it was different, she barely had to tell her anything because Weaver couldn't keep a fucking secret. Adora said it would be hard and Catra said she'd try anyway like an idiot. *My body shuts down at the worst times. I lied to my girlfriend. My foster mother-*

"I get mad sometimes," Catra says, and it's true even if it isn't why Adora wants her here. That's the thing that everyone at

school was always trying to fix and they never could, because the thing in her skin can't act like a person. "She doesn't like it."

"Why?"

The shapes on the carpet follow a pattern, repeating blocks, and following it makes it easier to pretend that maybe she's making up this conversation. "I say awful shit when I get like that."

"If you feel like your anger is out of control, that's something we can work on," Emily says. "We can develop better tools to help you respond to anger the way you want to." She sounds like every person who's ever talked to Catra about *coping skills*, like tensing and releasing her muscles are going to put someone else in her bones. Catra made a deal with Adora to try this.

Emily wants to know about the last time she felt like she was too angry, and Catra thinks about slamming books to the ground and snarling poison at Adora until she melted down, until she wouldn't let Catra touch her because she thought she'd broken Catra too. Adora begged her to stay because she thinks the only things she can have are things she has to fight for, and if Catra was even a molecule less of a selfish bitch she would leave.

"We had an argument," she says, and it tastes wrong, like every time she said she had an accident to explain why she was bruised or scabbed or bandaged, every time she said she'd been home sick.

"Why did you two argue?"

"I thought she lied to me. About something important."

"That would probably make most people angry," Emily says, and she doesn't get it, Adora sent her to go talk to another idiot who doesn't get it.

"I wanted to tell her that she's why her mom killed herself," Catra grits out. "I wanted to punch her. That's not what *most people* do."

"It sounds like you didn't, though."

"No," she says. Even when Catra was so angry she couldn't see, she couldn't do that to her. It's bad enough that she hit her when they were kids, and even when she was old enough to know better. If Catra ever loses it bad enough to do that now, she'll find the most painful way to die and make it go as slow as she can manage, no matter if Adora still wants her or not. The voice in the back of her head that never quite shuts up says she should be doing that already.

"It sounds like you care about her and you work hard to make sure you don't hurt her."

She's supposed to be honest, Adora had said. "I *already* fucking hurt her," Catra says, eyes prickling. "She's-" and Catra doesn't know where to even start. "I lied to her. For a long time. I didn't - I didn't tell her what-"

The words lock up, like a busted wheel, and she just manages not to punch the couch she's sitting on.

Emily waits quietly, like a cat watching a bug before it pounces. Adora used to tell Catra that she wasn't trying hard enough, and she doesn't say that anymore but she probably thinks it. Catra growls in frustration before she can stop herself, because she's never figured out how to be a fucking human being.

Emily says, "It's okay if you're not ready yet, we just met. That's why I usually have us get to know each other a little first."

The idea that someone would have to know anything about her before they know what Weaver did is ridiculous. Of all the people on earth, only a handful of the people who know have even met her. And she's going to have to do this eventually, what is she waiting for? Why is she being so ridiculous about this?

Emily asks some other dumb question about nothing. This was a terrible idea, she told Adora there wasn't a better person in her somewhere, there was no point to any of this. If the way she is

isn't good enough maybe she should just give up. "You're wasting your fucking time," Catra says. Her ears buzz. "This is so stupid."

Emily is holding something out to her. It's a toilet paper tube, and she blinks at it for a second before Emily shifts and Catra takes it. She didn't realize she was holding her elbows, nails biting in, until she has to let go.

"Some people like to destroy things in here," Emily says. "I have a lot of these."

Catra can't quite identify the emotion in her throat. "I tear paper," she says. "Sometimes."

Emily says it sounds like a good strategy, and Catra can hear part of a smile in her voice, and it's so much like being in the decompression room when she was a kid, one of the only times there was an adult who she thought gave a shit, that she tenses her jaw so she doesn't cry.

"I don't know your particular circumstances," Emily says, "but I primarily see clients here for negative sexual experiences."

She can feel her mouth wrenching despite her, and she tries to scowl. She rips off a chunk of cardboard and it helps. "That's a way to fucking put it."

"Most of my clients find it hard to talk about at first, especially if they've kept it a secret for a long time."

Cardboard is loud when it tears. "Wouldn't be here if the bitch had kept her fucking mouth shut too." And the sheer unfairness hits her for the first time - Catra doesn't get to say what happened but Weaver gets to gloat? Sell it? Show it off? Catra has no idea why she filmed her and the question burns under her ribs.

"Sometimes it's easier to not confront it, but people can only repress these things for so long. Being able to address it helps a lot of people. I think it will help you, and I think you'll feel better

about your anger too." Emily holds out another tube. "It's hard work, but I know you can feel better than you do now."

Catra doesn't quite buy it, but coming here helped Adora until Catra destroyed her life again. Adora had been so nervous this morning, like Catra is something she doesn't want to lose, and she'd cried into her collarbone yesterday. Catra can't think of something she won't attempt, if Adora asks.

She takes the second roll, and there is a basket full of them behind Emily. "Worth trying," she says.

They go to the park, after, and Catra leaves the building feeling like maybe there are worse ways to waste her time. Adora runs and Catra climbs up in her favorite tree, where she can watch the light flash on Adora's hair when she rounds the corner on a lap, where she can see her face smoothing as the endorphins hit.

Adora still couldn't tell Darla what she'd done. She talks about last night and works around it with giant steps. Darla has to know that Adora's leaving something out - she can't explain why Catra started threatening to leave, why Adora should have let her. Darla says she's doing everything right and Adora's eyes burn with how wrong she is.

Ten minutes before they end, Darla pauses for a moment, the way she does before she says something that's going to make Adora upset. "Do you remember when I asked you if there were other foster children in your home?"

Adora nods, a sick feeling curling in her gut. Earlier in the summer, the night after Adora told her about being small and thinking Catra was going to die, after Darla said she was going to talk to DCFS about the possibility that Weaver got other kids after them, she couldn't sleep. Catra had murmured *stop thinking* into

her clavicle, and it hadn't helped her forget how Catra had mumbled when she came in from the snow, and now she knows what was happening at the same time.

"I know you said Catra doesn't want to talk to the police. Have you talked about the possibility of her still fostering?"

She hadn't told Catra, because they didn't talk about Weaver, then. Adora had finally packed that into a box for her to ignore like everything else. Darla said, after their session on Tuesday, that she would have to call DCFS again, and Adora didn't even think about what that meant. "No."

They wouldn't give her more, right? It's impossible that Weaver has children under her thumb again, that a social worker looked at her file and saw how many times someone had said something and still leave a kid in her house. Darla talks a lot about what Adora couldn't have done, as a child, but she's been an adult for two years now. If Weaver has more foster kids, that's Adora's fault.

Darla says she needs to talk to Catra about it, because they have to consider that when they decide whether or not to give a statement to the police, and Adora can't let the thought go. She can almost outrun it, when they go to the park after, and when they go home Catra makes fun of the glassblowing show and makes faces and laughs, the way only she does, and Adora wants to cling to her and pretend there's no one else in the world but she ruined that.

When they're in bed that night, Catra keeps looking at her, pupils blown in the dim light. "It's okay," she says quietly, "if you changed your mind. About us. If you want us to be friends."

Adora shakes her head, bile in her throat. If she was a good person she would, but she can't. "No," she says. "Never."

Catra laces her fingers through Adora's, kisses her knuckles because getting the rest of her too close is dangerous. Adora let

herself pretend everything was fine, before, and all it did was hurt someone who didn't deserve it. "Love you," Catra says, voice getting sleepy, and Adora says it back but it doesn't fix anything. She needs to stop letting things break in the first place.

Past midnight, the thoughts get worse and worse. Darla said she called DCFS, like that would do anything. Adora remembers the way their social workers talked to Weaver whenever they visited, the exasperated looks Ms. Milagros and Weaver always shared when she showed up at the door. Adora's worker, Ms. Paterson, barely remembered her name and was always checking her watch. Adora doesn't trust DCFS to even remember they exist.

Catra's fingers curl when Adora slips her hand away, but she stays asleep. A cruel corner of Adora's head says *what's one more night*, after twenty months of pretending Weaver's dropped dead on her own, after eighteen years of looking the other way. As if one night is going to undo everything she'd already let happen. Catra was two years old when Ms. Milagros brought her to the door, and for all Adora knows Weaver started that same day, and if she doesn't do something to shut up her active imagination she's going to explode.

The drive is longer than she remembers but the house looks just the same. Adora doesn't know why she expected anything else. Weaver's car is parked out front, and when Adora shines her phone's flashlight inside there's two car seats. One of them still has the hole over one arm where Catra picked at the fabric every time Weaver said she should pull over and dump her out. Adora clenches her fists and tries to channel the panic into something useful, for once.

She bangs on the door long enough to consider what she'll do if Weaver doesn't answer, debate which window is the best to break, but then Weaver's there and Adora *finally* understands how it has to feel when Catra gets angry, because a fire raises in her chest. "How did you get them to give you more?"

"Adora," Weaver says, eyes full of an emotion Adora doesn't want to figure out, smiling, reaching for her face to cup it the way she always did when she told her how good Adora was.

If Adora feels her skin she's going to throw up. She shoves Weaver away. "I asked a fucking question."

"Look at you, my Adora," she says, and there's something in her voice that infects Adora's heart every time, like maybe this is what's real, but she can still hear how Catra sounded when she said *she broke me*.

"I'm not here for you." Adora pushes past her, because Weaver hasn't been bigger or stronger in years but Adora just let her keep going anyway. There's two pairs of small sneakers on the floor by the door, pink and yellow, and Adora wants to hit Weaver until she can't recognize her fucking face anymore. "Where are the kids?"

Weaver raises an eyebrow like Adora's the one being ridiculous. "In their beds, it's nearly three in the morning. As happy as I am to see-"

"Are they both in their beds? Really? Neither of them are *grounded* right now?" Her voice is shaking as bad as she is, she feels insane.

Weaver looks upset, hurt, and Adora looks away so she doesn't have to decide whether to apologize or punch. "I don't know what you're trying to say," Weaver says. "Come on, sit down. Tell me what's going on, let me help."

Adora starts towards the stairs and Weaver grabs her arm and Adora's whole body says *don't move, behave*.

"Adora," Weaver says, and Adora doesn't know when she slammed her against the wall but Weaver's clavicle lifts under her forearm, robe rustling. Weaver hauls in a heavy breath when Adora lets her go and she thinks she might throw up. This isn't about her.

"I'm not here to hurt you," she says, even though if she loves Catra at all maybe she should be. "I don't even want to think about you anymore."

"Listen," Weaver says from behind her. Adora goes up the stairs, where she had her second ever panic attack and Weaver stepped past her when she asked for help, where Weaver said *maybe that performance works at school but I know you're smarter than this,* and she keeps going.

All of Adora's stuff is still in her room, books on the shelf, field hockey sticks in the corner, card from Razz taped to the wall. The last time she was here she was carefully rotating her bruised wrist after Catra punched her and telling herself that everything was fine. The bed is empty, still made. Everything is covered in a fine layer of dust.

"For when you came back," Weaver says quietly from behind her. "I've missed you."

It was always safe in here, for her and Catra, and Weaver is the reason why they needed somewhere safe. Adora turns around and Weaver is looking at her like - like Razz used to. She shuts down that thought hard enough to make her dizzy. Weaver doesn't love her, no matter what she says. Someone who's done what she has can't possibly be able to love. "I'm not coming back," she says.

"Adora."

"Stop saying my name." There's the drawing taped up over her desk of the two of them that Catra drew when they were kids, she doesn't even know how long ago. She doesn't know what was happening when Catra drew it, how many years of Weaver's voice was echoing in her head. She turns back to where Weaver's standing in the doorway of her room. "Move," she says, "or I'll make you."

"Adora," she says, like Adora had never asked her not to. "Stop this."

That's what Adora had said, when they were young enough that they hadn't started school yet, and Weaver was shouting, belt snapping like something from a nightmare and Adora threw out her arms between them and said *please stop*, when she was too young to know better. Weaver put her hand on Adora's face and Catra hugged her legs like it would keep her from leaving and Weaver said *you don't want her to keep getting in trouble, right? you want her to learn how to listen as well as you do.* Adora doesn't remember what happened next, but she never stood between them after that.

Weaver's not wearing the mask but Adora can still see it, hazy with film grain. "I won't let you do it again."

"What nonsense do you have in your head now?"

Weaver sounds disappointed, and once that would have sent her stumbling over herself trying to fix it, do better, prove how smart and mature and good of a girl she was. Now it just makes her cross her arms so she doesn't grapple Weaver again. She isn't going to be like her anymore. "I said move."

Weaver tilts her head, face hurt and sorrowful, and Adora shoves past her harder than she needs to. She gets halfway down the hall to the other bedroom when Weaver says, "Why are you here, Adora?"

She stops, fists tight, breath shuddering in her chest. She told herself the whole drive here that she just had to look and see for herself that no one was here. Adora just needed to know that she hadn't given someone else to Weaver but she had. *Two*, and she knows exactly how many kids Weaver can pretend to love at a time.

"They're leaving tonight," she says. She doesn't know enough about children to add up what she's seen and know how old they are, but Catra was almost nineteen when Weaver tried to kill her for the last time so there is no age when they're safe. "I'm not letting them spend another minute with you."

"Were you going to kidnap them? If they leave this house with you, that's kidnapping."

Adora tries to smile with confidence she doesn't have. "Do you really want the police here?"

"I don't want to see you get into trouble, you're smarter than that." Weaver's footsteps come towards her. Adora presses her tongue against her teeth and reminds herself that she is the strong one now. "I don't know where this is coming from. What do you think I've done to you that's so bad?"

"To me?" It's such an insane question it chokes in her chest. She spins back, but seeing her doesn't help. Glimmer thinks Weaver abused her too, and so does Bow. Darla talks vaguely about *learned behaviors* and *coping mechanisms* and *trauma,* so she clearly does too. Adora knows, objectively, that Weaver wasn't good for any of them, but- "What have you done to *me?*"

"I love you," Weaver says. She reaches out again but stalls when Adora steps back. "Tell me what went wrong between us."

"You did," Adora says, bile pulsing in her throat, looking at Weaver so she can see in her eyes how much she means it. She's a liar, she hurts people, she ruins any chance they could ever be happy. "Call the cops. I'll tell them what you did to her and if you ever get out of prison they'll never let you within a thousand feet of a child ever again."

Weaver's eyes widen in surprise, or pain, or - Adora isn't really interested in how Weaver feels. "You've let that girl spin you a story, haven't you." She always did this, always telling Adora that she was crazy melodramatic *sensitive* so Adora wouldn't believe what her eyes and ears and heart told her, and she doesn't get to do it anymore.

"I saw you!" Adora's close enough that she could grab Weaver again. They're at the top of the stairs, and Adora's never wanted to hurt someone so badly in her life. She's had so many

nightmares about watching Catra die, feeling her life seep out under her useless hands, but maybe it would be different if it's Weaver. Maybe Catra would be able to breathe again. Maybe Adora wouldn't have her voice echoing in her head anymore. "You made sure she couldn't tell me a damn thing, but she didn't have to because I *saw your*-"

Something shuffles behind the bedroom door, and knowing that there is someone in there should be all the more reason to throw Weaver over the banister. It isn't. It makes the energy punch out of her like she's been punctured, cold panic flooding in instead. They're right there and she's hit with everything that could be wrong, right now. She doesn't keep her first aid kit in the car anymore, because she was foolish enough to let herself pretend that everyone was safe.

Adora's gone still and Weaver steps around her and opens the door, and two faces blink at her from the bottom bunk. Adora does the same quick scan she's done a million times and doesn't see anything, but she knows how little that means. They're two girls, maybe five or six, a mismatched set of twins like Adora and Catra had been, and Adora doesn't scream. "It's okay, girls," Weaver says, looking at Adora. "My daughter was just leaving."

Adora can't think about *daughter* right now. She takes a step forward. One of them inches back, eyes darting to the other, and Adora stops walking. Her chest hurts. There's a lot of things she wants to say. *This isn't how families are supposed to be*, and *everything she says is wrong,* and *you deserve more than this, no matter what she tells you*. "Come on," she says instead, even though Weaver's standing between them and her, even though she knows Weaver can call the police. Her voice crackles. She holds out her hand. "Let's go."

The kids stare at her, faces the same as Catra's and Lonnie's when they were little and trying not to look scared, and they don't move. "I don't know what lies that girl fed you," Weaver says, "but-"

Weaver is right there, too close again, and one of the kids screams muffled and Adora's aching hand matches the red spot on Weaver's face. Adora looks back and the faces are gone under the covers, and they know how to cry quiet already, and Adora wants to pick them up and carry them out in her arms but she can't, she can't.

She's crying in front of Weaver for the first time in more than ten years. Her fist stings and she said she wasn't going to be like her but here she is. Weaver says, voice cold, "I think you need to go."

Adora isn't sure how she got back outside or how long she's been there. She's in the car, trying to catch her breath. She's so stupid. All she does is make this worse. She doesn't know which one of those kids is getting pulled out of bed at night and it makes her want to explode. She should have pushed Weaver down the stairs when she had a chance. She should have brought Catra's scabbed head to the police as soon as she saw it. She should have planted herself on the floor of her first-grade classroom fourteen years ago, probably still too late, and refused to move until Ms. Milagros listened to her.

"I messed up," she says, almost as soon as Glimmer answers the phone.

"Okay," Glimmer says. Adora can hear every inch between here and Bright Moon. "What happened?"

"I hit Weaver."

"Jesus, okay, uh - what is she doing here? Are you okay? Is Catra okay?"

"I'm in Thaymor." Adora wants to wipe her face but she'd have to take her arm off of her stomach and if she does she's going to vomit. "I went to the house. She has *kids* again, Glimmer."

"Oh my god," Glimmer says, and her voice is full of the fear Adora doesn't have room for. "Are you still there?"

"They wouldn't come with me." She doesn't know if Glimmer can understand her over the phone. It feels lonelier than she's been in years. "They're still there, Glimmer, I can't take them with me."

Glimmer makes her give the address, says she'll get her mom. Bow's there and he talks to her when Glimmer leaves, asking gentle questions until they make her cry harder.

"I can't leave," she tells him, even though it's stupid because she's useless. It doesn't matter. She can't go back to Bright Moon with them still inside.

"I wouldn't ask you to. Angela's going to fix this, I know she will," Bow says, and Adora rests her forehead on the steering wheel and wants to believe him. *You can't fix this*, Lonnie said, the last time she saw her. *You're not going to fix me*, Catra said yesterday. "Is Catra okay?"

"She's at home," Adora says. "She was sleeping, I didn't want to wake her."

Bow sighs, and she knows why, but he's tactful enough not to say it right now. He tells her a story about a sailing project he did in high school, while Adora tries not to think about how much bigger she is than Weaver, how easy it would be to slam her head into the ground until she couldn't even look at a child anymore.

The sky is starting to pink when Glimmer says that an emergency worker is coming to get the kids and Adora can take a full breath for the first time all night, even when Glimmer says that Angella and Catra had to make a police statement to get DCFS to send someone. "Can you make the drive home?" Glimmer asks. "Do you need us to come get you?"

The drive is a little under two hours with no traffic. Adora's done it dozens of times by now, and it's her fault that she's here besides. "I can do it," she says, "don't worry."

Her phone pings. "I ordered you coffee," Glimmer says, "so you don't pass the fuck out on the freeway. If you don't pick it up they

have to toss it."

Adora says she'll get it, but she doesn't move after she hangs up the phone. She keeps watching the window that she saw Catra's face in when she came home, that she always checked when the carpool dropped her off after practice. The curtains don't move, but she watches like there's anything she can do if they *do* move.

Adora stays as the sun rises, she stays when the car pulls up, and she doesn't start the ignition until a woman in a suit jacket loads two little girls and their backpacks into her car. Weaver's face is in the window, and part of Adora hopes she sees her and knows that Adora's not hiding anymore.

Chapter End Notes

Fic title from Praying by Kesha.

Thank you for reading ❤️

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra wakes up to her phone ringing and Adora gone. The clock says it's 3:48 and no one has a good reason to be calling her at this hour.

"Sorry to wake you," Glimmer says. Adora finally woke up and realized staying with Catra was insane, or she went looking for someone who wasn't too broken to fuck and fell for them instead, and she doesn't even have the guts to tell Catra herself.

Catra already feels like she'd been hit by a truck, and it's all she can do not to throw the phone against the wall. "Say it."

"Adora went to Thaymor," Glimmer says, "to your old foster home."

Everything shifts off-balance for a second, and now she really feels like she's just woken up. Would Adora go back to Weaver *now?* "What?"

"She says there are kids there."

She probably should be surprised, but she's not. Weaver wouldn't be getting checks for them anymore after they'd all left. She'd made it clear enough that that was why she kept Lonnie around, anyway. She said nobody could pay well enough to make up for Catra. Of course she would foster more if she had the chance.

And of course Adora's too guilty and impulsive to not take off. If Catra ignores that Adora did this behind her back, when Adora said she'd talk to her, she isn't even angry. "Is she okay?"

Glimmer pauses long enough for Catra to know she's considering lying to her. "She sounds pretty upset," Glimmer finally says.

"Bow's talking to her."

If she drove all the way to Thaymor, she must have been panicking at the possibility that Weaver was filming them too. Catra knows exactly what she'll say when she gets back, the same dumb shit she said yesterday about how Catra had been a kid, like that mattered at all. There can't be enough creatures like her for Weaver to have found another one.

Something rattles on Glimmer's end of the line. "My mom says - is it okay if she talks to you? I think she'll explain it better than me."

Catra doesn't want to talk to Angella Fujimura again for the rest of her life, if not longer. Catra tightens her hand on her knee. "Fine."

Fujimura sounds a lot like Emily when she talks, even with the accent. She says the kids are two girls, and Catra shoves away that emotion as hard as possible, because why the fuck would she feel *replaced*, Weaver was throwing her away when she left. Fujimura says DCFS will send someone to get the kids tonight if they tell the police Weaver's name. "I sent them my report before," Fujimura says, "but I'll go in and formally file as a witness, and all you would have to do today is confirm that the material is of you and Stella Weaver, okay?"

That's all Catra has to do, with police staring at her and Fujimura talking about how dumb she looked when she screamed. Fujimura should know better than to think that anyone isn't going to look at her and know what she is. Either they're going to believe her and they'll take turns with all the things they know she'd let them do, or they'll call her a liar and snap cuffs around her wrists and then probably fuck her anyway. She thinks most cops are men. *You'll never take a man like that,* Weaver said once, when Catra's body tried to push her out. *They'll have to kill you instead.*

"Is that something you think you can do?" Fujimura asks, as if she has a choice.

Catra wants her to slow down, like there's any speed that would make this manageable. Adora's in Thaymor, probably in Weaver's house, probably refusing to leave unless she can be someone's white knight at last. If Adora has her teeth into this problem she isn't going to let go, and she already doesn't understand why the idea of talking to the police makes Catra want to die. "Yeah," Catra says, and it sounds like someone else is talking.

"Will you be ready if I pick you up in fifteen minutes, or do you need more time?" Fujimura asks.

Catra looks at the ragged hem of her sweatpants. She's going to have to get dressed and spend the whole time thinking about how easy the clothes will be to get off. She hadn't thought that in a long time. A week ago, that would have been a comfort because it would have been Adora doing it. At least she can steal Adora's shirt so she doesn't have to wear something Weaver stripped, right now. She must say something because Fujimura tells her that she'll see her soon.

Fujimura's car is shiny and clean, like everything that's hers. Probably she pays someone to vacuum the dirt out of the creases. The door closes, and Catra's throat closes too because they're alone now, and the windows are tinted so no one's going to see, and Fujimura can do anything she wants to her.

"Thank you for coming," Fujimura says, gentle accent with a layer of sturdy steel beneath. "I called the station, they're going to be ready for us, and DCFS in Thaymor is going to get an emergency order once the report is in."

"Okay," Catra says. She already feels numb, and she's going to have to try to say what she couldn't yesterday, and she's so tired.

"Please let me know what you need," Fujimura says. Her car is so quiet, with a touchscreen and blue lights that make her skin look like porcelain.

What Catra needs is to be able to go back in time and be born better. She shrugs. "I'm fine."

Fujimura asks if she's folded any new designs, because Catra must have told her that she did origami one time and she remembered that nonsense. "Not recently," Catra says. She gave Adora a winged unicorn before she left for work a couple weeks ago, for her birthday, and Adora had kissed her with a mouth that tasted like coffee, back before Adora scrunched up with stress around her. "Mostly cranes." She hasn't thought about it in days. She doesn't know if she could touch paper right now and not tear it up.

"They say that you get a wish if you fold one thousand of them," Fujimura says. "That's what my husband told me, anyway. His sister made a string of them for our wedding."

Catra probably hasn't done a thousand. Ms. Torres showed her how to fold them in second grade, when she was back in the decompression room for the third day in a row. They're easy to make when she's bored and they're fun to hide around the apartment for Adora to stumble upon.

"I never learned how," Fujimura says. "It's fascinating, though. Adora's shown me pictures of some of your more intricate models, they're so precise. I don't know how you do it."

Heat rises in her cheeks. Just because she's a wreck and has no business pretending to be anything else doesn't mean that Fujimura should make fun of her. "Turns out I have more than one skill set."

Fujimura goes quiet, and Catra's stomach churns but she's in a moving car and she can't leave. Fujimura is still technically Adora's boss and Adora still gives a shit what Fujimura thinks of her.

They're downtown now, close to the big train station, close to the courthouse. If she runs now she might be able to slip onto and then off a train platform in time to get herself out of this fucking

conversation. Adora's freaking out a hundred miles away and Catra can't help her if she gets ground into paste. She doesn't know if she trusts that Adora wants her help.

It's starting to rain, the way it does in the summer, quiet and then heavy all at once. Droplets of water bead on the window and they look dark at the right angle. She's probably getting oil on the glass where her forehead rests because she's just too tired to do anything else.

The car stops at the side of the road, because Catra fucking knew it, Fujimura's going to grab her hair and shove a hand down her clothes and Catra's going to let her because apparently that's what she does. "Catra," Fujimura says, and Catra doesn't even have the energy to flinch about it, "you don't have to do this right now."

Catra keeps her mouth shut, because she's not going to play the game. *Don't make me do this - this doesn't have to happen - if you weren't such an animal maybe I could love you.* Fujimura's going to do whatever she wants and Catra's thirteen years too late to do anything about it. She should've smashed Adora's computer that day, threw it on the ground and kicked until it bled wires.

"Do you want to talk to the police tonight?"

You want this. "Yeah," Catra says, and it's ragged and messy. Her breath hitches hard under her ribs. "I was really hoping to tell some strangers about what a great porn star I was," and she flinches at her own words, because at least a real actor gets paid, decides to be there, and Catra was just a body that could be posed however Weaver wanted it. She's always been too broken to understand what people actually get out of porn, but she had been attractive when she was melted out like wax in the sun, Weaver had said so, Adora had said so. Everyone likes her best when she isn't there.

Fujimura exhales slowly, loud. Catra's still not looking at her. "I apologize," Fujimura says. "I was thinking like an analyst instead of a mother. I made some assumptions."

"They're not going to give a shit," Catra says, and she sounds ridiculous, she sounds like Fujimura's knuckle-deep already, voice dense and wet. It's still dark outside the window, but a bird is starting to chirp, part of the normal day normal people are about to have. "So she made sure everyone knew what kind of brat she had, who *cares*."

Fujimura's quiet for a second, and Catra doesn't want to try to figure out what she's thinking. She considers opening the door and running, but there's no way Fujimura hasn't locked it to keep the wild animal in and if she pushes against a door that won't let her out she's really going to lose it.

"Take a deep breath," Fujimura says, and that's when Catra notices how hard she's fighting to pull in air. When she swallows she can feel the hand on her neck that she knows isn't really there. "Try to follow my breathing."

Catra doesn't know when her knees came up to her chin but she pushes her head into them and it helps the vise around her chest ease, just a little. When Catra's gulping air instead of gasping, Fujimura says, "Do you want me to call someone?"

The only person it has ever been is Adora, but she's either still in Weaver's house or she's in the Whispering Woods. When they had just found each other again, Adora would call her as soon as she got in the car to drive back to Bright Moon, and they could keep talking about nothing until the call dropped in the woods, words soaking into the trees, and Catra would have to wait until Adora reached the Bright Moon city limits and called back. Glimmer said Adora was upset, anyway. She doesn't want to deal with Catra melting down over nothing.

In the corner of her eye Fujimura's hand moves and Catra's shoulders start to slump, drooping as they go limp, but Fujimura

grabs the gearshift instead of her. "I'll take you home."

Catra shakes her head. "I'm going to do it." She doesn't know how to tell Adora that she couldn't. She doesn't want to be someone who can't.

"You don't have to. We can find another way to help those kids, Catra."

Catra curls her fingers against the base of the window. "Just get this over with."

Fujimura takes the lead in the police station, finding the detective she called. Detective Juliet wasn't in a uniform, didn't have cuffs or a gun on her belt. Fujimura talked to her for a while, quiet enough that Catra could watch the colors change out the window.

Fujimura said there were two kids, two girls. The kids are probably fine because they're probably normal, but Catra can't know if Weaver managed to find another one of her. It isn't Weaver's fault if something else feral came into her house, one who wanted what Catra did. She knows Weaver had to do it, so she doesn't know why the thought of it happening to another kid makes her want to crawl in a hole and never come out.

The detective looks at her square in the eyes when Fujimura stops talking, and Catra has to tear hers away. She doesn't tell Catra to speak up when she mumbles her name. The detective has a tablet with something on the screen and Catra doesn't want to look at it, doesn't want to see something half-dead look back. She points at it and asks, "Can you tell me who this child is?"

Maybe if she says no, this will all be over. Maybe she can go to work and laugh with Adora's friends and pretend to be someone normal like she did before. Maybe it wasn't her after all and this is just the worst dream. Maybe Adora will kiss her again and maybe she'll be able to keep what she loves about that, if she says no.

She looks at the screen, where the image pauses. She knows that floor, those walls. She knows those hands and where they are,

she knows that mask. She gags hard enough that the cop shoves a garbage basket into her hands, so she doesn't make a mess on the cushioned chairs and wood table with nowhere to attach handcuffs. It used to take forever to scrub vomit out of the carpet in the dark, with the bottle of cleaning fluid she had to fight not to drink.

She can't say no now even if she wanted to, and she doesn't. She doesn't want a different monster in that room, whether they deserve it or not, whether it's going to happen to them somewhere else anyway or not. One of the only things she clung to for so long was that the other two were normal so Weaver didn't have to melt them into paste, that Catra was the only creature on earth that was awful enough to deserve this, and when she got away it was supposed to be over. Weaver was supposed to rot angry and alone, not recast her and start again.

It's still possible that she didn't. Maybe she loves those girls, maybe they're as safe as Adora was, and the thought isn't as reassuring as it should be.

"I know it's hard," the detective says, "but if you know who this is it would really help us."

Catra nods, swallowing the bile in her mouth. "Me," she says, and it feels like pulling out an organ, ropy guts in her hands.

The detective points at the mask. "Do you know who that is?"

Catra grabs the water bottle in front of her, the one that the woman put there when they came in. It's cold, droplets condensing on the side, and it makes things more real for a moment. She says Weaver's full name the way she learned it before she started school, and she doesn't know if she's said all four syllables since. It's less brittle on her lips than she thought it would be. The detective gives Catra her card, says she wants her to come back another time, and Catra can't imagine there being a future to do that in right now.

When they get back in the car, Fujimura asks if Catra wants to go to her house, big and bright and full of people. If she has to act normal for another minute she's going to explode or melt down or both. "I'm fine," Catra says, "I just want to go home."

While they're driving, Fujimura says, "I know you're in therapy, and your therapist is going to tell you this, but this didn't happen because of anything you did or anything you are. That's what adults tell children that they want to keep quiet."

Catra doesn't bother to reply, because she doesn't want to yell at Adora's boss about how fucking stupid she is. Their car isn't on the lot when Fujimura pulls up, but Catra says, "Adora's home."

"Give her my regards," Fujimura says, and Catra smiles one last time and she half-expects it to break her face.

She closes the door and Melog curls against her ankles and it's nearly seven, nearly time to feed them, but she's fragmenting fast and she doesn't know what to do with that thought so she lets it go. Light comes in through the windows, spilling across the floor, and it was always bright in the basement room when Weaver was there. It had to be, or how was the camera going to see her?

She shuts the closet door and digs into the corner, under the clothes, and it's velvet-dark when she closes her eyes. Her hand braces on the carpeted floor and everything gets further away immediately. When she lies down, knees pulled up, the carpet grates against her cheek and she can disappear like she'd never been there at all.

A door opens, closes. Someone saying her name. Scratches on the closet door. Catra turns her face into the floor, chasing the nothing, but she doesn't go back. She wants to. She doesn't want to be here in this body that doesn't work, dragging Adora down like the heavy stone she's always been.

The closet door opens and Melog worms in immediately, nuzzling her chin. "Catra," Adora's voice says, with an emotion Catra can't

place.

Catra jumps when fingers brush her cheek and they spring back immediately. "I'm sorry," Adora says, breath shuddering, and Catra's anchorless in the emptiness of space, floating, no way to know where her body ends and the dark begins, and what she wanted a minute ago is unbearable now. "I'm sorry."

Melog's purr rumbles through her skull. She finds Adora's hand where she's dropped it to the floor and follows it up to an elbow, bicep, shoulder, and pulls herself up, because right now Adora is the only thing stable enough to put her weight on. She falls in close enough to bleed into Adora now instead, chin locking over the bone in Adora's shoulder. Adora puts her hand solid on the back of her head and Catra's here, on earth again, and she can remember why it's worth it to try to stay.

The next week blurs. Glimmer has Catra's favorite Indian food delivered and Bow drops off baked macaroni and cheese, along with two six-packs of protein drinks. Catra visibly suppresses her snarl when she opens the bag, and Adora doesn't know if it's the bottles or the fact that Bow made them food, but Catra eats it, so. Adora's taking small victories right now.

Adora has the drinks in her bag when she does stickhandling drills at the park, running the ball back and forth. Her ID doesn't work at the athletics gym until August, so she copes with thick dew-soaked grass for now, where her ball gets caught up instead of flowing smoothly over the astroturf of the field. She drills until she aches, then runs a few more. She's slacked, in the past week, and she's running out of time to catch up. If she starts early enough she gets home before Catra wakes up, and then she doesn't have to worry about leaving her alone.

Glimmer and Bow both say she did the right thing by going to Thaymor. Adora knows they're right, even though she's having nightmares about what she thought she found on the floor of the closet when she got back, glassy-eyed and staring. She's had dreams about Catra dying for years, especially after the time she brought her out of the snow, especially after Razz died, especially after they were fifteen and Adora woke up to Catra in her room, groggy, hair wet, eyes fixed on a jump rope Adora hadn't used in forever.

Her face was blank and dead and Adora wrenched the rope out of her hands, threw it deep under the bed, whispered furiously *what is wrong with you,* and Catra blinked at her. *sorry*, she muttered, expression glazed, and she didn't wince when Adora pulled her into bed with her, tugging the covers over, wrapping her arms around her tight like a seat belt. In the morning Catra acted like herself again, and Adora would've thought she'd dreamed it except that she found the rope under her bed when she looked. She threw it away in the outside trash can where it was less likely for anyone else to find it.

So she starts training at five, so she can be home by eight and showered before Catra emerges from the covers. Between the early mornings and the nightmares and the time spent lying awake, she's not really sleeping, but it's okay. Coffee exists, and she can sleep after they get through this, when Weaver's arrested and she can stop seeing her lurking in the corners of their room.

Bow drags them to the science museum with what he swears are guest passes that are about to expire. She understands why Glimmer didn't come. This exhibit is about robots, and Catra sees a coworker there and Adora pretends to understand while Bow and this girl talk about actuators for ten solid minutes until Catra drifts off to something else. Adora didn't know Catra had read so much about artificial intelligence. It's nice to hear her talk, even if Adora feels like she's missing vital background information on whatever machine learning is.

The family playing with the modular bot toys in the corner has three kids and Adora doesn't watch them because she's not a creep, but every time the youngest girl chirps something about the robot she's making, Adora's stomach clenches tighter. She's so self-centered she can't even enjoy something that's supposed to be fun and that Bow definitely lied about spending money on. "Anyone who says this thing would pass the Turing test doesn't understand what it is," Catra says, and Adora agrees, because she'd agree with anything Catra says with that look of furrowed indignation on her face.

"Hey," Catra says in the last room, while Bow and the woman she now knows is named Entrapta have a spirited debate about power sources or something. "Are you having fun?"

"Yeah," Adora says. Maybe it's because of how their week has been, but she feels almost drunk on how normal the last hour has been, even though she's never been to this museum or heard about half of the stuff in it or met Entrapta before. She could almost pretend nothing had happened, that she isn't going to call the police station later to try to find out if they've arrested Weaver yet. She doesn't know what's taking so long, when they had Catra in front of them saying it was her. She doesn't know if DCFS is going to give the kids back. She doesn't know if she got them moved from someplace bad to someplace worse, if they're in danger right now and Adora's here listening to tinny chiptune when the robotic arm picks up the right block.

"*Hey,*" Catra says, and her voice has a different tone this time. "So you're not having a blast with the engineering squad over there, that's fine. There's weird body shit in this museum too. Or we could go home."

Adora glances quickly at the guard, but they either didn't notice Catra cursing or don't care. "I don't mind," she says. "It's nice to learn new things. It's just hard to focus."

Catra looks at her, and sees right through her like she always does. "Yeah." She laces an arm through Adora's and there's no

reason why that makes her face flush, like she's thirteen and pretending that she isn't in love with her best friend.

Catra leads her through the museum until they get to a space in a corner, draped with mesh, bucket of foam baseballs on the floor. "Pitch 'em," she says. "You did softball, it's the same shit."

"This is a family museum," Adora says, while she blinks hard. "You're going to get us kicked out."

A month ago, Catra might have made a joke about how she doesn't behave, because she was starting to do stuff like that, but she doesn't now. Adora doesn't know if she could have taken it if Catra had. "Get throwing before security gets here, then."

There's a camera that records the pitch and analyzes it, and normally Adora would at least be curious about that, but now she just throws and throws until the balls aren't being spat back fast enough. Her shoulders flame from the stick drills she did this morning, and she throws the next ball hard enough for the muscle to spasm. When she massages them later, Adora can blame the soreness and tightness on the work they've done. The pain burns away the stress, and Adora's sure Darla wouldn't love that, but it works.

She can't read Catra's expression when she looks back at her. Catra never played a sport, never seemed to want to. Lonnie wanted to do soccer in middle school but Weaver said she couldn't afford two teams, so Catra never would have been able to play anyway. Catra was always throwing stuff when they were kids, though, and she must have remembered where this was for a reason. Adora holds out a ball. "Do you want a turn?"

Catra snorts. "And show you up, Castillo? I don't know if your reputation could take it."

Adora is the undisputed arm wrestling champion of the Rebellion, there's no chance that Catra's lean flexibility would give her a more accurate or stronger pitch, and Adora's about to say that

when she sees herself on the screen. Catra's standing an extra step away, just outside of frame. She looks fine. She looked fine plenty of times when she wasn't.

"Sorry," Bow says, popping around the corner with Entrapta trailing behind. "I didn't mean to lose you guys. I know we got boring."

"It's fine," Catra says. "Just had to burn off some jock energy. You know Adora's bad at standing around."

She even sounds normal. Maybe Adora's making stuff up, reading too far into it, determined for someone else to feel as trapped as she does. Bow's saying he didn't even know this was here, and Catra's flicking the museum map they were given at the entrance that Adora doesn't think anyone but Catra reads, and she should be enjoying this reprieve before she goes back to the apartment where they fought, where she found Catra motionless on the floor after leaving her alone, where she pushed her down on the bed and took whatever she wanted even though her girlfriend was running away in her own head-

"Earth to Adora," Catra says, casual, but the edges of her eyes are tighter and Adora thought she could read her but she never had, had she? Adora can't believe how *stupid* she is. "Ready to see the rest of this thing?"

Adora turns and throws the foam ball at the target so hard she stumbles forward and Bow catches her even though Catra's a lot closer, because Catra doesn't want to be in front of a goddamn camera, and if Adora knew where the little lens was she'd smash it and figure out how to pay for it later.

"Wow, you're strong," Entrapta says, eyes wide and excited, and Adora's breathing rougher than the exercise really justifies. There's a boy staring at her from across the exhibit, and of course kids are scared of her, they can see how dangerous she is. Adora jumps off the colored floor in front of the mesh like it burns. She doesn't have any words in her right now, just a bundle of fury and

guilt and the need to tear something apart, and she's not sure whether she hates herself or Weaver worse right now. She's not sure that there's any real difference.

Catra's face pinches, stressed, and Adora's making it that way because she can't let Catra be happy for five minutes. Catra's hand reaches for her and Adora runs before she can break things more than she already has.

She hasn't been to this museum before, and she didn't memorize the map like Catra did, but she runs and runs until she finds her way outside. She can see the parking lot, and as she gets closer she can see Catra leaning on the door of their car, looking at her phone. Adora's phone is always set to vibrate, and now that she's not running anymore she registers the buzz on her hip.

She answers and says, "Hi, I'm sorry."

"Don't know where you were going without your driver, princess," Catra says, and she sounds like she's making a joke but her face looks the same as it did when Adora was running away from her, face tense, eyes a little too wide. Her free arm is wrapped around her stomach.

Adora's shoes scrape on the ground. She's so tired. Catra's voice in her ear is a lifeline. "I'm sorry," she says again. She doesn't know what else to say.

As soon as Catra sees her walking up, she paints over her face with a smile. "Come now, m'lady, your carriage awaits."

When they're back in the car, Catra lifts Adora's phone out of her hands and taps on it for a moment. Music filters up out of the phone, *we could pack up this house, get out of town,* and it's Adora's playlist that she made when they first started dating and everything was bright and beautiful and she was so *stupid*.

Adora grabs her phone and hits pause hard enough to hurt and doesn't throw her phone out the window. She does have words, now, and they burst out. "Was it all bad?"

"What?"

Catra's hand comes back over to hers and she pulls away, static in her ears getting louder, because that wasn't an answer. "Dating me, before - it wasn't all bad, right?"

"What?" Catra's eyes go wide like surprise, but she's a good liar. "No, no, obviously not, dummy, it was *great,* where are you even getting that?"

Adora locks her hands on her shoulders, digging into the muscle hard. "I was-" *using you*, her brain finishes, and she doesn't want to put the idea that Catra is *used* into the air. "I hurt you, didn't realize you were-"

"Oh my god," Catra says, flush rising on her cheeks. Angry. "Is that what this is about?"

Adora doesn't know why she's expecting Catra to understand how relationships and sex are supposed to work. Who has she had to learn it from but her and Weaver? "I manipulated-"

"Fuck that." Catra's arms are crossed, turned sideways in her seat. "Fuck, Adora, you always have to make everything your fault. You didn't do anything I didn't agree to, remember?"

In a literal sense, yes, Adora was always careful to ask. Sometimes Catra did too. But that makes it worse, in some ways, for Adora to make her ask to be assaulted again. "But it did. Hurt you."

"You don't fucking listen to me at all, do you?" Catra snaps. "I used *you*, you were the one being lied to. This bullshit is all you, I never said you did anything wrong."

"You said it *wasn't that bad*, Catra, that's-"

"And sometimes it was good, there were things that were great, but you didn't hear that part." Catra's face is going red, fists

clenched. "You only hear the shit you want to hear, because you know best, right?"

Adora can't feel her face, can't think. "You were dissociating. That's - it was the same as-"

"I didn't want her!" Catra shouts. It echoes a little in the car. Catra jerks the door open and slams it behind her hard enough to rattle Adora's ears. She can see Catra outside, back to the door, nails against the base of her neck, pressing in where her shirt will cover the marks. Adora's fault like everything else.

Adora's not panicking, but pacing her breathing still helps. Of course Adora and Weaver's crimes are different. Adora didn't mean to imply that Catra agreed to anything Weaver did. Of course she's mad. Catra isn't moving, and it's getting hot in the car, but Adora's every instinct says to stay put where she has walls around her, enclosed, safe.

Air rushes in when Catra opens the door. "Fuck, don't die in here," she mutters, turning on the car. The air conditioner is loud when it starts.

"I'm sorry." Weaver used to say Adora said it so much that her apologies became worthless, and that's how it feels.

Catra shudders out a breath. "No, I am. That wasn't okay, I don't want to yell at you no matter how mad I am."

"It's my-"

"It's not. It's something I'm working on, okay?"

Adora's throat closes up, but it's good this time, like pulling a game through that everyone thought they'd already lost. "Thank you," Adora remembers to say.

Catra scrubs her hands over her eyes. "Don't thank me for failing at not being an asshole."

"Too late." Adora tries to smile and it doesn't work. "I didn't mean to say that you-"

"I know. What I was trying to say was - I ran away from Weaver, right?" Catra swallows and Adora can feel it in her own throat. "If you two were the same, to me, would I be here?"

Adora hopes not. She can't live with the alternative. If she remembers what Catra barely told her, though, Lonnie basically dragged her out that night. "You thought I was going to date someone else if we didn't - didn't do that," she says, mouth dry. "If you only agreed because-"

"I'm an adult, right?" Catra looks at her, face storming. "Do I get to decide anything, or is it all up to you?"

"Of course you do, but-"

"Then stop fucking telling me what happened, I was there same as you. If you want to break up, just say so."

Adora doesn't say that she wasn't there, that's the point. It seems like it's been years since then, instead of less than a week. She doesn't remember if they had sex last weekend or not, because it all blurs together now, but it hasn't been long enough that she can't still feel the dopamine flood in her head, the fire under her skin, how she tried to put her love in every movement. And for Catra it had been - she doesn't even know. It looked awful, when Adora saw it and knew what it was. And when she didn't it was worse. The time that she cracked, when she groaned like Adora had slipped a knife in her instead-

"I don't want to break up, I love you," she says, "but I can't - we can't do that stuff anymore and thought you knew why."

"No, I get it," Catra says, in a tone that suggests that she absolutely does not. "I'm sorry I tricked you into it in the first place."

"It's not that. I - I've always wanted whatever you would give me." It feels like stripping a layer of fascia back to show the organs underneath. "But I don't ever want you to feel like you did, after the Plumeria game last year, when-" Adora cuts herself off this time, when she chokes, but from Catra's tight shoulders, she remembers. "Don't try to tell me that was fine because I know it wasn't."

"Yeah," Catra says. She turns her head out the window at the purple and blue pinwheels along the front of the museum, turning in the breeze. She's quiet for so long that Adora isn't sure if she's dissociated again, but then she speaks. "I should have let you explain. I know it freaked you out when I - yeah."

Adora shouldn't have assumed Catra would know. She always assumes Catra knows more than her, and she's usually right.

Catra says, "I should have told you about her." Adora can only see Catra's blue eye, moving slightly as it follows the pinwheels. The nails of her right hand are digging into her other forearm. "You deserved to know what you were getting into with me."

Adora doesn't want to do this again. "No, I-"

"She didn't do it to anyone else," Catra says abruptly. "You can stop worrying about that."

"Catra," Adora says, chest aching, "we can't know that. People like her don't just stop."

Catra rolls her head back, looking at the fuzzy roof of the car. She pulls her feet up on the driver's seat, careful not to bump the horn. She looks so much like their last conversation in this car that Adora almost doesn't want to know what she's going to say. "It was because of me, because I was-" She chokes. "Wasn't normal. That's why I should've told you."

"She was lying about that," Adora says. She wants to tell Catra all the things she wanted to tell the girls in her old bedroom. "That's not how it works, that's not why that happens. You were a kid."

Catra puts her arms up on her knees, resting her head on them to look out the driver's window. Her hair is shaggy, not quite covering her neck. "Rotten fucking brat, yeah."

Adora remembers when they were around seven, in flashes - racing on the playground, reading to each other for homework, playing princess battle with Lonnie. The year before Razz died, when Adora came back from visitation with her stomach tight because Razz forgot she existed, Catra always knew and always distracted her. It had been obvious in the video that it wasn't the first assault, but Adora's terrified to ask when it started and find out exactly how long Adora refused to see her.

"I loved that kid," Adora says. She's quieter than she means to be, but Catra twitches, so she probably heard. She doesn't reply, and Adora's not sure what's churning in her head, so she reaches for anything else.

"Did Glimmer tell you that I punched Weaver?" Adora feels like an idiot immediately, as Catra goes stiff.

Catra turns her head back, face unreadable. "What?"

"When I went to the house."

"I mean, obviously, but what? Why?"

"Because I hate her," Adora says, and it's that simple and that complicated. "She wanted me to come *back*, she was saying the same kind of thing she always did, and - I wanted her to stop. So I punched her."

Something sparks past the shock in Catra's eyes. "I hit her with your old field hockey stick, one time. A little before I left."

Adora shouldn't smile. "Yeah?"

"Yeah." Catra shrugs, as well as she can in this position. "I was, uh, I was in your room, and your stick was there."

Adora's rage flares again, and this time it doesn't feel dangerous. It feels like the anger will burn away everything she didn't do. "Hope that hurt her," Adora says.

Catra's face shutters. "Not enough," she says, jaw tight.

Adora thinks about how close she'd had Weaver to the stairs, how easy it would have been to plunge her down them. "I wanted to kill her, when I was there."

"Me too." It spills out of Catra like a boil lanced. Her shoulders ease a little. "All the fucking time, I wanted to kill her, and I never did."

"Fuck that bitch," Adora says.

Catra laughs, squeaky and bubbling and hers, and it's a gift. "Oh my god, Adora, *language*, what example are you setting?"

"Guess you're a bad influence," Adora says, and Catra laughs again. It feels like when she made that playlist, when the new thing between them was so fragile and scary and beautiful. It feels like they can start over. "Thank you," Adora says. "For talking to me. It helps."

"Yeah," Catra says, voice soft, "it helps."

They end up going back in the museum, and the body section is a lot emptier except for the giant heart kids are running laps through, and they stay away from that when Catra asks Adora to explain biomechanics again. When they see Bow back in the sports science exhibit, Catra tells him that if he cooks her another casserole she'll throw it away, dish and all. He still looks like his birthday's come early.

Chapter End Notes

Song referenced is Pretty Places by Aly & AJ.

Thanks for reading!

Chapter 3

Adora is so sure Weaver's going to be arrested any minute now, and Catra doesn't know how she doesn't get it. Adora was there when the officer at school put cuffs on her wrists, when the principal said *think about your choices* before suspending her, when Milagros came to tell them both to shut up. But Fujimura's friend at the station got the girls' worker to move them, so now Adora thinks the cops are going to give a shit. Catra's not that naive.

They called her the next day, asking her to come in and tell them more. She told Adora she had to do something for work and she went to the station and she sat in the car outside for almost twenty minutes, telling her idiot body to move, and then she spent another thirty in the same interview room with the same detective that Fujimura liked. She couldn't stop thinking about the camera set up next to them, red light blinking. Weaver's camera couldn't have had a light like that or she would have seen it. The detective can play it later and watch Catra's stupid blank face when she asked *where would you like to start?*

Detective Juliet asked a hundred questions and Catra managed to answer a handful of them. She can't explain the kinds of things that Weaver did, because she can't put it into words even if she could force those words out of her mouth. The detective asks what she remembers from when it started and she can't say *shadows held me down, everything zapped and crackled and burned, the monster died.* For most of the questions she stares at the table like the dumb thing Weaver always said she was until the detective moves on.

The detective said she could bring someone next time, and her brain coiled in on the phrase. She couldn't do it again. She could barely do it this time. She only came so she could tell herself she wasn't a total failure, but she is. *We can call you an advocate*, the detective said, like Catra needs another person looped into the

parade. She leaves and she has to try twice before her shaking hand can get the key in the ignition.

When Emily asks if she's had to talk to the police, Catra says that she tried and Emily gives her the same pamphlet the cops did. She hates the name. The idea of going to see a *victim advocate* makes her want to puke or punch a wall or both. The police want her back again, and Adora's still upset that Weaver hasn't been arrested yet and Catra doesn't know how to make her understand that she isn't going to be. Everyone who meets Catra sees why Weaver was right to break her.

When Adora texts her that she has to do a police interview after training and Catra isn't allowed to come, she texts three hearts back and the pit in her stomach deepens. Adora keeps getting tangled in her loose wires, and she'll keep charging into the mess until Catra gives the cops enough for them to realize how pointless this is. Maybe someone who's trained to help people who have actually been wronged will be able to get this over with sooner.

She get the pamphlet from where she hid it behind the toilet. She hangs up on the first ring the first time she tries, and again after someone answers, and when they call back she shoves the phone in the crack in the sofa and fights to breathe. Adora's doing this. If Catra needs her goddamn hand held to do the same, the least she can do is make a phone call. When she finally dials again, she tells the woman on the other end that she's scheduling for her girlfriend.

At the Alliance, Netossa is friendly but professional, like Emily, and Catra's hackles come back down quickly. She asks a lot of the same questions at the beginning about what Catra does for fun and where she works, but she writes the answers down in tight, loopy handwriting on her form so at least it doesn't feel like bullshit. After Netossa writes down what Adora's going to school for, she says, "When you feel comfortable, I'm ready to hear about what brings you here today."

Catra practiced this, in her head, and it really shouldn't be hard to say out loud without a camera staring at her. *My former foster mother fucked me and recorded it.* The words don't come when she needs them. She should have brought something to tear, but probably the other *victims* don't need it. She grips one wrist with the other under the table, tight, nails denting the skin, and they're getting long enough for it to almost help.

"My foster mom had sex," she says, and feels stupid because she already fucked up what she was going to say. "With me. And a camera. When I wasn't, uh, old enough."

Netossa nods. "Your referral said you talked to an Detective Valenti?" And they move on, and Netossa doesn't say any of the words Catra had worried she would say on the way over. She doesn't ask why Catra didn't complain about Weaver before, or know that she was filming, or fight instead of lying there. She doesn't ask what kind of creature Catra had to be for this to happen.

"Have you ever been tested for sexually transmitted diseases?" Netossa asks, and everything freezes. Catra hadn't - that had never occurred to her. She isn't so stupid that she doesn't know how those work, but that couldn't be possible, it couldn't be, because if Weaver made her sick then she probably made Adora sick because she didn't tell her-

"Catra?"

Her t-shirt isn't warm enough for how cold it is here. She shakes her head, and the rest of her shakes too. Weaver didn't need to sign a permission slip for the part of health class when the teacher talked about the ways sex could mutilate or kill them, and Catra chose to ignore it, because back then she couldn't even acknowledge in her head what was happening. There's no way her enemy of a body will see a gun and not shoot her with it. Or shoot Adora with it. She can already feel it, bubbling and dark in her blood, Weaver waiting to kill her again.

Netossa's chair creaks as she leans forward. "I'm going to start by saying that I know that the possibility scares a lot of people, but I want you to know that you're low risk, especially for anything serious. With you and your foster parent being cisgender women, if she was the only person, you're low risk." With her fucking luck it doesn't matter. "Do you have any symptoms that you're worried about being part of an STD, like pain or discharge?"

She's puddling, inside, melting out, but she pinches her forearm under the table so she can stay alert long enough to finish this. Her stomach has ached as long as she remembers, and she doesn't know if it was better before Weaver shoved poison in her. She doesn't want to be a baby, whining, too stupid to know what's happening to her. "No," she says.

"You can still get tested if you want. If you do have an STD, most of them can be treated with antibiotics, okay? They're typically very manageable."

Typically. Catra nods, like a bobblehead doll, dumb and useless.

"When was the last time you saw a doctor?" Netossa asks. "For anything."

The school sent her and Lonnie home the second week of freshman year with letters saying that they were overdue for the mandated physicals. Weaver booked their appointments back-to-back and they were both in the room when the nurse asked Catra if she felt hopeless, felt like a failure, felt bad about herself. "Thoughts that you would be better off dead?" the nurse asked and Catra shook her head like all the rest. They were there when the nurse asked if she'd ever had a head injury and Catra told her no, lie acrid on her tongue.

The doctor sent them out of the room long enough to roll her clothes back and scan his eyes over her body, prod his gloved hands over her breasts, tell her to move her legs apart, and she was quiet and empty like she's supposed to be. Weaver hadn't touched her for over a week before the appointment, to let the

bruises go away, and she could feel her gaze eating her away all through dinner. Catra was always hungry, but she left as much food on the plate as she could stand, so she'd have less to throw up later.

"For high school," Catra tells Netossa, and she sounds far away. "Six years ago?"

Netossa scribbles something in her notes. "You would benefit from a full physical, then. I can help you get an appointment with someone who's had Alliance training, if you would be interested in that. They could collect samples for testing at that appointment."

That should be easy. Adora has a physical every year, always has, and she's always fine. She needs to do it, because if she's made Adora sick she has to fix it. Adults see the doctor all the time. It doesn't matter that she'd have to be bare in front of a stranger - what is she trying to hide, any idiot could've seen all of that already with Weaver fucking her besides. For all she knows the doctor will have watched it already. It's ridiculous to pretend that she has any dignity to lose. She'll go and maybe if the doctor touches her it'll hurt less that Adora won't.

Netossa pushes the tissue box on the table towards her, and when Catra touches her face in confusion it's wet, and the skin grows warm under her fingers because she's breaking down about something people do all the time. "This is hard for a lot of people," Netossa says.

Catra pushes the goddamn tissue box away, because she's not a fucking baby, she isn't going to do this right now. She checks the dumb box on Netossa's dumb form to request the appointment, and the poison in her gut pools.

They schedule it for a week later. Adora doesn't know to ask, so Catra doesn't have to lie about it. There's no reason to scare her before Catra knows for sure that she's at risk. Besides, Catra keeps waking up on the wrong side of their bed, Adora's indent left on Catra's side where she must have moved when Catra came

to her in her sleep. Adora isn't going to be more willing to touch her if she knows what she could have.

Weaver hadn't chased her when she left, but she can't stop thinking that she sees her in crowds, on the sidewalk. She hasn't felt like this since moving to Bright Moon. She's driving to work when she remembers that the car is technically in Weaver's name, and could she use it to find them? *Lying whore*, Weaver would say, *you never told them what you wanted to do, did you? Adora hasn't thrown you away yet, so I know you didn't tell her.*

She turns the static on the radio up but it doesn't drown out the murmuring at the edge of her mind. It helps to be back at work, even though Sean acts weird when they're on the same shift. She spends her breaks with Entrapta, who brings sandwiches cut into a dozen pieces and always offers Catra one. Entrapta never asks what's wrong with her.

Netossa says that Dr. Kamiya has done medical evaluations for the Alliance for years. Catra ignores when Netossa suggests that she bring someone, because the only person she would ever bring is Adora. In the waiting room, she has to leave the whole family history section blank, except for *substance use.* She gets nearly to the end, when she has to list an emergency contact, and she stops. When she shut down at work they called Adora. She leaves that blank too.

The exam room is bright, and she scrunches her toes in her shoes when she thinks about having to lie down on the table, splayed out like a frog ready to be dissected. At least the nurse told her to sit on the chair. The nurse has long black hair, like Weaver did, but it's pulled back in a ponytail. Catra's hair isn't long enough to do that yet.

"I have some questions I ask everybody, okay?" She talks like Netossa does. The Alliance must train them to talk that way. "Are you in a relationship right now?"

"No." It's true in all the ways the nurse probably cares about.

The nurse looks down at the paperwork. Her chest hurts and they haven't even started. "Have you ever been in a relationship where you were threatened or hurt or afraid?"

Her ears buzz. This doesn't fucking matter, it's not - she doesn't want to have to figure out if her and Weaver counted as a *relationship*-

"I'm sorry," the nurse says, and Catra can't see her well enough to tell if she means it. "I have to ask everyone. Should I just put yes?"

She thinks she shrugs. That's what she wants to do. Her muscles seem to have mostly stopped listening.

"Are your friends or family aware you have been hurt?"

She's on the sidewalk outside before her nails on the back of her neck snap her back. She sits down and it doesn't help her catch her breath. She stomps her foot into the ground, but her shoe cushions it and she presses her free knuckles into the hot edge of the curb instead, rough surface digging in. She hopes she didn't do something embarrassing in there.

She should go home, hold Melog and pretend that she deserves that much soft on her skin. She should go back to the exam room with the crinkly paper on the table and let the doctor strip her, pry her open, cover her mouth so they don't have to listen to her whining. She should get in the car and drive into a highway median fast enough to obliterate the crime scene she lives in.

She takes out her phone, hovers over the only number she's called in weeks. She tries to play out the conversation in her head, telling Adora where she is, telling her that she panicked and ran before the doctor even came in. She doesn't even know what she wants Adora to say back. *Pathetic little thing, you're just useless, aren't you?*

That's not what Adora would say. Adora would fuss and fret and try to pretend she isn't hurt that Catra didn't talk to her about this

before she got there. She would tell Catra that she'd help, and she'd say it all from too far away.

As soon as Catra puts down her phone, someone sits down a few feet away and she jerks like the rustle of fabric on concrete is a gunshot. It's not the nurse who was talking to her. This one has brown skin like her, subtle stripes on her green scrub top. "Do you need help?" she asks.

Catra shakes her head and looks for her earbuds in her bag. If she looks busy enough maybe this woman will go away, and maybe Catra will get the time to figure out what the fuck she's going to do.

"Heidi's new, she should have told you that everything's optional. Someone coming for you?"

She nods. The earbud cords are tangled. Sometimes she likes teasing them apart, following the lines of the wires until they reach the end, but now she needs a way to make this woman shut up and go away.

"You can wait inside if you want," the nurse says. "Maybe reschedule your appointment."

Catra swallows. "Testing," she says. "That's all I need."

"STDs?"

Nod.

"We can do that today," the nurse says. "Just blood and a swab. You can do the swab yourself, if you want. It's quick. Could even be over before your ride gets here."

Her stomach aches, deep and sore. Even if they're not having sex anymore, Catra still bleeds. If her blood is poison, Adora deserves to know.

"I'm not taking anything off," she says, arms crossed over her stomach.

She doesn't have to. Another nurse types something on the computer while her nurse she talked to outside sticks a needle in her arm and Catra tries not to wonder if her mom felt the prick every time she did the same. They tell her where to rub the swabs they give her and let her take them into the attached bathroom, with a door that locks. They say they'll call her when they get the results. "You did great," the nurse says, and Catra's polite instead of snapping. At home, she gets the origami paper, a birthday present from Bow, and tries to fold a crocodile while she waits for Adora's practice to be over for the day. She has to imagine the teeth.

She goes back to the police, with Netossa this time, and she manages to say a few assorted words in front of the camera, this time. It's still nowhere near enough, and the detective and her camera won't care she says enough, but she doesn't want to be too fucked up to talk about it. A mechanism jammed in her at some point, maybe when Weaver covered her mouth and said *shut up before I make you*, but Catra's going to force it open if she has to break the rest of herself doing it. Weaver doesn't get to brag while Catra has to sit quiet and limp and tamed, not anymore.

She's on time to pick up Adora after training, and when Adora asks how her day went, she smiles and tells her a story from a month ago about Kyle knocking over an entire display, and Adora can't tell how her skin keeps itching and itching.

The next day, the clinic called to say that Weaver hadn't broken her in any way that showed up on a test. A week after that, she's in the car coming home from work when her phone rings for someone to tell her Weaver's been arrested.

Catra pulls over. The cop is still talking, rattling and artificial in her ear, but she can't follow what he's saying. Chills ripple along her arms, down her spine. She can't even picture what expression

Weaver must have worn when they locked the handcuffs around her wrists. The first time the school cop cuffed Catra and brought her to the office, when she was eleven and collapsing like a dying star, she felt like the cold metal was going to keep getting tighter until it bit through her skin, meat, bones. She yanked on them until her wrists and shoulders screamed as loud as she had, and when she was grounded later Weaver gripped tight over the bruises and told her to get used to it. *Animals get caged*, she'd said.

"Ma'am?"

Catra blinks. "Yeah?"

"Do you understand? Do you have any questions?"

She doesn't understand anything, but explaining it again won't help. "Yeah, uh, no questions."

One of the core things she'd known is that Weaver had to do it. Catra had been the worst kind of creature and Weaver had to blunt those claws before she hurt somebody. Before she hurt Adora. When she was little and stupid enough that she told herself that it wasn't Weaver, Catra begged her not to put her back in the basement room. She said *don't let the monster get me,* and Weaver shoved her in before she said *the only monster here is you*. Catra had been horrible and Adora and her friends only cared because they were a bunch of idiots who didn't understand that if it hadn't been Weaver it would have been someone else.

The cops arrested Weaver. She's in jail. They think she did something *wrong*.

She blinks and she's still in the car. It's darker than it had been. Her phone is vibrating in her hand again, and then Adora's voice is coming faint out of it. She can't really hear her. It's like being in the kitchen and hearing Adora's voice buzzing in Weaver's ear. "Adora," she says.

Adora says something else Catra can't understand and that's when she remembers to lift up the phone.

"-where you are, please tell me you're o-"

"They arrested her," Catra says. "Adora. She's in jail."

Adora makes a sound that she can't make sense of over the phone. "Just now?"

"Someone called a little bit ago." The clock on the radio hasn't worked for months, so she checks her phone and - oh. Adora's freaked out because she's almost an hour late. "Sorry. I got distracted."

"Don't worry about it." Adora's voice is cracklier than it should be. "I'm just glad you're okay."

"Adora," Catra says, and she needs to be home right now, she can't stand being this far away. The smile on her face feels too big. "They arrested her."

"Yeah."

"They think she did something wrong."

"Catra," Adora says, and if she wasn't trying not to cry before she is now, "of course she did."

"Adora-"

"No. She did, okay? No one should do what she did, to you or anybody."

She doesn't care if Adora understands. Now Weaver can spend some time alone in a box she can't get out of, and if Catra's lucky she'll go crazy in there.

Glimmer and Bow are remarkably composed when they come over, though Adora isn't, and Adora must have told them the

dumb thing she said because they all say something like *Weaver was wrong*, but it's fine. Everything's fine, now, because she's gone and maybe everyone else can have normal lives like she'd never existed.

The sparkles dissipate after Adora's friends leave, when Catra picks up a hand to Adora's face to kiss her and Adora pulls her hand down. She's gentle, and she repeats that she doesn't want to break up, but she puts Catra back at the distance Adora wants them to have. Catra finds Melog squirreled under the bed and gets most of herself under there with them, petting their neck and listening to them purr. Melog doesn't care what lies she's told, what rot stays on her hands.

They already have nail clippers at home, but the pharmacy aisle has a dozen other things that aren't nail polish but aren't recognizable either.

Glimmer picks up something in a round tub. "This one's my favorite, do you think she'll like lavender or lime better?"

"Lime," Adora says. "What is it?"

"It's a hand scrub," Glimmer says, dropping it in the shopping basket. "It's for before her nails, it'll make her hands really soft."

Adora's stomach flips, thinking about Catra's hands. "Maybe that's a bad idea."

"It's great, it's one of the best parts of a manicure. Well, that and moisturizing, but. She can do it herself if she doesn't want that much contact."

What's become obvious is that what Catra thinks she wants isn't the problem. She's always stepping closer than she really needs

to, holding any contact they have for longer than normal. She touched Adora's face a week ago, when she was visibly giddy that Weaver was in jail, and Adora's not so bad at reading her that she couldn't see her disappointment when Adora made her stop. Adora and her goddamn libido is the problem. Adora wants Catra all the time, and she makes Catra stop before she finds out if she can make herself stop, because Catra isn't going to.

Glimmer throws a nail file in her basket. "Don't try to tell me you have this, I've met you."

Adora pulls it out, cheeks warm. "We're lesbians, Glimmer, we know that much."

Until Catra punctured a girl's eye, Weaver never bothered to cut her nails, and afterwards Catra came back from most groundings with fingers clipped to the quick. That tapered off as they got older, and Catra started digging her nails into her skin after her mom died. By the time she got to high school she had pink scratches on her sides more often than not. After they started having sex she kept them short, but Adora's seen them growing longer and longer since they stopped, and she's scared Catra's going to draw blood again as everything gets more stressful than it already is.

"You two could use a spa day anyway," Glimmer said, when Adora told her in the parking lot of the police station, after her second interview. She offered to come over, manicure them both, but Adora doesn't know how Catra would feel about Glimmer touching her hands. She's still nervous about it, but maybe it'll help. Darla says she should be investing in their relationship right now.

"This moisturizer's really good," Glimmer says. "You can borrow some of my polish too, if you think she'd like it."

They never talked about crushes or anything when they were teenagers, but Catra thought this senior was cool when they were fifteen. She had an undercut and a leather jacket and dark

chipped nails and Adora hated her. "Black maybe? Or maybe nothing. I don't know, we don't do this kind of stuff."

"I'll give you some options. Bow might have black, he tried polish in high school but stopped when he got into archery. Chipped like a bitch." Glimmer's eyebrows jump at something she sees behind Adora. She pulls a different jar off the shelf. "They have mousse and stuff too, you know. For hair. You could do a whole look, if she would be into that."

Catra always liked when Adora petted through her hair, but she wore the hat all the time until it grew out enough to be even. It stippled Adora's fingers like rain, at first, but now it was long enough to brush a little. Catra leaves the medicine cabinet open so the mirror faces the wall. She still wears hats that she doesn't need sometimes. "She doesn't like her hair," Adora says.

"Oh," Glimmer says, excitement quieting. "I remember now, you said not to compliment it when we met her."

There are ads running down the aisle, and no women have short hair in them. "It used to be long, like-" Adora indicates the middle of her back. Weaver never took them to get their hair cut, so it just grew and grew until Adora took scissors to it when her ponytail started to tangle too easily. Catra never cared about her hair being neat. "Pretty long. It was always everywhere, total nightmare to brush."

Glimmer looks at the shelf for a moment, teeth visible over her lip. "I know she was hiding for a little bit. Is that why she cut it?"

It's not Adora's story to tell. Catra's never going to tell it. Glimmer can keep a secret and, by now, she knows that anything about Weaver is a secret. "Weaver did, the night she left. It, uh, it looked like it hurt, when I saw it."

Glimmer winces hard. "Jesus." She slips the product back on the shelf. "Should've punched her twice."

Adora looks at what she has in the basket and feels like an idiot, trying to mend a shipwreck with a piece of tape. She hadn't even meant to hit her. It would've been just as useless even if she had. Glimmer squeezes her shoulder, tugging to turn her around, and Adora drops the basket to hug her. She needs it to breathe, right then.

"It's not going to rewrite what happened," Glimmer says, quiet against her collarbone, "but it doesn't have to."

"There's so much, Glimmer." Adora shifts to wipe her face before she messes up Glimmer's hair, and Glimmer's arms lock tighter around her back. "It's too much."

"And you'll get through it. You'll both get through it."

"I'm sorry," Adora says, pulling back. "I don't mean to dump stuff on you."

Glimmer waves her hand, like she thinks Adora can't see the circles under her eyes. "Don't worry about me. I've got Bow, and my mom, and I know where to get more help if I need it, okay?" Glimmer rubs Adora's arm. "I'm your friend, I want to be here for you. Both of you."

Glimmer gives the same excuse when she pays, and Adora understands. It's really for Catra, anyway, and Adora's not too proud to turn down anything that will help her. Glimmer keeps the supplies with her, so they don't spoil the surprise, and she hugs Adora again before she drops her off at home. "She's lucky to have you," Glimmer says, and Adora doesn't explain why that's wrong.

Catra's quiet after she gets home, spiraled tight. Adora tries not to spiral too. Catra beelines to the kitchen to start slamming pans, and Adora goes to the bedroom where she can read about nail-painting techniques. She's never tried, and her clumsy fingers are definitely going to mess it up, and she's going to have to scrub it all off and this article says polish remover is bad for skin so-

Catra's head appears in the doorway. "Dinner," she says, before disappearing again.

In the kitchen, Adora stares down the pot of spaghetti on the stove, like she can will it to be inside her already, and when she thinks she's going to puke she grabs a protein bar out of the cabinet. She's running through them faster than she used to, but they used to be a smaller part of her diet, before.

"You've got to be fucking kidding," Catra says when she sits down. She's eyeing the bar with the same disgust Adora feels, though she knows it's for a different reason.

The wrapper crinkles in Adora's hand. She knows what her nutrition targets are today, and if she doesn't eat something she's going to be under. Adora ignores the childish desire to throw the bar on the floor. "So I guess work went well."

Catra's face twists, like Adora knew it would. "Don't try to change the subject, and *don't* patronize me. I'm talking about you and how you're fucking allergic to dinner apparently."

"I ate with Glim-"

"Sure," Catra says, "lie."

Adora puts the still-wrapped bar down. If she doesn't eat it she's going to be under target and she might start dropping weight and her stats might go down. If she picks it up again she might puke.

"Maybe if you actually ate food you'd be less hungry for your fucking *face,*" Catra snaps. Her knuckles are fisted tight around her fork.

Adora makes an effort to stop chewing the inside of her lip. "I don't want to fight with you."

Catra shoves her plate at Adora. The noodles slide slippery where they half-twist onto her fork. "*Eat*, then," she says, as if it's that

easy, like every degree of tension in the air isn't making that harder.

Adora looks at the fork wrapped in spaghetti, and she doesn't want to. Weaver doesn't get to tell her what to do anymore and neither does Catra. She's sick of being the one who does what she's told.

She stands up, and walks to the bedroom where Melog is curled up in their bed, and maybe Catra's still mad enough that she won't follow, that she'll appreciate a little more time without Adora there, but Catra's steps are coming behind her and Adora's not childish enough to slam the door.

Catra sits next to her on the bed. Frustration still billows off her, heavy as smoke. Adora says, "I said I don't want to fight."

Catra's hands fist on her knees. "I don't either."

Adora pets Melog, rubbing beneath their chin until they purr loud. *Then leave me alone,* she doesn't say.

Catra pulls her feet up on the bed, tucking her legs against her chest. "It freaks me out when you get like this," she says.

Catra, Glimmer, Bow - they're so weird about what Adora does and doesn't eat. They hate when she picks at her food, but they also hate her bars and her shakes, because they only want her to eat what they choose. Adora says, "I meet all my macros, I'm still at the target weight for a striker, I passed my physical. It's not affecting my game, you don't need to worry about-"

"See, it's that fucking shit. This isn't fine, Adora. I don't want to scrape you off the sidewalk again."

That was *one time*, last winter when the cold broke records and the price of gas went up and they had to get the brakes replaced on the car. When they were behind on rent and Catra was picking up every shift she could and they slept huddled together under their blankets and coats to save money on heat, Adora couldn't

buy more powder or bars when she ran out. She was running at school when she passed out and campus security called her emergency contact before they called the hospital. Afterwards, while Catra was yelling at her, all Adora could think about was how grateful she was that they didn't have an ambulance bill to deal with too.

"You know why that happened," Adora says. "You know that's not going to happen again."

Catra lets out a shaky breath. "You didn't use to be like this. It's getting worse."

Adora doesn't know if that's true. She would whiten her knuckles under the table when Weaver served food that was mush and rot in her mouth. She took more plain chicken and plainer rice than anything else, and small portions meant that she wasn't costing more than the state paid for her. When she pocketed bags of chips and fruit cups at lunch, she could pretend she would've eaten them if she wasn't saving them for Catra. When she got to high school, her field hockey coach sent everyone home with a coupon for protein mix and Weaver bought it, because she loved Adora's sports until they took her to Bright Moon, and it meant Adora could put less on her plate. Catra was missing most dinners at that point, so maybe she never noticed.

"I don't know why this makes you so upset," Adora says.

Catra's quiet next to her. Melog fills the space with their purrs, nuzzling their cheek on Adora's hand. Catra says, "Because this shit *kills* people, dummy. Could've killed you already if you'd wiped out on the road."

"I didn't, though, and I already said that wasn't going to happen again."

Catra makes a frustrated sound in her throat, just this side of a growl. "You definitely don't tell your shrink about it," Catra says, "because she'd tell you it's messed up."

Adora stops herself from wrapping her arms over her stomach. "We have plenty of actual problems to talk about."

Catra twitches hard enough to see in her peripheral vision and Adora turns, gut aching from something else this time. "I'm sorry, I didn't mean-"

"I know, stay focused." Catra says, but hurt is still clear on her face, because Adora never says the right thing, never knows how to help. "You don't get out of this conversation that easy."

She's right there, inches that are miles away. Adora says, "I don't know what you want me to say."

"I want you to stop," Catra says, as if it's that simple, like Adora can just decide to shrug off how she feels as easily as she wants to. Maybe if she wasn't so weak useless pointless she could, maybe she could be someone who deserves to be here, instead of chasing and chasing and never being good enough.

"Hey," Catra says, when Adora can't get air in her lungs. Catra peels the sheet up, drapes it over Adora's shoulders and pulls it tight. It isn't as good as real weight. "Breathe."

Adora grabs the ends of the sheet to hold it there. "Sorry," Adora says.

Catra adjusts her grip so the sheet presses down her arms too. "I'm not mad," she says. "Just do the breathing thing."

Adora closes her eyes and tries not to spiral. She has exercises to step through, comforting weight, Catra's breath in her ears. She's supposed to focus on all those things. Instead she says, "I left them," words worming out of her mouth without permission. "I *left* them with her."

Catra makes a small wounded sound. She says, "No, you didn't," which is ridiculous.

"I left *you* there," Adora whispers, like it can stop being true if she's quiet enough. Adora's run through that mistake a million times, too. "It's all I do, I-"

"Nope." Catra's eyes are sharp. "You came back for me, remember?"

"By the time I found you, you were already safe." Adora had a car, she had a bed, she had a box full of bandages, and none of it mattered because she didn't use any of it. Adora got out and she barely looked back. "I didn't help at all."

Catra's face spasms. She nudges Adora's shoulder, gentle through the fabric, guiding her to lie down, tucking the sheet so it stays snug. "You helped me *all the time*," Catra says, eye contact steady, and she has to just be trying to make Adora feel better because anything else is impossible. "If your brain's saying something else it's an idiot."

Sorry is the only word that fits in Adora's mouth right now, and it's not enough so she keeps it behind her teeth where it belongs. Catra breathes with her and it's like a taste of how it was, when Adora didn't know how badly she'd failed.

"So the food stuff is you punishing yourself for not having superpowers or some shit?" Catra asks, when Adora's heart is mostly even again.

Adora wishes she knew. "It's not just that."

Catra's eyes search her face, and Adora doesn't know what she's finding because she doesn't know what's there. "Then what is it?"

"It's - I don't know. Textures are bad, tastes are bad. It's too hard sometimes." The sheets smell like Catra's conditioner, peach and sweet. "The shakes and stuff, I can manage that. Everything else makes me sick."

Catra hesitates. "Do you need to see a doctor?"

Adora shakes her head. She's so tired. She's been tired for days. "I just passed my physical, I'm fine."

Catra says, "Gotta argue with that one again," but she sounds fond instead of angry this time. Her hand traces circles on the mattress under her and Adora imagines she can feel it on her back, in a world where she can be trusted with such a gift.

"Promise you'll tell your therapist," Catra says, sounding at least as tired as Adora is.

Adora would give her anything in her power, right now. If Catra put a pie in front of her she would choke it down, fruit bursting like blisters between her teeth. She nods, and the tension drains out of Catra with every loop she draws. When they go back to the table, Adora meets her calorie goal in a way she can stomach, and Catra's foot bumps hers too many times to be accidental.

A few days later, she takes out all the things she bought with Glimmer, and Catra doesn't laugh at her so Adora mispronounces *ambiance* as badly as she can to make her laugh. The world doesn't explode when Adora holds her hand, even though she's too shaky to do a good job with the black polish that Bow loaned them. Catra watches what she's doing with eyes like deep pools, and when Adora's done she grips her hand back hard enough to hurt. "I look like I fingerpainted, it's hideous," Catra says, but her voice is too full for her to mean it. Adora cleans it up as carefully as she can, even though she can't hold the q-tip steady.

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Things are supposed to be better, once Weaver's in jail. Adora doesn't tell Catra what she talks to her therapist about, but there are more dishes in the sink and fewer protein bar wrappers in the garbage can over time. She throws herself into field hockey as intensely as she always has, but she's less spent than she had been last year, even once classes start, even with everything. She apologizes less.

Catra doesn't tell her what she talks about with Emily either. They have a system for starting sessions now, practicing all the stuff she's supposed to do when she gets angry or starts to go numb. Listening to her breath and feeling the chair under her and stuff like that. It's not that different from what Adora does when she's panicking, so maybe it works.

She picks at her too-short nails, and the lack of edge makes her do another deep breath. It's silly, because she's never actually hurt someone older than twelve with them, but it still felt like having a weapon. She can't even find a rough spot to scrape and scrape at her skin, like she did when she was a kid. Adora sanded them smooth, not missing an inch.

It was worth it, to have Adora holding her hand and focusing on something of Catra's like it's important, like maybe her body isn't a ragged grimy mess that would make anybody sick. It made Catra feel like she was dying, in a good way. It's one of the things about sex that she misses and she's never going to have again. Adora pulls away all the other times Catra gets within the invisible circle Adora's built for herself.

"My foster mother assaulted me," she says, trying on the words. They're clinical, weird-shaped in her mouth.

Emily waits for her to talk. She does that a lot. Sometimes it feels like looking at a test when she wasn't in school to learn anything on it, but on a day like today it's a blank page she can fill with whatever she wants.

"Legally, anyway." Weaver was officially arrested for *aggravated indecent assault,* among other things, but Catra doesn't think she'll ever be able to spit that out. Netossa said the state's understanding of rape is a hundred years out of date.

"How does it feel to say that?"

Emily has a lot of fidgets on her table. She always has cardboard rolls out too, and paper. Catra spent half of their second session trying to teach Emily how to fold lotus flowers, petals blooming. Catra picks up the ball full of something soft and moldable.

"Stupid." That's not one of the emotions on the chart Emily has, but she doesn't have a better word. "Like I'm stupid."

"What do you mean?"

She likes that Emily asks. Adora always thinks she knows. The ball squeezes between her hands, crushing flat. "Just - it's pathetic."

"Why?"

Because Weaver barely had to try, she just existed and Catra gave up. "I - stopped fighting, after a while. I just." She digs her useless smooth nails into the ball's surface. "Let her do whatever."

"That's what you learned to do, to get through it," Emily says. "You were a child who was trying to survive."

She's so sick of hearing about that whimpering little shit. After Weaver was arrested, they got an envelope from the house with pictures of Adora - bright blonde kid with a gap-toothed smile at sports games and school events and birthdays. Weaver could only document Catra as something else. The police showed her a bunch of frozen video frames, she remembers what that brat

looked like well enough. Ugly little bug-eyed thing. Sometimes when Catra glimpses herself in the mirror, she can still see the fragments of the monster in her face. "Whatever," she says, so she doesn't have to talk about it anymore. "It's dumb to still be fucked up about it."

"Why?"

Because it's over. Because she's safe now, arguably. Because *stop whining, if you were a good kid we could both be asleep right now.* "Because."

"I think it makes a lot of sense that this continues to affect you," Emily says. If Catra could look at her face instead of the squishing ball, maybe she'd know if she's fucking with her. Catra doesn't look on purpose. "I would have different but no less serious concerns if it seemed like it wasn't."

She had to move a shift to meet with the prosecutor last week, right when the store needed her for turnover after Halloween. *Rosetti's not your lawyer*, Netossa told her before they went in. *She's going to make her argument the way she thinks will work best, and she might ask questions you don't like.* She's getting better at talking about it, but she still froze up when Rosetti asked *how often did the assaults took place*, because she doesn't know and she should, shouldn't she? If it was actually traumatic the way people keep saying, she'd have each time seared in her mind, right? Half of what she remembers has to have been dreams anyway.

Netossa told Rosetti she had to take a break, and they walked down the hall and bought a cold soda from the vending machine to hold even though Catra didn't think she was dissociating actually, and she went back and told the prosecutor that she doesn't know. Rosetti nodded, like she thought that's what she would say, and she moved on to other questions that weren't any easier, and at least Netossa brought her bags to puke in.

She just doesn't know when it's going to be *over*. Weaver's in jail, Catra hasn't even seen her in almost two years. It feels like this is her whole life now, between therapy and Netossa and Adora still avoiding her, and when she left it was supposed to be done, but the stupid meat she lives in can't let go of it.

She was waiting for Adora the night after she had to meet the prosecutor, watching television that she didn't have to think about. She leaned her head on the back of the couch and pretended her hand was Adora's, rinsed her fingers through what hair she has, the way she used to love when Adora did it. Her body went dead and limp for no reason anyway. When she blinked, her muscles were leaden and slurred and she'd lost at least twenty minutes. Adora's right not to want to touch her anymore because her body's useless and impossible and she can't do Emily's dumb grounding exercises if she doesn't know when it's going to happen. A voice in her head said *you should be taken out back and shot*.

She's so tired.

"What's going on in there?" Emily asks, voice calm.

"I don't want to be like this anymore." Her dry throat creaks. "I can't keep doing this."

"Are you feeling like you don't want to be alive?"

It sounds like what Ms. Torres asked her in second grade, a couple months after she got locked out in the snow, when she kept exploding at everything and there wasn't a consequence on earth that could keep her calm. That day, she slammed her hands on the wall until Ms. Torres pinned her arms across her chest so she couldn't do anything but cry and think about how much she wanted to be a splat on the pavement. When Ms. Torres finally let go of her, she said *I know you don't like it, but we have to keep you safe,* and Catra said *what if I don't want to be safe*, and Ms. Torres asked *are you thinking about doing something that isn't safe?*

When Catra said *what if I am, what if I'm gonna get a bus to squish me*, they had to go to the counselor who rolled her eyes and asked in that stupid-kid voice *do you even know what that means? does that get you attention at home?* Weaver never mentioned it, and she wouldn't have missed an opportunity to remind Catra how dead she should be.

If she tells Emily how often she thinks about it, she'll send her to a hospital, but Catra doesn't need that. She's stayed alive for years when she didn't want to. Every time Catra's thoughts have gotten more specific, more real, she thinks about Adora having to move because she can't afford the apartment by herself, and needing to throw away Catra's clothes, and how guilty Adora will feel. She'll think Catra died to get away from her. Catra isn't going to make the same mistake Adora's mom did, leaving her to be alone. For Adora, she's willing to do harder things than live.

"I'm not gonna *do* anything."

"Do you know what you would do, if you did want to end your life?"

She has at least three options in this room alone. "No."

She can see Emily write something in her peripheral vision. "Can you agree to let someone know if that changes?"

She nods. "I'm just tired."

"I know," Emily says. "This is a lot, and it isn't fair, but I promise you won't feel like this forever."

Catra picks up Adora after practice, and they sit together, making fun of Melog. "I missed you today," Adora says, from the distance she keeps now, and Catra echoes it back like it means anything.

A few days later they go to the park, because Adora's a freak who's been outside all week and that's still not enough for her. Catra's not going to complain about getting to watch her run. It's getting cooler as fall deepens. Bright Moon doesn't get as cold as

Thaymor in the winter, so they're at least a month off from snow, but Catra stole one of Adora's sweatshirts on their way out the door.

It's her fucking day off, and Kyle is still calling her about override codes like he doesn't have a manager, because somehow he's more scared of Denise than he is of Catra. She does everything she can to correct that, but she's barely hung up before her ringtone plays again. "So fucking help me, Kyle, if you call me again I'm framing you for theft."

"Hey, Catra. Uh, if it's a bad time I can-?"

"Scorpia?" She hasn't tried to contact Catra for almost a year. Catra knows Scorpia doesn't want to talk to her, so she can't imagine why she's calling. She doesn't sound like herself. "What's wrong?"

Scorpia's quiet for a moment. "Are you okay?"

She hasn't been okay for the entire time Scorpia has known her. She opens her mouth to say she's fine and she can't. Instead she says, "Sorry, someone's bugging me with shit that isn't my problem, what's going on?"

"I just got a call," Scorpia says, "from someone at the prosecutor's office? They said they want to talk to me about, uh, the night you came to my place."

Adora's still running, arms shifting by her sides. She's rounding the loop, headed back towards Catra now. The sweat on Catra's neck is clammy. She didn't tell Rosetti about Scorpia. She said she ran away and lived with Adora, she didn't want Scorpia part of this at all. Scorpia saved her when she didn't owe her shit and now she's getting dragged into this mess too, now she's going to *know*.

"I was trying to give you space to live your life up there, you know, but that call freaked me out. I know you didn't go to the police at the time, because you and your, uh, your friend were

super clear about them not getting involved, and we never had a conversation about it but I know-"

Catra cuts her off, because she needs a minute before she learns what Scorpia's figured out. "Are you going to? Talk to them?"

"Do you want me to? I don't want to break your trust, but I really think you deserve better than for your, uh, for that bitch to get away with what she did. And - Wildcat, that night was especially bad but I know it hadn't been good for a long time, if it was ever good, and I wanted to talk to you before I-"

"What did Lonnie tell you?" Catra doesn't want the answer. "That night. What did she say?"

"Not a lot." Scorpia's probably pacing, the way she does when she's stressed. When Catra lived with her, Catra used to make popcorn when she was like that, and when Scorpia was done pacing and venting she would sit and watch people on the internet play video games while they ate it together. Catra doesn't love her the way she loves Adora, but Scorpia made things simple and she misses that sometimes. "When your friend called she said I had to come right away, she said you were pretty messed up. She came with you all the way to my apartment, do you remember that? You were really out of it."

She mostly remembers flashes when lights went past the car window. She thinks Lonnie sounded angry at some point. It all blurs together. Once she got in Scorpia's car, her body sort of quit. "Kinda," she says.

"Anyway, she made sure you had a pillow and your bag and everything. She said at least twice that you'd be in danger if I called the police, which is part of why I'm concerned, because how do they even know about it? Did that bitch find you? Are you and Adora still good? If you ever need anything, you know I'm here, right?"

Catra's throat is full of glass. She's had to talk about it so many times now, to strangers sometimes, but Scorpia inexplicably likes Catra and she doesn't know yet. Maybe she'd regret kissing Catra as much as Adora does. Maybe, if they ever see each other again, she won't fold Catra into one of the second firmest and safest hugs she's ever had.

"Catra." Scorpia takes a heavy breath. "If you went back to her instead of-"

"No," she says. The idea of that is like a static shock. "I haven't seen her since then, I'm still in Bright Moon."

"Sorry," Scorpia says. "I'm not trying to pry, I don't want to make you get into anything you don't want to get into, I'm just really worried about you."

Catra from six months ago might have said *that sounds like a you problem* and hung up. The anger still rises, the *leave me alone, back off, don't make me strip off my skin for you right now.* Catra searches along the trail until she finds Adora. She'll smell like sunscreen and sweat, later.

She could tell Scorpia that Weaver is in trouble for things Scorpia already knows about. She could tell her not to talk to Rosetti at all. They might not need what Scorpia has to say to lock up Weaver and throw away the key. But Catra's not supposed to have to keep lying about this. She doesn't want to lie to Scorpia anymore.

She steps far enough from the tree that its shadows don't fall on her. "Did Lonnie tell you that our foster mother, um, assaulted me?"

"I mean, Catra, you were beat all to hell and I already knew she was hitting you, it didn't take a genius to-"

"The other way."

Scorpia clears her throat. "No, but. I tried to give you the bed when we got to my place and your friend, she lost it, said if I tried to, um, take advantage of you she'd do something pretty colorful, so I, uh. I worried. About that. I mean, the stuff you hear about foster care, you know?"

Catra didn't know. Maybe no one had ever had the guts to tell her. "Well, she did. And she - she had a camera. When she did it before. A bunch of times before."

Netossa said they're still looking, but they've found over a hundred so far. If she recorded every time, there has to be way more than that. All they found in Weaver's house was a room in the basement, freshly painted, carpet clean of blood. There was no mask, no video files. What's been found has turned up the same way Adora saw it, pulled off some creep's computer after they try to buy a kid online or something. Catra doesn't know what to do with the fact that all the evidence they have was first appreciated by someone she's never met, someone who jerked off to hearing her whimper, someone who probably pictures themselves fucking her when they close their eyes.

Scorpia's breath shudders. "Oh."

Catra sits, so she can trace her hand through the grass. "Yeah. Someone found it and - and that's why they want to talk to you. Sorry."

"Don't apologize, that - fuck, Catra, that's terrible. That never should've - well. A lot of stuff never should've happened to you, but that too. I'm so sorry." Scorpia's voice is more crackly than Catra can blame on the connection. "What can I do? Anything you need."

The voice in Catra's head still says *she's lying, now she knows how much she can do to you, you know she's always wanted to.* She slept on Scorpia's couch for months, she tried to kiss her again once she could stand up and Scorpia told her *not yet.* On

the phone, Scorpia sounds like she's about to cry if she isn't already.

"Just talk to them," Catra says. "Tell them everything you know. I want her to-"

She wants Weaver to die in all the ways Catra always wanted to kill her, arteries spraying, bones glinting white through her skin, face smashed until no one would recognize her. She wants to have Weaver's blood on her hands for a change, to be able to claw her open and find the things Weaver took away from her. She wants to make her squeak as she dies and smear her own gore on her face and tell her *you always make such a fucking mess*.

"I know, Wildcat," Scorpia says, even though Catra never finished her sentence. "Me too."

Adora slows as she gets closer, and Catra must be doing a bad job at keeping her face looking normal. She's so tired of pretending. "I gotta go," she chokes. "I - thank you. For all of it."

"Anytime," Scorpia says. "Can I call you again sometime, can we work out a time for me to visit? You can say no if you just need space right now."

Catra doesn't know why she's crying. Adora sits across from her, puts her hand down in the grass between them. *I love you*, Adora mouths, and she looks a little alarmed when Catra cries harder. "I want you to come," she manages to say. "I want to see you."

"Then I'm there, you know I am." Scorpia was there when nobody else was, she saw her when everyone else wanted to believe what Catra's mouth and face and rage said instead, and she knows what she is and she still wants to see her. She might hug her and everything. "Take care of yourself, okay?"

"You too," Catra says, and then she hangs up. She tries, anyway. She can't see the screen that well. Sobs tear out of her chest like a storm, and she's not quiet and anyone who walks past is going to stare at her and this is what she's become, now, someone who

just has wailing meltdowns in public, *fucking embarrassment, we'd all be so much happier if you were dead.* She's so tired. She just wants everything to stop.

Adora takes the phone from her, hangs up. "Here," she says, hand out, and Catra grabs it and pulls herself close enough to Adora to stop exploding. She clings and clings and tries not to drown in whatever emotion is splashing up over her head. It feels like - it feels like when she thought Adora had left and was never coming back, which doesn't make any sense because she hasn't abandoned her yet, because she lets Catra have the hug she doesn't deserve. Adora's other hand drifts to brush away tears and Catra hasn't earned it but she gets it anyway and that hurts for no reason.

"Why," she says, and she doesn't know how to finish that sentence or why she started it. There are so many questions that there's nowhere to start.

"I don't know," Adora says, because for all the times that Adora doesn't listen, sometimes she hears what Catra doesn't even mean to ask. Adora's free hand strokes tentative down her back and her legs are probably cramping because she didn't stretch but Catra can't stop. "I don't know."

In November, Adora's playing the regional semifinals against FZU, one of the top teams in the division, and they're behind in the third quarter. FZU is trying to run the ball back over the center line after getting the ball off Jules, and the player coming up drives right up to Adora, like they aren't scared of her at all. Adora dodges to block them but they're going too fast and when she tries to adjust, she steps wrong on her right ankle.

It's not like the last time, when she turned it and kept playing and it didn't hurt until she tried to stand up hours later and pain shot up her leg. She feels it now, white-hot and nauseating, but the girl's getting past her and they're already losing, so she runs after her and focuses on keeping her ankle from collapsing each time it thuds on the ground.

She barely makes it a minute before Coach Hope pulls her off the field. "Is your ankle compromised?" she asks, eyebrows knitted. "Your form is irregular."

"No," Adora says, heart pounding from more than exertion. The team runs the ball back up the field and Adora watches past Coach, skin itching at standing here useless. "I can keep playing."

Coach doesn't have a wide expressive range, but she doesn't look convinced. "Sit down and take off your gear."

As soon as Coach touches her ankle, her fingers feel too cold, and it's obvious from the jump in her jaw that she can feel that it's swelling. She tells Mermista to help Adora get inside to the trainers. "When you've been treated, wait in my office," she says, voice stern.

Mermista tries to pull Adora's arm over her shoulder to support her but Adora shrugs her off. "I'm fine," she says, "this is ridiculous."

"Sure, hotshot," Mermista says, all but rolling her eyes. "See if I catch you when you fucking beef it halfway there."

Adora tries to do the breathing exercises she's supposed to. It's hard when adrenaline still thrums through her veins. She was grounded from a game freshman year when she hid that her wrist was bruised. She already missed the end of last season while her ankle was recovering, and now she's ruined it again by doing nothing. Her brace is still in her locker and for a crazy moment she thinks about putting it on and running back out, like if Coach can see that she can stand she'll let her play again. Her ankle

stabs with every step but if she limps Coach will know she was right to make her sit out.

"Something's up with you," Mermista says. "That girl with the weird eyes break up with you?"

"Catra and I are fine." Adora's voice is rougher than she wants it to be. The pain in her ankle is starting to drop as it swells, but she knows it's temporary. The trainers are probably going to yell at her too, not that that even matters when she's going to get expelled from school.

"Okay," Mermista says. Adora has to brace on the wall to get the door open, but she manages. "So, what, she stopped putting out?"

Adora turns back to her, and she doesn't even know what she was intending to say. *Mind your own business,* maybe, or *what's wrong with you,* or *just because your relationship is a disaster doesn't mean mine is,* but her ankle wrenches wrong and collapses out under her. She catches herself on the wall and shoves Mermista away when she tries to keep her from falling. "Shut up," she says.

"Jeez," Mermista says. "That bad, huh?"

Adora grits her teeth at the pain rising through her leg. Theresa is heading over to them, and Adora half-wonders if she'll let Adora skip the ice, this time. The sharpness in her ankle distracts her from how fucked she is and how much she wants to scream at Mermista when it isn't even her fault that Adora wants to kill something. She pulls her phone out of her locker before she goes to wait for Coach, and she has two missed calls from Catra and a text that says *hope you're okay,* with a heart emoji. Adora holds down the power button before she shoves it back in her locker, pulse thudding in her ears.

Mermista comes back down later, after her ankle's iced and wrapped and she's waiting in Coach's office, leg propped up on a

chair. "Sorry if I hit a nerve before, it's just really obvious," Mermista says, leaning in the doorway, and Adora shifts her eyes from where the dim light catches her jawline. "And like, you know Sea Hawk and I are open, and you're hot even when you're absolutely insane, so if you ever wanna hook up let me know."

"I'm good," Adora says, and tries not to think about that. Mermista's attractive, and Adora's seen her in all stages of undress, and she hasn't gone this long without even getting herself off since she figured out how. Every time her brain considers it, she remembers how limp Catra used to go, and how proud she was of that, how it felt like an *accomplishment*.

Mermista shrugs. "You know where to find me. Anyway, good luck in here, the game just ended."

"We lost, right?"

"We can manage to win without you," Mermista says, "if you can even imagine that."

Coach is back a couple minutes after the locker room chatter starts. Adora can hear what she's going to say already. *Pack your belongings and leave. I don't know how many chances you expect to receive.* Adora doesn't realize she's rocking a little in her seat until Coach says, "Settle down, Castillo."

Adora holds herself still and forces air into her lungs and reminds herself that Catra says her store is always hiring. They don't have to be homeless when she gets expelled. It only feels like a death sentence.

"Explain yourself." Coach Hope's voice doesn't have much of a range, but Adora knows her well enough to recognize fury.

"I could still-"

"You could have shredded your ankle badly enough to end your career, give yourself a life-long mobility problem." Coach's cold,

almost monotone voice makes it worse. "Do you think I want to invest in a liability like that?"

Adora swallows, tries to think through all the thoughts screaming *you're going to die.* "It didn't hurt."

"Why do you think that helps your case? If you can't be trusted to know when you've injured something, you're at greater risk of permanent damage. Again, explain to me why I am putting time and money and effort into someone who's not going to survive the rest of the season, let alone next year."

The sweat under her shirt isn't just from the game. She doesn't know if it's better to look as desperate as she feels or not. She's willing to be manipulative if it means she doesn't have to leave school. "I'm sorry," she says. "I didn't want to have to sit out the rest of the-"

"The truth comes out." Coach looks at her unblinking. Adora knits her lips together, because talking isn't helping. "I was lenient with you last year, because I believed you then. Maybe that was a mistake. I saw you tonight, Castillo, and you're far worse at lying than you think you are. If your ego is so strong that you think you're the only one who can score, you don't have a place here."

"That's not it," Adora says, heart in her throat. Begging's never really helped before, but the instinct hasn't gone away. "It's not - I know I'm part of a team. I'll do better. Give me extra gym hours or - anything. Please don't make me leave BMU."

Coach Hope bends her eyebrows slightly. "That's not up to me, Castillo. Removal from the athletics program isn't expulsion."

"But I can't stay without the money." Adora swallows so she doesn't start crying. Stupid, stupid. When Adora came back to Bright Moon after looking for Catra, freshman year, she told Coach that she'd had a family emergency. Enough people had been delayed coming back to campus, and Coach just told her to not let

it happen again. Adora's tried so hard since she got here and she'd mostly managed not to screw up, but here she is.

Coach's face softens, just at the edges. "I'm protecting you, Adora. I can't let you continue to collect injuries under my watch. We'd be having the same conversation if you were having medical problems. We can talk to your parents and financial aid to learn your options."

This isn't happening. It can't be happening. Catra and Bow and Glimmer are probably waiting for her outside and if they figured out that she's hurt they're probably furious too. She thinks wildly that this will make it easier to get time off for the trial.

Coach is pulling out a folder. "Let's call your family now, they can help you get home tonight. We can plan on another time for you to get your gear."

And Catra has been doing so much better lately. She's going to therapy, she's trying to communicate better. She's more than earned a few breakdowns, and while they're scary when Adora doesn't expect them, she's doing better than she had been. Adora had finally stopped worrying about her being at home by herself, and now Adora's going to dump a ton more stress on her.

Adora can't spiral right now. Coach is already disappointed enough without Adora getting hysterical on top of it. The ice on her leg is too cold, chill creeping up her leg, and it feels like it's going to keep going until all of her is frozen and trapped. She was supposed to go to school so they wouldn't have to worry about money ever again, and now she's wasted the last two years and she's going to have to pretend she isn't an absolute failure every day for the rest of her life, and Weaver was right, she couldn't handle it.

Coach drops the phone back on the receiver. "What number do you have for your mother," she says, "this one is out of service."

"My former," she means to say *guardian* but she can't force it out of her mouth, "contact is unavailable, I don't - I think my girlfriend's outside, she'll help me."

Coach pauses. "If you're having a personal situation right now, Adora, you know you could have informed me, and perhaps we could have prevented things from escalating to this point."

It doesn't even matter now because Coach is going to get rid of her. "Sorry," she says. "Can I go now?"

Adora doesn't bother turning on her phone when she grabs her bag, and luckily everyone else is in the showers and there's no one to talk to her. When she opens the door to the hallway, Catra's pacing by the pad Adora had to scan to get in, except her card isn't going to work anymore. Catra's eyes dart to her ankle right away. "How bad is it?"

"Coach booted me," Adora says. Something's swollen up under her ribs, the way she feels when she's going to cry, but she's still numb. She's going to wake up and this didn't happen.

Catra looks up, brows creasing, and she's so beautiful and so good. Adora doesn't deserve her. "For what's left of the season?"

"Permanently." Adora swallows the gravel in her throat.

Catra's face goes tight and Adora has to look away from her. "There's no way that - can they do that? They can't kick you out because you got hurt, how is that not illegal, what the *fuck.*"

Adora needs to explain. She's exhausted and tacky with sweat and she has to get out of here before the rest of the team comes. "Can we talk about it at home?"

Catra puts her hand on her face, brushing away the tear Adora hadn't known was there. "Yeah, princess." Catra's voice is soft. "It's going to be okay," she says, the phrase Adora swore to stop saying because it wasn't true. "We're going to be fine no matter what, I promise."

Adora turns on her phone in the car and she has missed calls from Glimmer and Bow too, and texts from half the team already. Frosta sent her a gif of two bears hugging. She drops it back in her bag, something wrenching in her chest.

When they get home, Catra comes out to the living room with her shaker bottle and she feels like such a failure, because she'd been trying to rely on this less, because she knows Catra hates it, because she's too stupid to be able to eat cheaper things and she's cost so much money with her *bullshit* and she's already ready to vomit before even tasting it.

Catra looks at her, tucking one of the pieces of hair that escaped her ponytail back behind her ear. "I know you don't want to," she says, "but you played tonight. You have to have something."

Adora swallows. "I fucked up. I fucked up so bad."

"It's not your fault you got hurt," Catra says, and Adora doesn't know how to correct her. Catra's going to be so angry if she learns how Adora's ruined everything.

Adora asks if they can watch that flower show they'd been talking about, and she can't even pay enough attention to pretend she's enjoying it. She fails to stop thinking about how much the internet and electricity and rent cost for her to sit here. Catra keeps putting the cup in her hands until most of it is gone, and Adora only chokes on it twice. Catra tells her she's doing a good job and she wonders if this is how Catra felt when Adora fed her chips that her melted hands couldn't pick up.

After Catra takes the cup away, she rests her head on the back of the couch while they watch, and looking down at her used to make Adora feel every extra inch of height she has in a good way, but now it just makes her feel like a bumbling giant that's too stupid to know when it's crushing something.

Catra brushes her chin and Adora lets her lip go. "We're going to figure something out," Catra says again.

"I'm sorry," Adora says, feeling huge and dumb and expensive. The least she could fucking do is calm down so she doesn't keep stressing out her girlfriend who's already dealing with enough but she can't. She wishes her ankle wasn't wrapped so she could stretch it the way it hurts, now that it doesn't matter when it heals.

Catra grabs her hand for a moment, squeezes. "I'm coming back," she says, but she doesn't go farther than her work bag. She pulls out a handful of crinkling plastic. She opens a wrapper and picks up Adora's hand to put the candy inside. "Taste it."

"What?"

"It's a grounding thing. For freaking out. You gotta focus on it instead of the other shit."

Adora eyes the ball, rolling slightly on her palm. Candy's too sweet for her, sticky, and this looks like the kind that lingers unless she bites it hard enough to make her teeth ache. Her breath is still coming too fast under her ribs, an attack waiting to happen, and it's Catra's idea, so she shoves it in her mouth.

It's so sour immediately that she has to move it on her tongue so it doesn't burn. Catra grins at her face. "Sorry," she says, "that's the whole point. Emily said it's the strongest kind she can find."

It's intense, a blast of noise in silence. Adora's mouth gets impossibly dryer, and the candy doesn't feel like it's getting any smaller, and instead of gagging Adora spits it back into her hand.

Catra's smile droops a little. "Well," she says. "Not sure why I thought my thing would work for you."

"It did," Adora says automatically, and then she realizes she's not lying. The ache on her tongue replaces what she wanted to do to her ankle, and the panic rattling between her shoulders has dropped down to a buzz. "Way too strong for me, but it was like a shock, in a good way. This helps you?"

Catra nods, tense. She gestures at Adora's jittery leg, and Adora nods because she needs *something* to hold her down. She puts a hand on Adora's knee and presses her weight down, anchoring. "When I get - when I start, you know."

Adora covers Catra's hand with her empty one. Her words tangle up. She's glad that Catra's working with her therapist, learning how to manage her symptoms. Catra's smarter than Adora, always has been. No one gives her credit for it, but she read a prep book for the diploma equivalency exam last year and passed the test two months later because she can learn lightning-quick when she's able to eat and sleep and breathe. She doesn't have to work three times as hard to grasp a concept or see a pattern, like Adora does. Of course Catra's better at this too. She's *glad*, Catra's suffered more than enough. Adora just wishes she didn't keep holding her back.

Catra uses the wrapper to pluck the candy out of Adora's hand. She says, "We'll talk to the school, we'll figure something out. People say stuff feels better in the morning, right?"

Catra wouldn't say that if Adora wasn't lying to her. "I didn't get kicked out because I turned my ankle," Adora says, and her knee jumps under Catra's palm. "Coach was mad because I tried to keep playing anyway."

Catra stills, and it's going to be just like when Adora passed out running last winter. Catra hit the turn signal hard enough to rattle and said *what the fuck is wrong with you*, and when Adora said that she forgot to eat lunch Catra snarled her lips and turned up the static on the radio until it hurt. She wasn't scared of Catra, but she still couldn't breathe around the tension in the air. Catra left her in the car when she went into the store, and she slammed the car door after she threw a tub of powder in the backseat. She ripped a box open and shoved a protein bar in her hands and said *eat before I fucking lose it*, and Adora put the sand in her mouth until it was gone.

Catra lets out a long breath, doesn't pull back. "Are you hurt bad?"

Adora shakes her head, pulse thudding in her ears. Catra puts her hand on the side of Adora's face, skin cool. Adora manages not to push it away or turn to kiss it. "I love you," Catra says. "I know you're trying."

Adora feels all her muscles slump at once, and Catra takes the weight and Adora isn't strong enough to pull back. "I love you too," Adora says, and she can't move her head from where it's fallen on Catra's shoulder. At least she's too exhausted to worry about whether she'll do anything else. They watch people shape huge flower arrangements, colors flowing and textures shifting, and Catra holds on to her like a life jacket keeping her afloat.

Student services calls a few days later, after she drops off the paperwork about where she lives, her rent, how much Catra makes. They tell her that they have money for former foster youth that no one's claimed for the year yet. They say the financial aid will cover her tuition, and something collapses off her shoulders so hard she sits down where she was standing, on the floor in the middle of the living room. She barely hears them talking about food banks and heating assistance, but they want her to come in and sign paperwork for it all so it doesn't matter if she remembers.

When she texts Catra at work with the good news, she gets a cluster of hearts back. *see? they know better than to let you go*, Catra says, and Adora knows how the smile in her voice would sound.

Chapter End Notes

> If you are experiencing suicidal thoughts, chronic or acute, do not try to manage them on your own. Like Catra, I've had them since I was a child, and it's very tempting to say that you've made it this far so you'll continue to be fine, but it's dangerous and I am only here now because I got help at a

critical time. Please get whatever help you can if you're in this situation, you do not have to deal with this on your own. I know this is a topic that's been present in maybe every chapter of this series so far, but I wanted to say that at least once.

On a dramatically different note, they're watching The Big Flower Fight in the last scene, I recommend it if you find chill competition shows like GBBO distracting and relaxing but want something not food-focused.

Chapter 5

"She's not going to talk to us," Catra says, clicking her signal to pass this idiot going forty on the highway through the Whispering Woods. The glare off the snow on the trees makes her squint.

Adora's voice is steely firm next to her. She's vibrating, and has been for the last twenty minutes of the drive. "I'll make her talk to us."

"You're under twenty-one," Bow says from the backseat. He's on winter break too, and Adora thought he could help with the file when they get it. "She's still your social worker, you were never formally discharged from foster care."

"Oh, but she's so *busy.*" Milagros said that every time Catra saw her. *I don't have long, we'll make this quick, some kids are really suffering and I can't help them because I'm stuck here with you.*

From the frustrated sound Adora makes, she remembers that too. Adora leans her head on the window. "I'll break her door down," she says.

Catra still hasn't decided if she's even going to speak to Milagros, if they see her. She does want to read her file, because Netossa said it would be part of the evidence at trial. She said it'll be easier if Catra knows everything that might come up. Adora says she has enough to say all on her own, if Catra doesn't want to.

Catra's never liked talking to Milagros. It was usually because Milagros was there to close out her report and tell Catra to stop causing trouble. She doesn't want to think about her anymore, not when she has to drive at the same time and she has people she likes in the car. "Adora said you got to see yours," she says to Bow.

"Yep. Dads gave it to me when I turned eighteen."

Catra tries to imagine what Bow, already adopted by the age Catra entered foster care, could've possibly had in a DCFS file. "How was it?"

"Complicated." He shrugs in the backseat. "I mean none of it was fun, but some of it was rewarding. My dads had always said my birth mom was really young and when I was angry or frustrated with them, and wishing that I hadn't been adopted, that felt like a lie they made up to stop me from looking. It wasn't, she was seventeen, and seeing her signature on stuff, kinda shaky, made me feel better about her not wanting any contact. She was young and scared and had to do something she probably shouldn't have had to do. It helped me understand a lot of things."

Catra isn't sure what her file could help her understand - none of the questions that rattle in the back of her head have anything to do with it. She thinks it's going to mostly be notes from school, and people telling Milagros to come check on her, and Camila's missed visits.

They only had a handful of visits, before she disappeared, and they had to have a supervision worker there every time. Catra remembers doing a lot of sulking, wedging into the space between the couch and the wall. Her mom was always apologizing. *This isn't how I wanted things to go*, she would say. *I would give anything to do things different, baby.* And then Catra would usually tell her to stop calling her that and her mom would just stare at her with that face she didn't want to figure out.

I miss you, Camila used to say, and then the next week Catra would have to wait with the worker until they gave up and called Weaver to come get her, and in the car Weaver would say *how long did you think she was going to put up with you?* Camila would be back on the next scheduled visit or the one after that, all sorries and excuses, and Catra would tuck back into the small space behind the couch so she didn't scream at her mom in front of the worker writing down every move they made, and Catra would find something of Lonnie's to break when she got home.

"I'm glad that helped you," she tells Bow, and hopes that she sounds remotely supportive.

"Maybe yours will too," Bow says, because he lives in a world where good things happen.

The receptionist tells them that Milagros won't be back for an hour. "I told you," Catra says, and the bitterness in her voice surprises her. There's only two chairs, but Adora can't sit still anyway, pacing lines along the wall under the poster that says something that she thinks is Spanish. Sometimes people at the store come up to her, spilling words she doesn't understand and looking desperate at her, and she tries to say what Entrapta told her means *I'm sorry, I don't speak Spanish*. Entrapta actually remembers something from high school language class. Catra doesn't think she even passed it. None of the customers can know that, but they always look disappointed in her anyway.

Adora's grandmother spoke a little, she told Catra a long time ago, not that she had time to teach Adora anything. Catra doesn't know if Camila did, or if she also had to spread the apologetic smile on her face when she told people that she couldn't help them. The folder they're here to get probably won't tell her that, not that it matters because she doesn't care if she never thinks Camila's name again for the rest of her life. There are pamphlets about becoming a foster parent on the table and Catra doesn't feel bad tearing one up.

Bow starts telling her about a new daily puzzle he's found, a crossword, and he's got enough background knowledge that he's good at those, so he helps fill in where she doesn't know the answer. She knows he's trying to distract her and it mostly works. She's not sure when it stopped bothering her that Bow can read her as easily as he does.

When Bow goes looking for a bathroom, Adora flops into his chair. "Sorry," she says, "I'm just so wound up. How are you doing?"

When Emily asks that question, she's supposed to listen to her body instead of saying she's fine. Clench in her gut, neck too vulnerable, something wriggling under her skin. She doesn't want to listen to her body anymore. "Doing okay," she says, "but maybe I shouldn't talk to her."

"You can do whatever you want," Adora says, nudging her foot, which reminds her that she doesn't have the first idea what to say if Milagros says anything about them being together. She doesn't have to know that they're dating, but they tell most people that they've known each other since they were kids and leave out the details. Milagros knows full well how they know each other.

When they finally get to Milagros' office, and Catra sees the chair where she sat when Milagros said *I'm honestly not sure if you'll ever be able to live independently,* and Milagros smiles at her from behind her desk like she's literally ever wanted to see her, her tongue sticks like she knew it would.

"Catra," Milagros says. She looks both older and younger than Catra remembers. "I'm so happy to see that you're okay, you don't know how worried I was when you disappeared on us."

You weren't, Catra thinks. *You never even once cared about what happened to me.* She doesn't say it. Every inch of her says *shut up, shut up.*

"We're here for her file," Adora says, venom thick in her voice. "The lady out front said you have Catra's copy."

Milagros' smile distorts. "Good morning to you too. Adora, right?"

"Don't start with me," Adora says.

Milagros shifts her eyes away from her, like Adora is that easily dismissed. "Your file is here," she says, putting the folder in Catra's hands. It's so thick, and it probably has the notes from that worker who had to watch her ignore Camila, and the grades from school that got worse and worse, and all the reports that

Milagros complained about having to come visit her about. "If there's anything else I can do to help with the transition out of-"

"You." Catra tries to clear the rust from her throat, force the gears to turn. Adora's next to her, and she can imagine what her hand on her back would feel like. "You left me with her. For so long. You left me."

"Catra," Milagros says, and the irritation is creeping back into her voice. She can barely pretend to give a shit for two minutes. "If you need something from me, just say it. You're not my only appointment today."

"Everyone told you something was wrong, *everyone.*" When Catra clenches her hands on the file, the edges dig in. Catra doesn't even know how many times somebody said something, Adora and Lonnie and Ms. Torres and somebody at the hospital that she doesn't remember meeting, and who knows who else. Sometimes Milagros would show up with her little laptop and *I thought we'd discussed this* and Catra hadn't done anything more than exist, and Milagros never told her who complained. "But you believed her every time. You told me to be grateful and she-"

When Catra's voice dies, Milagros does that sigh she used to do, after Catra yelled or threw something or kicked the wall of the decompression room. "So you *are* behind the allegations against Stella," she says.

Catra realizes, almost distantly, that she's never been angry at Milagros before. Talking to her was always something she tried to wriggle out of without getting in worse trouble, furious at herself or Adora or Lonnie or whoever summoned her. But now when the rage swells up rich and deep, it's for Milagros.

"I was there." Catra's voice is rough against her ears. "It was me, nothing's *alleged*, she did it all, she-" Catra stumbles to get anything out of her mouth. She's said it a few times now. This shouldn't be that hard. She's not even trying to say the hardest part, *production, distribution, prepubescent*-

Something brushes the back of her hand, and she jumps, and it's Adora. "I can see you're upset," Milagros says, and she's doing that overly-calm voice that she's always used when Catra got worked up. "You went through a lot with your mother, and-"

Catra shakes her head, and her stomach clenches. When they had visits and Camila hugged her without asking and Catra shoved her away, Camila never hit her or grabbed her clothes or told her to die. They'd never been alone, so maybe she would have if she'd ever had the chance, but she didn't get one. Weaver doesn't get to hide behind the corpse of her mom.

"-aging out is a really difficult process, even if you," her eyes flick to Adora and Bow, "have support. But you're an adult now and you need to learn to act like one someday."

Catra wants to show her what adults do, make her scream and bleed. *Stop making up stories because you're angry*, Milagros told her once, when she hadn't said a word. Catra slams the folder on the desk and Milagros barely reacts, and Catra wants to do it again harder and louder until she makes the bitch flinch. "That's the only thing you ever cared about, whether I *behaved*."

"I'm aware that you never attached to Stella," Milagros says, "and after your mother that isn't your fault, but you really have no idea how lucky you are, do you?" Milagros has that bite in her voice that makes Catra's mouth want to close, especially when she feels someone behind her. Weaver was always there, when Milagros talked to her at home, laser eyes on her back waiting for her to make a mistake. "Stella loved you, despite your behavior and despite your constant efforts to manipulate everyone around you. My other oppositional kids, they can go through dozens of placements, but you had someone who fought for you."

Of course she did. What if she never found someone else awful enough to hurt the way she wanted?

"I told her so many times that residential care might be best for you and safest for her, but she wouldn't give up on you."

That was Milagros' biggest threat, for years. *If you don't turn it around, you're going to residential. You think you're tough? Kids there have no parents, friends, belongings, nothing. They don't get sisters.* Maybe someone else would have broken her there, and maybe that would have been better. Maybe they wouldn't have filmed it too.

"I'm sure she regrets that now," Milagros says, "with how determined you are to ruin her life."

You're taking everything from me, Weaver hissed in the kitchen, before she dug scissors into the monster's head. *I should have killed you years ago.*

Adora's hands are fisting next to her. Catra can't feel hers to know if they are or not. "You still think I'm lying." Her voice is too loud, echoing odd on her ears. "The only time in my life I'm telling you the truth and you-"

"Catra-"

"Do I need to run the tapes for you? Do you need to-" see a kid held down and sobbing and probably begging Weaver to help her, tiny and disgusting and pathetic, "*fucking watch*-"

"If you can't control yourself I'm going to call security," Milagros says, with that same *stop this tantrum* voice, that *Ms. Weaver's going to be very sad to hear that this happened again* voice.

The chair makes a firm sound when Adora pushes it back down on the ground. Catra feels it under her hands but she doesn't remember when she picked it up. "We're leaving," Adora says. "And we're taking a copy of the file with us."

"As is Catra's right." Something softens around Milagros' mouth. "I really do hope you get the help you need," she says, and Catra knows she doesn't mean therapy with Emily, where someone believes her.

Milagros would be so much happier if she'd repeated back the same *accident misunderstanding my fault my fault my fault* broken record she played for years. Adora's hand still holding the chair down is all that keeps it there. It's been so long since she's wanted to hurt someone else this badly. She wants to break Milagros' arm, tear out her hair, make her gasp as her vision goes gray, tell her to shut up when she screams.

Something honks, and she's outside. She doesn't have blood on her hands, so Milagros is probably still in there, telling herself that she saved the unlovable little beast that Weaver wouldn't let go of. Catra punches the brick wall hard enough to send knives up her arm.

Hands land on her and she bucks them off before she recognizes Adora saying her name. "Catra, stop." Adora's trying to manage her again, trying to control her. She used to do that all the time, when they were kids - get in Catra's angry punching face and say *calm down*, and Catra would hit her too. All anyone ever wants her to do is stop, shut up, be less of a problem. "You're hurting yourself, you have to-"

I have to send you away if you hurt yourself, Milagros told her when she was fifteen and some fucking idiot at school told the counselor that she had a burn on her forearm, after she left dinner in the oven too long and Weaver covered her mouth before she held her arm against the hot glass because she knew she'd scream. Milagros said *I hope this was an accident* and Catra lied until she got to go stare at her textbook and count the minutes until she saw Adora at lunch. Milagros said the same thing after she got caught pulling half-eaten burgers out of the trash, after bleach made her hands stiff and raw, after-

She hits the wall again and the electric pain is familiar, sharp. It feeds the angry tears in her eyes. It feels like being stuck in the same peeling walls again, fire under her skin, and if she hits hard enough something's going to break and she almost hopes it's her.

Something turns her around, back thumping on the wall, head knocking hard enough to see stars. Her right hand smacks the brick and the jolt shoots up to her chest. "Shit," Adora says, and the panic bleeding heavy into her voice makes Catra blink. The grip on her shoulder is gone almost before it processes that it's there. "I didn't mean - oh my god-"

"M'okay," Catra manages. Her breath comes in gasps, quiet as her useless body can make them.

Adora's an arm's length from her, fists opening and closing the way they do when she's freaking out. "Your head-"

"Adora. Stop."

Adora quiets, but she doesn't look any calmer. Catra's knee buckles, and Adora helps her to steady herself on the wall before jerking back like she's been scalded again. Her chest aches almost as badly as her hand does. Adora hovers, too far away to make Catra feel any better. Catra's dying and Adora's right there, still angry, still punishing her.

"M'sorry," Catra says, broken glass on her lips. "*Sorry,* please."

"You're not in trouble, that doesn't happen anymore." Adora's voice is too wet. Someone steps off the curb to give them an even wider berth, because they're in public and they're making a scene, and Catra has never cared about anything less. "Catra, she's not here-"

When Catra reaches she can get to her, pulling herself up to the rescue boat, driving her head into Adora's shoulder where the oxygen she needs lives. *stay*, she thinks, like maybe Adora can hear her. When she was little she used to think they could trade thoughts if they were close enough, back when that idea was a comfort. Adora doesn't stop her. "Bow's coming soon," Adora says quietly. "You can-"

"Don't want Bow," Catra says into her shirt. "Please. I'm sorry."

Adora stops arguing. She molds her hand to the back of Catra's head, the way she used to, even when it was prickly and ugly. They sway a little, a tree in the wind that can bend instead of breaking. Adora doesn't say it's going to be okay but Catra hears the words soothing in her head anyway.

This is what Weaver said was wrong with her, that yawning canyon in her chest where only Adora has ever fit. She said what Catra had really wanted was to fuck her, but Catra's done that, now, and what she needed was *this.* Sometimes sex got her here, and sometimes sex was worth it for other reasons, but never in a million years would she take it over this.

They get back in the car, at some point. They were supposed to meet up with Scorpia afterwards, but Catra ruined it like she does everything. Bow must be driving, because they're moving but Adora's still holding her, hand stroking down her back. She's so tired, and after the third time Adora says *still there?* and Catra croaks out a reply, she lets Catra rest her head on her lap, legs solid under her.

"Is she asleep?" Bow asks, after a long time of silence.

"Think so." Adora's stomach vibrates as she speaks, breathing from her gut like her shrink told her to. "I'm glad, she needs it. Wish I still had the medical kit in here, her hand's going to-" Adora clears her throat. "Going to bruise bad."

There's quiet for a moment. "It's a thick file." Bow's voice.

"Sixteen years," Adora says.

"Is yours like that? I mean, you said you entered the system younger."

"Never seen it, but I doubt it. My social worker just checked in every six months. We saw Ms. Milagros a bunch of other times too, and I know the school sent reports, and my visits weren't supervised until the end, and. Anyway. Thanks for agreeing to help with all of that."

"Of course, anything." Bow clears his throat. "You said you had a lot to say to her, if Catra didn't."

Adora's hand shifts on Catra's back. "Yeah."

"What would you have said?"

"Something similar." Adora lets out a long breath. "I talked, in the beginning. To teachers and stuff. But she told me everything was fine, she said Catra would go somewhere worse if I didn't stop."

"That shouldn't have happened," Bow says. "She should have listened to you."

Catra tries to imagine, for a moment, what it would have been like if things had been different. If, when she was little and Weaver said *her tantrums are so violent* to explain the bruises on her arms, Milagros had taken them both somewhere else. Catra had always told herself she didn't want that, because Weaver said that someone else would tear animal sounds out of her throat, and she wouldn't even have Adora to cling to afterwards. Lonnie's sisters were in different homes and they had the same mom, same last name. Adora wasn't anyone to Catra, technically. Anyone could have separated them, and back then Adora was the reason why she only thought about hanging herself with shoelaces instead of actually doing it.

Fujimura'd had Catra alone in her car, going limp already, and she hadn't even touched her. Scorpia'd had her asleep on her couch for months and she hadn't either. Lonnie could have done anything to her that night, and she helped her get somewhere safe instead. Bow and Glimmer know what she was for Weaver and they've never even tried to get her to do the same for them. If Milagros had brought Catra and Adora to people like that, maybe they would both be normal now. Maybe Catra wouldn't need to touch Adora to be safe, and maybe Adora would actually want to let her.

Adora swallows, and Catra can feel it echo through her. "It wasn't all her fault. I lied a lot too."

"You know I lie to my dads. About, uh, almost everything about my life."

"You have a good reason," Adora says. "Honestly, Bow, I don't know why you feel bad about that. Anyone would lie if they were afraid they'd have to give up their dream."

"But I think that's the worst thing they're going to do." The turn signal clicks. "You were protecting yourself from someone who could do way worse."

"She never hurt *me,*" Adora says, disgust in her voice. "She never even - she was always tearing Catra down, telling her she was an idiot and a wild animal and all this stuff, but she'd say I was smart. Too smart to get scared."

"That's just another way of saying you weren't smart, though. Of course you were scared, you were a kid in a dangerous place."

Adora sighs. "I guess." She plucks at the back of Catra's shirt, light enough that she wouldn't feel it if she was asleep. "I got scared a lot and she never liked it. Said I was accusing her of something, by freaking out. Said I was, uh, being manipulative."

"Adora," Bow says, voice tight, "you get why that's trying to manipulate *you*, right?"

"Yeah." Adora laughs. "I have a therapist and everything." She laughs again, more bitter this time. "She would say that no one was going to love me as much as she did. She said that's why my mother committed suicide, because she couldn't love me enough."

"Fuck," Bow says, but Catra barely hears. It sounds like something Weaver would say, but Catra hadn't heard that. She hadn't even known how Adora's mother died until a few months after Camila did, one afternoon when Catra was ranting about how no one would shut up about her and how much everyone thought her

death fucked her up. *Why would I even care if she killed herself,* Catra had said. *I already know she didn't want me.*

My mom killed herself too, Adora had said, and Catra couldn't imagine anyone choosing to be apart from Adora. When she aches with exhaustion all the way through and the thoughts about what she needs to do to stop it loop endlessly through her head, knowing that Adora would be left behind is one of the only things she has.

"It doesn't matter," Adora says. "She's going to go to prison and she's not going to hurt anyone ever again. And I'm going to file as many complaints against that bitch back there as I possibly can."

Catra must drift after that, because there's someone singing with a guitar somewhere over Catra's head. When Catra stirs, Adora rests her hand on her head and keeps it there. "Sleep."

Adora's sitting in the front with Bow when she wakes alone in the backseat, not sure if she'd dreamed.

Adora put ice on Catra's hand as soon as they got home. She rolled her eyes and said Adora was fussing too much, but she kept the ice pack on the bruise that was already purpling deep.

Bow filled the file with the colorful tabs Adora puts in her textbooks. The next day, he walked them through what he found, words calm even when his voice crackles. Fourteen abuse or neglect reports, kindergarten through high school. The hospital. The time Adora said she got too cold. The time Catra's hands were raw, weeping lumps. So many other times that it was obvious that something was horribly wrong but nobody helped.

They split it up, after Bow leaves. Catra's face is blank as she reads one of the yellow tabs, incident reports from school. Bow

had to open a new package of tabs for those.

Adora looks back down. *scald or chemical burns, untreated - highly defensive - foster sister reported that the injury appeared the night she was suspended, states that their foster parent must have done it.* That had to have been Lonnie. Adora remembers Catra being furious with her for weeks after her hands went back to normal. Lonnie's mom had gotten her paints for Christmas and Catra dumped them on the tattered plush lizard she kept in her bed. Now Adora knows why.

When Adora came in from school and saw her on the couch, hands wrapped in white, it took Catra long enough to cover the pain on her face that Adora knew it was bad. She remembers guilt for feeling sorry for her, when Catra was suspended for punching someone hard enough to send them to the nurse. Adora had saved her potato chips from lunch, and Catra couldn't pick them up with her mittened hands, something wetting the gauze from the inside, so Adora fed them to her one at a time, telling herself that Catra would be okay if she ate them all.

When the suspension was over, Catra hid her hands long enough to make it on the bus. Adora had never seen part of someone look like those did, skin bubbly and red. Adora tried to cover them even though Catra tensed whenever anything touched them. She didn't listen when Adora said her teacher would notice. Adora told her she should have stayed in her room, and Catra growled at her, and then she wasn't at recess because the nurse sent her home and Adora didn't see her for another two days.

"Can I ask something?" Adora says. Catra raises an eyebrow at her. "I was always telling you to stay home, when you were hurt. Lonnie too, after Weaver hit her."

Catra flips the page. "Not hearing a question."

"I mean, she." Adora swallows. She doesn't know how to ask. She probably shouldn't be in the first place. She needs to know if she

put Catra directly in Weaver's hands too. "She hurt you when you stayed home, right?"

Adora can see Catra's shoulders try to stay down and normal. She's been tense since they woke up this morning. Catra says, face wrenching, "Do not make her fucking me your fault."

Adora doesn't want to flinch, but she does, and immediately opens her mouth to apologize.

"Sorry," Catra says first, looking back at the papers in her hands. "Habit."

"I mean, you can call it whatever you want. It's your story, not mine."

Something softens on Catra's face. "Yeah, but. It makes you uncomfortable."

Adora doesn't know how to say that there's not going to be a way to talk about this that she feels comfortable with. "How I feel doesn't matter, though. Not about this."

"What did you call it? At LUNA."

"Child, um, sexual exploitation. Sexual assault, rape."

Catra makes a face. "The police like one of those. Lonnie called it the last one but Netossa said it isn't, legally."

Adora probably should address that definition first, but- "Did she, with Lonnie-"

Catra jerks her head. "No."

Chills run along Adora's skin. "But Lonnie knew?"

"I think just the last time." Catra shifts, shoulders hiking up, and Adora starts to feel the drop in her stomach like she's started to step after the stairs have ended. "The night we left."

"She-" Adora swallows and it does not help. Adora knows exactly where she was, that night - staring blankly at Bow's bio notes and trying to tell herself that she made the right decision, that it didn't matter if refusing to go home made Weaver angry because Adora hung up. And two hours away, Weaver was-

"It's not complicated." The document shakes in Catra's hands as she puts it down. She goes to the stack of paper by the recycling bin, the school newspapers Adora brings home just to be shredded. "Last hurrah or whatever, before she - whatever."

"Lonnie didn't tell me," Adora says, numb.

"Yeah, she fucking didn't. You aren't just telling people, right? Have you just been telling-"

"Of course not." Adora takes a breath. Lonnie's not even here, it's stupid to be mad at her. "But if I'd-"

"If you would've known you never would've fucked me, yeah, I remember," Catra says, venom thick. She rips a sheet of newspaper. "Then I could've had eighteen more months of *this*."

Adora stops, tries to figure out where the conversation broke. "Eighteen months of what?"

Catra's face pulls in a snarl. "Begging you to give me a fucking hug is what."

Adora's cheeks heat. She's been putting this off, hoping if she just ignores it and everyone ignores it they can pretend it's fine. Darla tells her that she needs to have the difficult conversations with Catra, but she doesn't know if she can bear to hear her argue again that the sex they had was good actually, that she wanted to be dissociated half the time. Adora already knows that the parts she was awake for must have been more awful than Catra's willing to admit, if she's glad she could check out part way through. Adora would never have wanted to miss a second, and now she wishes she could cut it all out of her head.

"Knew that's how it would go too." Catra blinks, jaw tight. "I've said I'm sorry about a million times. I get that that's not good enough but I don't know what the fuck else you want from me."

Adora closes the file, pushes it aside. She wants Catra to stop blaming herself more than she wants to avoid this. "Come here," she says.

Catra doesn't move.

"Do you want to figure this out?"

Catra walks over carefully, sits across from Adora. She brings her paper with her, and Adora tries not to let the ripping sound raise her hackles. She tries to remember what Darla said. *Find the emotion under the thought. Say how you're feeling. Trust her to hear you.* It wasn't about this conversation, because she still hadn't figured out how to admit it to Darla, but this is Catra. She can trust her.

"It really scared me," Adora says, "when I realized that you weren't - there. All the time."

Catra winds a strip of newspaper around her index finger. "I know I should've told you. I'm sorry. If that's not something you can forgive, just say so, instead of making me apologize over and over and-"

"I don't need to forgive you, this isn't your fault. I'm not, I don't know, punishing you." Adora breathes again, tries to feel the weight of her hands on her knees. "I'm just - I'm scared."

Catra pulls the strip tight until the tip of her finger pales. "Don't worry," she says, voice darkening. "I won't let the big bad monster get you."

"That's not what I mean."

"Isn't it? You *signed up* for me, I gave you chances to leave if you were over having a feral bitch in your-"

"Don't talk about yourself like that," Adora says, nausea curling in her gut. She doesn't like when she can hear Weaver's cadence in Catra's voice. "That's not what I'm saying, you know it's not. I'm saying I don't want to make you-"

Catra's hands slam on the floor. "I'm not going to keep having this argument with you." Her face is flushed, angry, and Adora can't figure out where that anger was when Adora pushed her out of her head. "You gave me shit for years and you're the one who can't listen."

"I don't want to argue about it again either! You say it wasn't all bad but you don't-"

"Do you need a fucking play by play of every way she ever touched me? You know anything can set that shit off, Adora, come up with a better lie next time. This one's getting old."

No one's ever going to trust you if you keep telling stories, Milagros told her in her living room, Weaver watching with her hurt face from the doorway. *Someday you're going to be in trouble and no one will listen, and that'll be on you.* Afterwards, Weaver said *I know you get mixed up, but I almost think you're doing this on purpose,* and Adora's denials tasted worse than the truth. "I'm not lying, stop-"

Catra laughs, the mean cruel way she does that makes Adora want to explode. "That's the worst one yet."

"You are the *last* person who can fucking lecture me about that."

Catra's eyes shutter. "This was stupid," she says. She stands up, paper confetti scattering, looking over at the couch. Trying to find Melog, seeking the comfort Adora can't figure out how to give her.

"Wait," Adora says, grabbing her unbruised hand. It spasms before tightens on hers. "Wait. Can I try again?"

Catra rakes her free hand through her hair, sighs. "For the record," Catra says, "if this is how talking is supposed to go, it

fucking sucks."

"It's not. I'm just bad at it."

Catra sits back down, back to the wall. She hasn't let go of Adora's hand. She tugs more newspaper onto her lap and pins down the edge between her elbow and leg so she can tear it one-handed. "Right, because I'm great at this."

Catra's trying too. *Find the feeling. Say it. Trust her.* "I know why you didn't tell me about her, I do. I'm not saying you should have, and I'm not going to tell you that you have to see what we did in any particular way. But you weren't *there*, Catra, and you hid that for so long. That was - that was the *point* for me, for us to be together, but you don't seem to care if you were even awake or not. That really freaks me out."

Catra shrinks in on herself, paper quieting. Her fingers are so tight it almost hurts. The circles under her eyes look especially dark.

Adora remembers something Darla does sometimes. "What do you hear, when I say that?"

"I don't *hear* shit. You're saying that you'd liked to have known you were fucking a whore before you did it."

Adora doesn't even know where to begin with that. She tries to think past the fact that Catra's using the same word for Weaver raping her and what they did together, because it's far from the worst part. She doesn't want to have that argument again when Catra clearly isn't ready to have it. "What Weaver did wasn't your fault, it doesn't-"

Catra drops her hand then. "Oh my *god*, not everything is about her!"

This isn't working. "Maybe we need to go see someone," Adora says carefully. "Together."

"I don't need someone else trying to get in my head, I'm fucking drowning in that already. I just need you to say shit instead of dancing around-"

"That's what I'm doing *right now*." Adora's working so hard not to shout, to keep all the frustration bundled up where it isn't going to hurt anyone. "You just keep hearing something I never-"

"Because you care too much about sounding nice to actually say what you mean!"

"If you're convinced I'm always lying to you-"

"You can barely fucking touch me, Adora, what am I supposed to think?"

"You're supposed to think that I love you!" Adora's breathing too hard, face hot, skin itching. This isn't how Darla said to do it. "You keep telling me I'm not Weaver, so I don't know why you're treating me like I am!"

Catra blinks at her, lips open slightly, and Adora realizes that she didn't manage to keep her voice calm the way she wanted to. She fights for that now, pushing a hand against her head. "I love you," she says. "I don't know how to make you understand that I care about you. I'm never trying to hurt you, I'm never thinking any of the fucked up shit she told you, and I don't know why you think I am. Tell me what I did that makes you think I ever would, because I can only think of one thing, and you flip out every time I say it."

Catra's quiet for a moment. "I know you care. About me," she says.

Adora wants to argue back, list out all the ways Catra reads the worst motives into everything she does, point out that less than a minute ago she was saying that Adora's too polite to blame her for being abused out loud. She doesn't.

Catra's hands lie quiet on her lap. Her throat bobs when she swallows. "I trust you. Or I'm - trying to."

She said she loved me, Catra said, after her mother stopped seeing her and then stopped living. *She didn't mean it, but she said it*. Weaver used to tell Adora that she loved her all the time, and then she made her best friend scream.

"I just-" Catra coughs, draws her knees in against her chest, looks at the blinds over the window. "Back there, when things were awful, and you were there, you would - when you held me and talked to me and - being with you helped, and when I said no I knew you'd back off before I freaked. You were - safe, and even here I still, I need you. And now you're being like this and I can only think of one reason why."

When Catra surfaced after hours or days downstairs, she was always one of two ways. Muted, confused, tired, what Adora recognizes as dissociated now, or jittery and shaking and easy to overwhelm. After the first few times Adora tried to hug a panicking Catra and got shoved away, she learned to ask first.

Usually she nodded and Adora could tuck her face in her own neck and pretend that her arms were a shield, gold and bright, but sometimes Catra shook her head with eyes big and desperate and Adora sat next to her instead and tried to make her voice calm and soothing, like ocean waves, the way Razz said soothed babies who were too young to understand words. When the color came back to Catra's face, she almost always poured into a hug anyway.

"But what if I keep going," Adora says, "when you need me to stop? What if I-"

"Adora." Catra grimaces, hands tensing over her legs. "You keep talking about sex like you held me at gunpoint and it's just not true. It's not like you-" Catra stops, breathes. "I know what forcing it *is* and that wasn't what you did. You would have ended everything if I'd told you to and I didn't."

It keeps Adora up at night, thinking about it. "Why?"

"Why what?"

"Why didn't you tell me to stop."

Catra pinches her lips. Melog comes out from wherever they've been hiding and bops Catra's knee, the way they do when they want exactly eight pets and no more, and Catra breathes out shaky when she scratches between their ears. "Maybe I didn't want you to, dummy."

"I can't figure out *why,* other than because you wanted to hurt yourself, or I made you think I'd leave you."

"Yes, Adora, everything's always about you," Catra says, scowling. Melog nudges her hand where she stopped petting them, and climbs in her lap. She looks at them like she isn't sure where they came from. Her eyes flick to Adora's for an instant, regret tugging at her mouth. "I didn't mean that. I'm - working on it." She curls her hand under Melog's chin, scritching lightly. Adora fiercely wants something she's told herself it isn't safe to have.

Catra says, "I wanted you to like me, yeah, and I didn't want you to have to find someone better, but that wasn't all of it." Catra watches Melog purr against her stomach. "I wanted you to - to touch me like I wasn't what she said." Her face bitters. "I was, I guess, but you made me feel like I mattered anyway."

Adora remembers to breathe. "You do, you always have. You've never been *anything* she said you were."

"And our whole lives, that's part of how you showed me. I know it's not going to be like it was, and I'm not - if you don't want me to glitch out, I'm not ready for it to be. But I need the, y'know. Cuddles and shit."

"Cuddles and shit," Adora echoes.

"Yes." Catra's face is flushed, pink high in her cheeks, and Adora knows the skin would be warm to the touch. "So it would be nice if maybe you could ask me what I need instead of deciding."

When Adora reaches out again, Catra tugs her over where she and Melog nest. She doesn't know where to put her hands when Catra pulls her in, head on her shoulder. It felt different yesterday, when they were in public and Catra was an open wound, when she knew Bow was there to stop her if anything went wrong. Melog's between them, purring and purring, and it lets her quiet the part of her mind that keeps repeating that she's going to hurt her. Catra jumps a little when Adora's hand lands over her scapula, but she holds on tighter and says, "I'll kill you if you fucking move right now."

"Okay," Adora says, something light bubbling under her ribs, heart slowing back down. Close to Catra has always meant safety, and the feeling is too deep-rooted for even the strongest guilt to change.

"I mean it. I have a particular set of skills."

"Sure you do." She brings her other hand to the back of Catra's head, threads her fingers through the hair that's still growing out, and scars texture under her fingers. Catra presses her face into the space where her neck meets her shoulder like they can merge if she tries hard enough, and Adora can hear and feel the air come in and out of her lungs when she cries.

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer's birthday is at an ice skating rink, which she apologizes for in advance. "This is part of a long con to get Bow on skates," she says, "so at least you'll have that to entertain you."

Catra's not complaining. It's outdoors in February, so she has an excuse to bundle up and lean on the walls at the edge of the rink and drink hot chocolate with her girlfriend. Adora's getting better at a range of liquids even when they're full of poison or whatever.

Bow's lack of skill at ice skating is as advertised. Glimmer pulls them up to the boards, cheeks pink, and Bow clutches them gratefully, pants dusted with ice. Glimmer puts her gloved hands on the barrier. "C'mon," she says. "Which one of you do I get next?"

"Can't skate on my ankle," Adora says, smirking, traitor. She's not even in the brace anymore, it's not even a good excuse.

Catra looks at Bow, who's trying to balance while holding onto the side. "Not a chance."

"Catra," Glimmer says with a performative groan. "It's my birthday. You gotta respect birthday royalty."

"You're barely a week older than me, I've got to be at least birthday nobility."

"Sure, next week I won't make you skate." Glimmer does a face that probably works on Bow. Adora takes Catra's styrofoam cup like the absolute enabler she is.

Skating isn't as bad as Catra feared. As long as she stays mostly still and lets Glimmer pull her along, she doesn't feel like she's

about to get a face full of ice. Glimmer holds her hands and skates backwards, face a little pink from the cold. Catra says, "Okay, I admit it. This was really cute when it was Bow."

Glimmer's teeth catch the light when she smiles. "Not you though."

"Obviously not. My girlfriend's thirty feet away, and also I've never been cute in my life."

"Uh-huh." Glimmer shifts their hands, glancing over her shoulder to guide them around the corner. "So how are you doing?"

Catra doesn't grit her teeth. "So that's what this was, Fujimura? A ploy?"

"You don't have to answer that," Glimmer says, "but for the future, it's a really normal question to ask a friend."

Catra focuses on keeping her ankles straight instead of thinking about *friend*. "So Adora told you the trial's scheduled for April."

"Not what I was asking, but okay." Glimmer pinches her lips, glancing back again before she speaks. "Do you want me or Bow to be there?"

Catra can't make sense of the question. "Aren't you guys Adora's best friends or whatever? You should ask her."

"Yeah," Glimmer says, "but ultimately I think your opinion is more important here."

Catra's skates slip a little under her, and Glimmer adjusts their weight so they don't fall. On the other side of the rink, Bow's made it off the ice. He's talking to Adora, who's still holding a cup in each hand. Adora's smiling but Catra can't read the nuances from here. Adora knows how to make friends, always has, even when Catra was young and trying to sabotage them at every turn.

Catra didn't have friends, before. Not for very long. She had Adora, and occasionally Adora would bring someone else to sit with them at lunch and Catra would spend the entire time thinking all the mean things she could say to get them to leave, and at the smallest bit of friction all her cruel words or fists would spill out. Whoever it was who had liked Adora enough to take a chance on Catra regretted it every time. *I told you she was crazy*, kids would tell each other in earshot, *her poor sister's a saint.*

Scorpia was the closest thing to a friend Catra had, before moving to Bright Moon. She'd come to visit in January, and she fussed over Melog and showed off pictures of her new girlfriend and insisted on doing touristy shit and they didn't have to talk about how Catra's life has been falling apart. It was nice, having her there, acting like Catra was still someone she wanted in her life. *Call me if you want to talk, come down, anything,* Scorpia said before she left. *I'm always here.* Catra rolled her eyes, but Scorpia can read her better than to be fooled by that. Scorpia hugged her before she left and only cried a little.

Catra shrugs like some pathetic corner of her head isn't trying to figure out how she has friends that she doesn't want to chase away. "If you want to, I guess," she says. "If Adora wants you there."

"Okay, I'll check with her." Glimmer asks about work, then, and Catra complains about the new inventory system that corporate is trying to roll out, and Glimmer complains about the guest speaker her public policy class had last week. Catra's chocolate is no longer hot when Glimmer steers them back to the edge of the rink. Adora's cup is gone, but she's still with Bow so she probably actually finished it.

On the drive home, Adora asks Catra if she wants to see if Scorpia can come up for her birthday next week, and she smiles when Catra says her dumb friends should also come. They go to the Indian place Catra likes, with paneer cubes that squeak in her teeth. She didn't realize Adora would take that as an invitation to

Glimmer's mom too, but Fujimura is quiet and Catra can almost pretend she isn't there.

Gifts are a good thing about doing birthdays, now. Bow got her the book about gay androids that he knows she's checked out of the library three times already. Glimmer gave her more of the lime scrub that Adora's rapidly using up on her hands. Catra told Scorpia not to bring a present, because she already owes her enough, but she insists that the toy is for Melog so it doesn't count. Fujimura's gift is last, and it's heavier than she expects from the size of the box. It's a stuffed animal, a cat the same color as Melog and almost the same size, and beads shift under the fur when she picks it up.

"Aw, it's like Kowl," Glimmer coos. "Does it smell like lavender too?"

Fujimura shakes her head. "I confess I didn't know if you would like it scented, so it's not. That can be changed, if you'd prefer. It takes oils very well."

It's nice, way too nice. Catra's brain scatters with what Fujimura could possibly want for it before she remembers that that's the kind of thought she's supposed to stop.

"Kowl?" Adora asks, foot pressed tight to Catra's. She always knows how to distract attention away from Catra when she needs it.

Glimmer pulls out her phone. "Stuffie I've had for years. Dad made him - he tried so hard but you can tell Dad had never done it before. I've got to have a picture of him somewhere."

"He looks like an alien," Bow adds. "Scared me to death when I was little."

"You big baby," Glimmer says, "just because your dads only got you educational toys so you can't appreciate art-"

Scorpia is sitting on her other side, and she gets her hand close to the cat's head before she stops. "Can I pet him?" she asks, and Catra nods, something confusing welling in her chest. The cat's blue eyes catch the light. "He's great, Wildcat."

Fujimura is watching Glimmer with amusement, but Catra's being unbearably rude, and stuff like that matters now. "Thank you, Mrs. Fujimura," she says, and she doesn't sound the way she expects to. "It's beautiful."

"It was my pleasure," Fujimura says, "and please call me Angella." Catra isn't going to, but she nods anyway. Glimmer finds the picture, and the toy truly is hideous, and Catra only puts the cat back in its box so it doesn't get masala on it.

When Catra wakes up in the middle of the night a couple weeks later, Adora's side of the bed is cold. Catra finds her in the living room, looking at a folder, wiping her face. Catra sits next to her and puts her arm around her.

"Didn't mean to wake you up," Adora manages to say, flipping the cover of the folder shut. Catra catches it before it closes.

"You didn't." It's Catra's file, from Milagros. It's one of the photographs on a scanned page, black and white and grainy. It's a school picture, like every picture of herself she's ever seen from before Adora got a phone, and they're all equally ugly. Pretty silly thing for Adora to be getting weepy about.

"I'm sorry," Adora says. "I just - I had a nightmare and - anyway. I wanted to see you."

"I was like six inches away."

"You know." Adora blinks too hard. "How you used to be."

In the picture, her hair is brushed, giant and puffy the way it always was. Adora used to brush it, back then, apologizing every time she hit a knot. She can't be older than eight, and she's wearing the god-awful headband that she got from Razz. Adora

had given Razz the fucking sob story about her mom once, and she came home with it in her backpack. Catra was little and stupid enough to hold onto that thing long past when it got to be too small for her head. The kid in the picture is looking past whoever's behind the camera, smile empty and fake, mask on already.

Catra looks away. If she wanted to stare at the monster all day she could get her own fucking picture.

"I forget how young we were." Adora drags her hand across her eyes again. "It just - it wasn't fair."

Catra closes the file. It shakes a little in her hands. "You shouldn't have had to see all that," she says.

Adora swallows hard. "You shouldn't have had to live all that."

She can hear her own teeth grind before she responds. "Well, I was born that thing instead, so. Are you coming back to bed?"

Adora tenses. "What do you mean, that thing?"

Catra's been waiting for this particular pile of shit to hit the fan, now that every person she knows has something sappy to say about the little brat. Maybe that's why she said what she said, to get it over with. Catra flips the file open. "I'm sorry, is this before or after she fucking mauls a kid?"

"I remember that," Adora says. "You were defending me, Octavia was twice our size."

"And she shoved you. That's how the quote goes, right? Eye for a shove?"

Adora's pulling away, trying to make Catra look at her, and fuck that. "Obviously you didn't mean to hurt her that badly, you were six."

She didn't mean to, Adora whispered after the pain in Catra's arm settled into a dull ache under her cast, after Adora stole Motrin in

the middle of the night and rubbed circles on her back until the medicine started to work enough for her to hear. *Obviously it was an accident.*

"You don't know *what* I meant to do." Catra only remembers what happened in broad strokes, but she remembers feeling Octavia's skin tear, feeling something give under her fingernails, blood jumping up to meet her hand. She still has a picture in her head of Octavia's head snapping off like a Barbie, rocking on the gray carpet, even though she knows that didn't happen and it's such a dumb kid thing to think that it could.

"You were traumatized, Catra, that's how this stuff works. You were - violent, yeah. That's not abnormal when-"

Catra slams the file shut so she doesn't have to look at it anymore. "You don't know shit."

"I know you weren't what Weaver said," Adora says.

Catra manages not to throw up on the file. She jerks far enough away that Adora isn't touching her anymore, but she still feels ghost pressure, tugging at her hair, the thing she always tried to write over with kinder hands. She's supposed to use her coping skills for this. She's so tired of having to cope all the time.

"Catra," Adora says, "you *weren't.* I was there, remember?"

"No, you fucking weren't." Adora flinches in her peripheral vision at that, and that's why everyone wants her to finally control herself. "I didn't mean it like that, I'm sorry."

"I know," Adora says, but it's clear that she heard it like that anyway. "But we were *best friends*, Catra, I remember what she said and - she never should have said any of that stuff."

"How do you think this even happened?" Catra shoves it out of her chest, because Adora's never going to figure this out on her own. She's too good at seeing what she wants to see. "Do you

think she just woke up one morning and thought, oh *that* kid looks especially fuckable?"

"She's a predator." Adora rocks a little, blurry at the edge of Catra's vision. "That's why when we left she moved on to someone else. She just wanted to hurt people and she didn't care who it was. It could have been any-"

"Bullshit," Catra hisses, poison in her gut. "She had three and only one of them was awful enough to-"

"The part of her brain that's supposed to care about other people doesn't work," Adora says, with that cadence that means it's her therapist's words. "She couldn't love any of us. Everything she's ever done has been to get what she wants."

You think I don't know what you want? the voice says against her ear. Sometimes Catra remembers things from somewhere else in the room, like the camera watching, and when she remembers the little thing crying she wishes Weaver had hit it harder, knocked back together whatever broken wires couldn't line up inside. "And you think she wanted *me?* How delusional are you?"

Something flashes on Adora's face, an expression too fast to catch before it vanishes. "That wasn't about you, she was-"

Catra slams her hands on the ground, almost as hard as her ringing in her ears. "Of course, it wasn't about me because I don't fucking matter, right? She was *inside me* and she was just jerking off to you? Is that what fucking me is like?"

"You're doing it again," Adora says, which is the moment that Catra realizes how much her voice has risen. "I'm not who you're mad at, stop yelling at me."

Catra forces her shoulders to drop, face growing hot. This is her fucking point, she never stopped being a vindictive feral thing, and she hurts everything she touches. "I'm sorry."

Adora reaches for the weighted cat, the gift from Fujimura, and puts it on Catra's lap. Its fur is rich and soft, and it's something she doesn't deserve. "It's okay," Adora says, and it's not. "We're both tired, it's late. Maybe we should talk about this another time."

Catra doesn't want to do this another time. She's so sick of being something people have to dose out, and she isn't supposed to dig her nails in anymore, but her skin itches worse when she stops. The cat isn't warm like Melog is, but petting it helps. Maybe if she'd been born something better, she wouldn't be an adult with a stuffed animal who has to work way too hard to *talk*, which most preschoolers have figured out. "I'm sorry," she says again. "I'm trying to explain."

Adora puts her hands on the back of hers, and when Catra flips her palms she can hold them. "Take all the time you need," Adora says.

Actions have consequences, the principal said. Catra shifted her hands in the cuffs, red marks already harsh where she yanked on them until it hurt too much not to stop. *You can't act with violence and expect to get away with it. That's not the way the world works.*

No wonder your mom doesn't visit you, Lonnie said, eye darkening and lip swelling after Catra punched her until Adora pulled her off. *I think I'd shoot myself if it was my fault you exist.*

I wish you didn't make me do this, Weaver said in the middle of the night, while Catra watched blood ripple off her skin into the bathwater in curling ribbons, muscles still glitching and slack. Weaver's hands were gentle in her hair for once when she worked soap through it. *I hate that this is what it takes to get you to behave. I want to love you instead.*

"I was a bad kid," she says, and it's only half-true because she's still one of those things. "That's why I was always causing problems - that's why Weaver - my mom-"

When her voice dies, Adora tightens the grip on her hands, so hard it almost hurts. "That's not true."

That's Adora though, to look past all the evidence for something and believe what she wants to believe instead. She's not going to understand, because she's always been the good one, top of the class and star of the team and *such a wonderful young lady*, and her largest blind spot has always been for the parts of Catra that drip rot. She's too nice to let herself see it, like everything else.

"Catra," Adora says, thumbs stroking over the backs of her hands. Catra watches, seeing it more than she feels it, unable to look at Adora's face anyway. "If I have to guess what you're thinking I'm going to get it wrong."

"It's just - everyone would've been better off if-" If Weaver had followed through on any of the threats to drown the monster in the bath, or bag her on the curb, or wring her neck. If Catra had followed through on any of the times she was too aware of the yellow line on the road, or the edge of a roof, or the jump rope in Adora's room. If anyone had managed to solve her when she was a little problem. "If I wasn't here."

"Not me. I needed you, always have, I - you were the only thing that-" Adora stops, breathes harsh. "Everyone else who was nice to me, it was because I did what they wanted. At school, at home - they just liked that I was obedient, and when I wasn't perfect I was sure that something horrible was going to happen to me, but you - I didn't have to be perfect with you. You liked *me*. I looked out for you, but you looked out for me too. You made things better for me, always, like it was okay because you were there. I was always so scared without you."

"You were scared of *me* half the time, I was awful to you."

"Remember that-" Adora pauses. "That time you bit me?"

A week after Lonnie moved back into their house, Ms. Knowles kept Catra five minutes late to clean up the mess she made when

she heard that they had homework. When Catra got to the bus, Lonnie was already sitting with Adora, giggling about something, and Catra punched Lonnie in the gut before she ran to the back of the bus where the older kids who called her crazy sat. She wedged herself behind the back seat and sobbed because Adora didn't want to be her friend anymore and she was going to die alone in the dark.

She growled at the fifth graders who tried to get her to come and sit. When they got to their stop, Adora came to pull her out and Catra bit her hand until she tasted blood in her mouth. Catra missed school for three days and Adora had to take medicine so she didn't get an infection from Catra's filthy mouth.

Catra says, "Yeah, I remember, and it doesn't help your case even a little bit."

"I was terrified that Ms- that Weaver was going to see my hand and find out what happened, because I knew how she'd be, but I was never scared of you."

Adora should've been. Maybe if the only point of reference she had was Weaver, she didn't realize that people weren't supposed to be like that.

Adora says, "Do you remember me looking for you? When you were hiding?"

Catra had burrowed under the bunk bed, where she could pretend that this hadn't happened and Adora didn't hate her and when Weaver got home in a few hours she would forget that Catra existed. She does remember Adora lying on the floor, tilting her head to see underneath, saying something. Catra yelled for her to fuck off until she left. Lonnie asked *what's wrong with you* and Catra said *shut up or you'll find out*, and then Lonnie left too, and she knew they had to have been going to play together because they knew they were better off without her.

"And later I came to talk to you? Downstairs."

Everything down there blurred together. She must have been sore, after she was pulled out from under the bed and slammed against the wall and Weaver said *what is it going to fucking take with you*. Weaver had a cover for the light switch in the basement room back then that her hands were too small to open, so she didn't waste the electricity on a feral brat that shouldn't even be alive. It would have been too dark to see anything unless someone turned on the basement lights and lit up the line under the door. She used to lie on her side so she didn't have to feel the carpet on her neck.

Catra's stomach aches. "You got a point?"

Adora's voice warps. "I said I was your friend, remember?"

She'd forgotten that it was the same time. Adora brought her the light under the door and when Catra told her to go away she said *no, I want to be with you.*

You hate me.

No, I don't. My hand doesn't even hurt anymore, I'm fine except I miss you.

I know you like Lonnie better. Go play with your new sister.

She's your sister too. If you told her you were sorry, maybe we could all play together.

You're supposed to be my friend.

I am your friend. I'm always going to be your friend.

You promise?

I promise.

Adora also looked to Weaver for comfort, praise, affection, because she earned it. Catra did too, even when she knew she hadn't, and she thought it was kindness every time she melted

and Weaver said *there's my docile girl*. "The fact that I was the best of your terrible options doesn't mean as much as you think it does."

Adora lets go of one of her hands so she can pull the file closer, flip it open. When Catra risks a glance at her face, it's hard to look at, all sad and hurt and guilt. "I've always loved you," Adora says, "then and now and always. This kid *is* you, and she's important to me, so please be nicer to her. I think she's heard enough already."

Catra's words tangle up, and she puts the cat on Adora's lap one-handed. Adora smiles, but pain stays etched in every line of her. "Hey, buddy."

"Excuse you," Catra says, trying to work her face into an expression, "that's Mx. Buddy to you."

Adora laughs wet. "Do they finally have a name?"

"Until they finish their doctorate."

Adora giggles before her face crumples again. She puts her free hand over her eyes, shoulders hunching. Her foot nudges the folder away. "I'm sorry," she says, "I'm *sorry*, I can't-"

When Catra slides up on her knees to get closer, Adora drops against her like her strings have cut. "If you thought the name was that bad you could've just said so," Catra says, feeling unsteady. The picture in the file stares at her, little thing trying to ruin her life again.

"I'm sorry," Adora says into Catra's shirt. "I'm trying. I just-" Her hands spasm around Catra's waist. "You hate yourself and that scares me so much."

Adora needs to hear that she doesn't. Maybe she wants Catra to be one of those people who own words like *survivor* and don't wish they hadn't. Adora definitely doesn't want her to lie anymore. "I'm going to therapy and stuff," she says. "I'm trying too."

"I know," Adora says. She closes her eyes, ear to Catra's heart. "And thank you for doing that. Taking care of you can't just be my job, I need to know that you will too."

She can still feel the echo of *stupid useless thing, can't do anything by yourself, weak weak weak,* but she can hear something else, this time. Adora loves her. Adora's scared that she's going to finally listen to the part of her head that tells her how to die. Adora doesn't want to lose her.

"That's what I'm doing," she says. Her voice gets stronger as she talks. "I'm not going anywhere. I don't want to, not really. I promise."

They don't bother going back to sleep, after that. Adora puts green in her new coloring book with the pencils she's less and less diligent about keeping sharp. Catra tries a new origami pattern, a panda, and Adora lets her pile up her failed attempts on her lap. Adora keeps reaching out to touch her, like she's making sure she's really there, and it lights like stars in the darkness every time.

Adora's anxiety ramps up as the court date gets closer, which surprises no one but her. She's meditating like Darla told her to, but every time she tries, her thoughts scatter too much for her to gather back together, and she doesn't have anything to distract her from how hard her heart pounds. On the third day in a row that she puts the rice she made back in the fridge, she goes to the gym to try to run it out, and it only barely works.

"I don't understand. I'm supposed to be doing better," she tells Darla, that evening. "My course load is lighter this semester, and I'm not an athlete anymore, and I'm trying to do the mindfulness stuff and everything."

"Mindfulness isn't for everyone," Darla says. "You're headed into something very stressful, and maybe it's not a good fit right now."

Darla asks what Adora's concerned about, during the trial, and she doesn't even know where to start. She's practiced with Rosetti's aide three times, so she knows what she's going to say. The aide said witnesses were especially important in this case, because the police never found the original recordings, never found the mask, and Adora knows that has to be because she warned Weaver of what was coming. "I messed up," she says, and she knows Darla's figured out by now that that's just another way for her to apologize.

"We've talked about why the abuse wasn't your fault," Darla says, and she's right. Adora knows she's right. Some days, it's easy to believe, and other days guilt weighs down on her like a collapsing building, and all the thought challenging in the world doesn't help. She can't shake the feeling that she's fooling herself again, that the logic Darla tries to walk her through is based on Adora's lies. Darla thinks she's blameless because she can't know what really happened, and Adora can't know if she's only remembering what she wants to remember.

Darla asks what Catra would tell her, if she knew how guilty she feels sometimes. "Catra thinks it's *her* fault," Adora says, tasting metal. It fills her with such a heavy mix of despair and fury and terror. This is why she's worried to see Weaver in court. She doesn't want to snap again, and she doesn't want Weaver's voice in Catra's head to get loud enough to drown Adora out. "Lonnie thought I should have stayed."

"Lonnie was angry and scared," Darla counters. "She'd just run away from a dangerous situation. Have you talked to her since then?"

Adora's tried probably a dozen times over the months since Weaver was arrested. The line says it's disconnected, but she tries anyway. She even got desperate enough to call from Catra's phone, on the impossibility that Lonnie has her new phone

number blocked too. Adora had to get hers changed, after she hung up with Weaver and never answered another call. She only listened to one voicemail, the first, after she didn't call the next Thursday. *I don't know why you would do this to me. I can't lose you, I love you more than you can ever understand.* She deleted the rest unopened, but her phone buzzing made her jump until Glimmer told her how to change her number.

Darla says she should listen to people who know her better. She still thinks about it for the rest of the day, stone in her gut. When she sees Lonnie outside of her research methods class later that week, it's like Adora summoned her. She's sitting on a bench, looking up from her phone every time the door opens. Everything but the length of her dreads is what Adora remembers.

"You," Lonnie says as soon as she spots her, loud enough for Adora to hear from yards away. "We gotta talk."

For a moment, she entertains the idea that Lonnie is a student here, but she looks as out of place as Adora feels most of the time. "Hi," Adora says. She walks up to Lonnie, who's always been more snarl than bite. "What happened to never seeing me again?"

Lonnie's face is set. "I know the cops called you, so don't try to lie to me."

Jada from Adora's assessment class walks past, eyes darting away as she pretends not to look. "We can't do this here," Adora says, skin on her neck prickling.

"Sorry," Lonnie sneers, "afraid your college friends are gonna find out you used to be trash like the rest of us?"

Adora can't take the bait. She turns and heads off the main walkway to the side of Baylor Hall, and if Lonnie came all the way from Thaymor to yell at her she'll follow. Adora makes it probably fifteen feet through the trees before Lonnie grabs her shoulder, yanks her around. "You don't get to walk away," Lonnie says, "not again."

"I'm not going to get in a screaming match on the quad, Lon-"

"Don't change the goddamn subject," Lonnie snaps. "The court's gonna make me testify, and there's no way in hell they didn't ask you too, and I'm making sure you know you can't defend that bitch up there."

Cold flashes over her so hard she can barely breathe. "What?"

"If you don't believe Catra, believe *me,*" Lonnie says. "You know I'm not a liar, we fought about it enough. I saw her, I got her out of there. I know what that piece of shit did to her, whether you want to fucking see it or not-"

"What do you think I am?" She has nausea most of the time, as the date gets closer and closer, but it's overwhelming now. Lonnie's glaring at her and Adora doesn't know how this person grew up with her and still thinks she would be capable of that. "Of course I believe her."

"You never gave a shit before, so forgive me for-"

"I couldn't stop it," Adora says, something exploding in her chest. "I wanted to, but what were we supposed to *do,* Lonnie?"

"Literally anything." Lonnie's knuckles are pale. "The keys weren't that fucking hard to find, if you'd ever looked."

Adora had, though not for years. When she was younger, and more scared, and worse at telling herself everything was fine. When Adora had nightmares about Catra cold or bleeding or snapped in half and just needed to know that she was alive in there. Sometimes she ran downstairs and knocked until Catra woke up, and then she had to pretend that she'd thought of something to tell her that was too cool to wait until morning. If Catra saw through her, she let her pretend it had worked. Sometimes Adora got to the top of the stairs and heard muffled cries and knew not to go any closer if she didn't know where Weaver was. She never slept well, after that.

"You know that idiot would have gone anywhere you told her to. But you were too busy playing school, you wanted her to wait for you like a dog in a-"

"Stop it." Adora closes her eyes, pulling a breath through her nose. She doesn't want to find herself pinning Lonnie to a wall. Adora was never like this, before last summer. She doesn't know what's wrong with her.

She's thought about what she should have done a thousand times by now. How she should have pulled Catra in the car with her the day Weaver gave her the keys, and driven away, and then what? Slept in the backseat when the summer and winter both get cold enough to kill? Looked for a shelter that didn't have a waitlist so long that she could have graduated by the time they had somewhere to sleep? Tried to hide Catra in her dorm room and hope the RA didn't notice?

Adora asked an adult for help once, *once*, when her first grade teacher asked her why Catra was absent and Adora told her the truth. When she got home from school, Catra screamed at her from the other side of the door for the first time, and Ms. Weaver sat with her on the couch and told her how disappointed she was that Adora was telling lies. *I know you don't mean to hurt me,* she said, *but it breaks my heart. I love you and this is how you repay me*. Adora had to get her crayons and write an apology to Ms. Layton for making stuff up. She made an apology for Catra too, even though Ms. Weaver didn't tell her to, and when she slid it under the door she just heard ripping and ripping, and she knew all she'd done was make things worse.

Catra doesn't think she didn't do enough. That's all Adora cares about.

"I did everything I could," she says, "and if you're just here to argue about that, I'm leaving."

A muscle jumps in Lonnie's jaw. "Tell yourself whatever the fuck you want. Just fucking swear to me that you won't spin your little

happy family story in court."

"No!" Blood rushes in her ears. "*Fuck* no. She - she's a monster, she - I'm going to do everything I can do to make sure she never gets out. You don't - you don't even know-"

Adora snaps her mouth shut before she regrets it. *You aren't just telling people, right?*

Lonnie laughs, and the edge in it makes Adora bristle worse. "It wasn't a fucking *secret*, you idiot. Just because you turned your brain off whenever you didn't want to see something didn't mean everyone did."

Screw it. Lonnie was going to be in court, she'll find out then if Rosetti doesn't tell her first. "It wasn't just the once," Adora says, stomach turning. "She hurt her so many-"

"Like a million times, yeah." Lonnie's hands are fisted at her sides. "Of course that's fucking *news* to you. You were joined at the goddamn hip, I wouldn't even believe it if I didn't know how you are."

Adora swallows. "Not just the - she-"

"Yeah, I know." Lonnie keeps staring at her, like she's daring Adora to make the first move. "Some of us have eyes."

Adora realizes her hands are balled up too when Lonnie's eyes flare and her shoulders bunch. They've never physically fought before, because Adora was a good kid. She didn't hit back, and Lonnie would never throw the first punch, so their orbit stayed steady even as Catra and Lonnie collided again and again. "There wasn't any way to know," Adora says, and her voice is quieter than she wants it to be. Something aches under her ribs.

"Bitch wasn't *subtle*." Lonnie crosses her arms and looks away. "Think I didn't see how she looked at you two? I mean, of course she wouldn't give the bad touch talk, but I didn't know you slept through it at school too."

Shivers skitter up Adora's spine. She doesn't know what Lonnie's saying, and she doesn't want to. Sometimes Adora remembers stuff wrong, reads into innocuous things, but she would have realized if there was anything there. Weaver was never - not like she was with Catra, that was because Weaver hated her and she never - Adora's always been so sensitive-

"Bet she said you were special," Lonnie sneers. "How much did it hurt to find out that she was using the punching bag too?"

Adora swallows down a wave of nausea. "It wasn't like that," she says, but it sounds far away. *That's my special girl,* Weaver would say, tracing a hand on her face while Adora basked in hearing that she'd done something good for once. *My Adora. I love you so much.*

"Did the prosecutor tell you she put a goddamn camera in the wall? Sick piece of shit." Lonnie kicks a branch on the ground, voice tight. "Said they've found over a hundred, but I can tell you there's gotta be more than that. How many are they going to dig up of *you*-"

"*Stop,*" Adora grits out. "If you're just here to yell at me, you can leave. I have stuff to do."

"Fine," Lonnie spits. "This wasn't a fucking social visit. I just had to make sure you weren't going to lick Mommy's boots again."

Adora isn't going to keep arguing about this. She feels fragile in a way she didn't expect. She doesn't want to talk to Lonnie anymore. "I'm going to tell the truth," she says. "Just like Catra, just like you." She sounds young, softness sliding back into her *s* sounds like her front teeth are still apart, and she doesn't know why. "I'm sorry."

Lonnie rolls her eyes. "Save it for the jury," she says. "I got nothing else to say to you."

Lonnie shoves past her, heading towards the rear entrance, and there's nothing but the back of campus that way. Lonnie doesn't

know where she's going, and Adora should just let her get lost in BMU's sprawl. It's been years since Lonnie accepted her help for anything anyway. Lonnie's barely out of sight before Adora can hear her cursing loud, and she reappears. "Fucking construction," she snaps, and she almost gets past Adora before Adora manages to catch her arm.

"Lonnie." Adora forces the words out of her mouth. *Angry and scared*, Darla had said, and Adora understands that combination well enough. "Wait."

"Don't fucking touch me," Lonnie says, but once she's shaken off Adora's hand she doesn't leave. She doesn't look at her, jaw pulsing as her teeth grind, but she stays.

Adora doesn't remember the first time she met Lonnie, just like she doesn't remember meeting Catra. Lonnie moved in when they were all three, and she left the summer before kindergarten, when her mom got custody again. She was gone until her social worker showed up with her one October afternoon in third grade. That first night, she was sullen. She ate mechanically and she didn't talk when Adora tried to ask her about her sisters. *It looks like the junkie didn't teach you manners while she had you*, Weaver said, lip curled.

The only clean clothes she had were the ones she was wearing - the rest were ingrained with dirt and food crust, at least a size too small. Weaver threw them away and told her to take some from Catra until her clothing subsidy came in, but she was a couple inches too tall for that so Adora put a week's worth of her own clothes back in the dresser she'd just been moved out of. Adora came downstairs in the morning to Lonnie wearing her pineapple shirt and eating cereal and trying to get Catra to talk to her, and Lonnie acted like she'd always been there, and Adora let her.

She wants to apologize again, but she's not supposed to when she doesn't know why. "I saw it," she says. "One of the tapes, I - I *saw* it and-"

Her backpack crunches when Lonnie slams her back against the wall, fist pinning her clavicle. Her lips snarl, but Adora still sees the tears in her eyes. "Enjoy that, huh? Did Mommy show it off or was that just *for fun?*"

Lonnie's not pressing on her ribs, but it's difficult to breathe all the same. "It was my job. We helped the police find the children, put the adults in prison. I - she was so young." Adora tightens her jaw so she doesn't cry. She can't tell herself that it was a surprise, anymore. She knew something changed, that year, when Catra got quieter at home and louder at school and angrier everywhere. She knew there was something wrong with the way Weaver moved her around like Catra's body wasn't hers. She knew not to keep going down the stairs when she heard crying. She didn't know what she knew, but she thinks she went to LUNA because part of her needed to do it over, help this time.

"It was awful," Adora says. Lonnie hasn't moved, hand still tight in her shirt. "And Weaver got kids after us, Lonnie, and I don't know for sure but - she had to have hurt them too. People like her don't just stop."

Lonnie flinches back. She lets go of Adora, puts a hand on the back of her own neck and tightens her grip, forearm wire-tense. "Kids?"

Adora has nightmares about them, as best as she can remember their faces from a few moments in a dim room. The worst ones are where she stops a grainy video of screaming, or opens the door of the apartment to a blue and bleeding body. Which girl it is changes every time. Sometimes, inside the dream, she wakes up on the bottom bunk to both of them crawling into her arms, bumping her nose with sleepy clumsy movements, and she tucks them into her chest and says *it's okay,* and when she wakes up she shakes. "Two," Adora says. "I don't know how old but - five or six. Catra told the prosecutor she was five or six."

Lonnie's throat pulses when she swallows. "And you?"

"I-" Adora shakes her head, and when she tastes blood she knows she's bitten through the inside of her lip again. "It wasn't like that. With me. She never - not that."

Lonnie doesn't look convinced, but she moves her hand from her neck to her dreads, twisting one between her fingers. "I used to go blocks out of my way so I wouldn't have to see that place again." Her voice is monotone, cold, familiar. "She came to the drive-thru one day and I made Karli switch with me, spilled milkshake everywhere because I couldn't stop - they gave her *kids* again?"

Adora nods. If she talks she's going to lose the battle to stay calm.

Lonnie digs a knuckle into her temple. "Fuck."

"Yeah."

"I look for her, you know. Catra. I don't see her around town, and that's probably the point, right? But I don't - she looked so bad, that night." Lonnie's breath shudders. "Was sure she was dead when I saw her. Guess she made it, if she's talking to the prosecutor and shit, but. Should've brought her to a hospital or something. I was an idiot."

She was scared, like Adora used to be, like Weaver wanted them. "Catra's in Bright Moon," Adora says. "With me."

Lonnie looks up, eyes searching, and Adora knows the question she doesn't ask.

"She's doing better. She really is. I tried to call you a few times but couldn't get through."

"Had to change my number." Lonnie shrugs, the exhaustion Adora feels on her own shoulders weighing heavy on her. "Bitch kept blowing up my phone. Never gave a shit about me before and then spouting all this bull about how much she loved me. Guess she hoped she could get one warm body back, I don't know."

Lonnie scrubs her hands over her face. "My mom used to say she was glad we didn't have a foster father, you know. She didn't like Weaver, because she was such a colossal bitch about visits, but Mom thought at least she wasn't going to touch any kids."

Razz might have thought that too. Adora doesn't remember talking about Weaver with her, beyond Razz sometimes trying to send stuff home. *Something for that nice lady*, Razz would say, as she handed Adora a book or necklace or cookie. Adora squirreled away what she could in her room to bring back next month, and split the cookie with Catra if she was in her room when she got home. Adora doesn't know if Catra's mom thought that Weaver was safe.

"Knew she'd lose it if I told her, and she was already so worried that if she complained about anything she'd never get us back. Mom told me to just keep my head down, and-" Lonnie sighs long. "That worked out so well."

Weaver wanted something different from all of them. Mostly she wanted Lonnie to keep quiet and stay out of her way, and Lonnie was great at that. Weaver used to complain bitterly about visitation, about how much of her time Lonnie's mom was wasting. *If she wanted you she'd stop shooting up,* Weaver would say, *wish she would just die and be done with it*. Lonnie was good at keeping her mouth shut for that.

The only time Adora really got scared for her was after they got back from court the last time, after Lonnie's mom lost her rights. *Don't know what the face is all about*, Weaver said at dinner. *Not like that junkie even fed you*. Lonnie threw her plate in the trash, smashing at the bottom, and Weaver hit her in the face hard enough to send her to the floor. Her voice was soft when she said *you're going to be here for at least eight more years. I need you to think about how you want those years to go*.

Adora pulled on Catra's hand until it hurt, but Catra didn't move, so Adora couldn't either. Lonnie uncurled her fists and Weaver kissed her head and let her go, and Adora pushed food around

her plate until she was dismissed too. Her hand was locked on Catra's under the table the whole time, because if she let go all the electric tension in the air was going to bolt through her. The next morning, Catra slapped Lonnie over the bruise on her face and said *now I hit you,* and she wasn't at recess later.

Adora tries to remember how she used to make Lonnie feel better, back then. Lonnie didn't cling like Catra did - she folded into herself, brittle, and after her mom lost her rights she didn't talk for almost a week. "I'm sorry," Adora says, "that I wasn't there to help you leave."

Lonnie sniffs. Adora can count on one hand the amount of times she's seen her cry. "Tell Catra that."

"She knows. You needed me too, Lonnie. You shouldn't have had to do that by yourself."

"It fucking sucked." Lonnie puts her hands on her face and half-screams, the kind that can't be heard in the hallway if the bedroom door's closed. "Told my worker I didn't want to go back there, I told him, and he spun all that shit, 'No one likes to be separated and it's temporary and you'll adjust.' Bastard. Could kill him."

"I'll show you how to file a complaint," Adora says. "It's not as good, but it's less messy."

Lonnie starts with surprise, teeth flashing, laugh slipping out through her lips. Adora didn't have much time between classes, and she's probably late for her two o'clock if she hasn't missed it entirely. She doesn't care. "Do you want to come to our place?" Adora asks. "I think Catra might want to see you, I can ask."

Lonnie's laugh is hollow this time. "Catra's never once wanted to see me."

"She's different now. She's-" Adora looks for the words. "She's less mean."

"Low fucking bar." Someone squeals on the walkway in front of the building, high-pitched, excited, reckless in a way Adora's never been. "I gotta go," Lonnie says, slowly, reluctantly.

"You don't have to," Adora says. "I can-"

"I can't talk to her right now." Lonnie tugs at one of her dreads, face unreadable. "I'll see you in court, I guess."

Adora's faster than anyone but Catra, so when Lonnie stands Adora's there. "Can I at least help you get out of here?"

Lonnie lets Adora explain how to get to the bus stop heading southbound from here. She's quiet, a pendulum swing from when words spilled out of her like blood. Lonnie has always been like that. Adora asks for her new phone number and Lonnie smiles tightly and says *I'll see you in April.* "At least take mine," Adora says, heart in her throat.

Lonnie rolls her eyes at her, but she hands over her phone to let Adora put the contact in. She puts Catra's number in too, two of the only numbers she has memorized. Weaver's was the other. Adora doesn't text herself, as much as she wants to. She's trying to stay back when she isn't wanted. She slinks into her class on motor control halfway through the lecture, and she must look as rough as she feels because Dr. Williams doesn't say a word.

When Adora gets home, Catra's asleep after her early shift, Melog curled up behind her knees. Adora can slide in next to her, press her face between Catra's shoulder blades, listen to her murmur as she stirs barely awake. "It's me," Adora says, and Catra hums before she goes quiet again. Adora nudges everything she remembered with Lonnie out of her head, the way Darla wants her to, holding the thoughts and letting them go. She doesn't get them all, but the coal of grief is smaller, with Catra solid and calm next to her blotting out the rest.

Chapter End Notes

"Thought challenging" was referenced - it's a technique in cognitive behavioral therapy to combat distorted thoughts and is notably less effective in someone with a history of experiencing denial and gaslighting, since it relies on trusting your own perceptions and beliefs over the distortions. It's not a waste of time, and they are getting somewhere, but it doesn't work as well as it might otherwise.

Headed to court next week! On that note - the edits that I thought would be minor in the coming chapters are rapidly ballooning (chapter count subject to change), and real life isn't letting me get as much work in on this as I'd like, so I'm going to switch to updating alternating weeks until we hit the end or I have everything revised. Thank you all for bearing with me, your kind words around this complicated mess mean a lot.

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

> Note that I'm not a lawyer or connected to the justice system in any country in any way. I read a lot to research for this and then I ignored many actual facts and procedures in the interests of the narrative, so please don't draw any conclusions about how courts work from this. Etheria's not real so I am making stuff up.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra hasn't been in a courtroom since her mom's parole hearing when she was nine. She only remembered her mother from visits at the prison, then. It was impossible to get to know someone in hour-long meetings a few times a year, and she mostly remembers being hungry and bored and this stranger fussing over her. The attention made her want to crawl out of her skin. Milagros always scribbled on her notepad when Catra rolled her eyes at her mom or ignored her, and Catra didn't know what she was writing and she didn't care. It was always noisy there, so it was easy to tune out the questions. *What's your favorite subject at school? How many friends do you have? Is that lady taking care of you? Talk to me baby girl I love you I miss you-*

The people at the parole board talked for a long time, and she tuned them out too. Camila's lawyer had wanted her there to prove that her mom had a reason not to go back to drugs and the thefts that paid for them. *Look at my baby,* her mom had told the board, while Catra scrunched her toes in Adora's mary janes from Razz's funeral, Lonnie's court dress loose on her shoulders. She hated when her mom called her that. *I've been away from her too long. Please let me be with my girl.*

This courtroom was nothing like the room where the board decided to give her mom another chance. There are so many more people here, maybe a dozen people in suits scattered

through the benches where Rosetti's aide said their friends were allowed to sit. Netossa said it would be a closed courtroom, so random people couldn't just walk in, but it still feels like a crowd. Netossa couldn't be here, but Catra has her number in her phone and a promise that she'll answer no matter what.

"And then I thought, Pellan Park might be fun, after court." Adora fidgets with Catra's hand while she talks, running her fingers down the bones one by one. Her palm is sweaty. "Weather's supposed to be nice."

On Catra's other side, Scorpia hums in agreement. She's idly stroking the head of the cat on Catra's lap, who was now called Wrong Melog after Adora groggily tried to feed it one morning. "They have the coolest little garden there, Perfuma was telling me about how it attracts pollinators-"

"I am not signing up to get stung by bees," Glimmer says behind them.

"I'll defend you with my life, my liege," Bow says, voice soft and teasing, and this is the shit that's going to make Catra lose their mind if they don't finally start dating. She and Adora couldn't possibly have been this bad. "I mean, most bees die after stinging, so they're not usually aggressive if you leave them alone, but if one has gone rogue-"

Weaver's chair is still empty, but there's a man at her table who must be her lawyer, white-blonde hair swept back. Catra doesn't like him already. He keeps looking out over the gallery, like he's trying to find someone, and Catra can't see why it would be anyone but her. Anyone involved in handling evidence has to be pretty familiar with what she looks like, and she's heard enough about how *distinctive* she is. When he finally makes eye contact, she glares at him, and something glints in his eye before he goes back to his notes.

"I could be allergic for all you know," Glimmer says, "and you're just fine potentially sacrificing me for the sake of some flowers."

"They're good flowers." Even without looking, Catra can hear Scorpia smile. "If that helps."

Adora's still fussing, tracing the lines of Catra's palm so light it tickles. Catra closes her hand on Adora's, leans in closer. "We just have to listen today, it's going to be more boring than anything."

Adora's hand squeezes hers. "I know." They both went with Glimmer and Bow to get formal clothes a week ago. Catra has a couple fancy shirts she'll never wear again and a suit jacket that's flimsy armor. *You'll have to wear that on a date sometime*, Glimmer had said, like there was a chance she'd ever look at it again and not think about what she bought it for.

"You can run later." Catra could take or leave the fresh air and whatever, but it's worth it to get to see Adora fly.

Adora shrugs. "If you're up for it. If you'd rather just go back to the hotel-"

"I'll tell you. I know. And that's true for you too."

Adora's making a face like she's going to disagree, and Catra's ready to argue about it until Glimmer or someone backs her up, when a door opens and Weaver comes in, officer on either side. Catra had been imagining her haggard, skin dull, in the orange one-piece her mother always wore in prison. She wanted to see that hollowness in her eyes that Catra always felt when she got out of the basement, but Weaver looks exactly the same. Hair down, long and straight, green eyes sharp. She scans over the gallery and she has that face when she sees Catra, the *wait-until-we-get-home* face that no adult ever seemed to recognize.

Catra's back presses into the bare wood of the bench, and it's like the last two and a half years never happened because she's pinned under that look again. It's stupid because there is no going home with her anymore. Catra has a job, friends, a cat and a girlfriend who loves her in an apartment with no doors she can't unlock, but it feels flat and far away, like she dreamed it one of

the times that she pillowed her head in her hands on the carpet and imagined being somewhere else. Weaver glances to the side when someone speaks to her, and Catra can't look away, can't stop reading the anger hidden in the line of her shoulders, the angle of her neck.

Adora's shoulder is warm against hers, solid, strong. She moves their hands along Wrong Melog's head, and holds out a plastic box on her other palm. Catra blinks twice before she remembers what it is - mints on one side, sour candy on the other. She forgot they'd talked about what Catra wanted to do if she started freezing up. She forgot she'd said she wanted to choose. Her fingers are clumsy as she clicks the box open, makes cold mint spill over her tongue. Adora puts her lips next to Catra's ear, and the whisper on her skin makes Catra shiver in a way she can't work out right now. "She can't hurt us anymore," Adora says, words faint enough to be only for Catra. "That's why she's mad. She knows if she can't hurt anyone she's going to lose."

Bow taps a stress ball on Adora's shoulder. "I brought enough for everyone," he says, "if you want it."

Adora takes one and immediately starts crushing it in her palm. Catra holds hers and wills herself to stay calm enough that she won't throw it while the jury comes in, while the judge talks and talks and talks. She keeps looking back at Weaver, like she'll disappear if Catra doesn't keep an eye on her, like if Catra stops watching her she'll blink to find Weaver inches away from her, nails going tight on her face, *you ungrateful piece of shit, I can't wait until everyone sees how much of a stupid whore you are.*

Adora gasps a little, next to her, and that's what Catra registers before she recognizes the face on the screen as Rosetti finishes setting up. They must have sifted through a dozen of these and *this* was the best they could do - school picture like the rest, eyes mismatched and alien, squinting at someone past the camera, trying not to smile. The list was always alphabetical by last name, so Adora always had her picture taken before her. She liked to make faces to try to make her laugh, the couple years that they

were in the same class, and Catra always did her best to keep a straight face. Might have been kindergarten or first grade, then. She heard Weaver on the phone the summer before second grade, talking about how Catra's behavior was dragging Adora down. *Adora has to compromise enough at home*, she'd said, *she doesn't need further distractions.*

"Ladies and gentlemen, let me tell you a little about this girl," Rosetti says. "Her name is Catra Guerra. She's six years old. Her favorite color is purple and her favorite animal is a lion. She likes running races on the playground with her best friend. She wants to be an equine veterinarian when she grows up."

Catra remembers answering that question, for one of Ms. Bell's projects. She hadn't known what to say because she wasn't going to grow up, but Adora said she wanted to be a horse doctor so Catra said that too. She doesn't know how Rosetti knows. Maybe Catra wouldn't take the paper home and Ms. Bell still had it. Maybe it had slipped behind a dresser and Weaver had forgotten to throw it away, and someone found it when they tore her house apart looking for the mask. Or maybe Weaver kept that piece of paper that said *All About Me*, with Catra's name clumsily printed in the corner, if this was before she pulled her out of bed and decided that she wasn't good for anything else. Sometimes Weaver said there was a chance that Catra could be worth caring about again. Probably she was just trying to keep her quiet and toothless, hypnotized by the possibility that Weaver saw anything good in her.

"She lives in the care of the defendant, Stella Weaver, as she has since the age of two. But by the end of this trial, it will become clear that 'care' is far too generous a word to describe the way the defendant treated this child. You're going to see a lot of this little girl during the next several days, but this will be the last time you see anything resembling a normal childhood. The evidence will demonstrate that the defendant savagely abused this child in every conceivable way for over a decade, doing everything she could to undermine this child's credibility to the adults who should

have saved her. But the defendant wasn't content to brutalize this little girl in the privacy of her own home, ladies and gentlemen."

Netossa called her sometimes to tell her what the police found and what they didn't. They didn't find the original recordings, but they found where the hollow in the wall was plastered over, like Weaver thought she could hide it when they could have calculated the angle the videos were shot from anyway. Catra thinks she knows why Weaver shared them, now. Maybe that was part of Weaver getting rid of her, after she cut her hair. Maybe that's why she didn't care if it wasn't their secret anymore.

"The defendant stole this child's innocence, not once but hundreds of times, and recorded these violations for the gratification of other predators. Evidence of her own making will prove to you that the defendant inflicted sadistic physical, emotional, and sexual torture on this little girl for years, and eventually sought to take her life. Multiple witnesses and official records will outline the history of callous cruelty from the defendant, and the victim herself will describe unthinkable violence enacted upon a defenseless child by the one person entrusted with her safety."

You pathetic thing, the voice in her head says, soft, affectionate. Rosetti wants to make Catra look small and sad and scared, the way Weaver liked her best, because she knows she has to if she wants to win. Rosetti doesn't think the jury will lock Weaver up if they know that Catra bit and spat, that she yelled and threw things, that she was a danger too. They wouldn't feel bad for the monster, so Rosetti has to make this kid someone worth avenging.

This is the story Rosetti's going to try to make her tell, when she has to sit up there. They said she was going to be last, and that must be so the jury sees the whimpering brat when she talks. She doesn't know how she's going to make herself do it. She can't handle the nightmares about a world where she doesn't and they lose, where Weaver puts the camera back and pulls on different little arms, where Catra has to tense at every shadow for the rest of her life.

"The state's job in this case is to prove these charges beyond a reasonable doubt. Your job, as members of the jury, is to evaluate the evidence as it is presented. It is my sincere belief that the facts speak for themselves with horrifying clarity, and for these reasons, the crown will ask you at the end of this trial to find Stella Weaver guilty on all charges. This little girl will never get her life back, but only you can give her something approaching justice."

Her hand shifts and she jolts. It's Adora, fingers still laced in hers, squeezing hard enough to hurt, like she can tether her to earth if she holds hard enough. Catra bites the mint in her mouth so the flavor sharpens enough for her to be able to stay alert. Adora asks, near-silent in her ear, if she needs a break.

"No," Catra grinds between her teeth. Weaver's lawyer's next. She needs to know what their argument is, what he's going to ask Catra when it's her turn to talk. She thinks she knows. *I should tell Adora how awful you are,* Weaver used to say. *I should tell everyone. Then everyone will treat you like the trash you are.* Adora strokes her knuckles with her fingertips, soothing the way she's always been.

The man sitting next to Weaver stands up, hair slick, suit creaseless. The judge introduced him as Thomas Horne. Catra doesn't like the way he studies the jury for a moment before he speaks, like he's seeking out soft places to dig in his blade.

"It is an honor to stand before you today, ladies and gentlemen of the jury. My client, Stella Weaver, has been a loving foster parent for over two decades. In that time she has raised multiple children, giving them everything in her power to live successful adult lives, despite their difficult beginnings. What was not in her power is the mental and emotional instability of a damaged young woman."

She knew something like it was coming and it still echoes in her head. *damaged, damaged, broken little thing-*

"ACA Rosetti has framed a lurid and sensational tale for you, one that even now some of you must be struggling to believe. It captures the imagination, certainly, but it sounds like a tabloid fantasy because it is. No one disagrees that Ms. Guerra's life has been marked by tragedy, like every child who walked through my client's door. But while most children blossom in a nurturing home, Ms. Guerra did not. The evidence will show that, like some neglected by drug-addicted mothers, she never developed the capacity to love others and accept it in return. People with attachment problems are highly manipulative, vindictive, and especially malicious to those who they can't bend to their will, and the facts will show that Ms. Guerra is all of those things.

"Over the course of this trial, it will become clear that the outlandish claims against my client are a symptom of this condition. It will become obvious to you why the prosecution leans so heavily on video footage that, while sickening, cannot be linked to my client by anyone but the supposed victim - because no other evidence of this alleged mistreatment exists. At its core, the crown's case will ask you to ignore anything that proves that my client is the dedicated, hardworking parent she was, and to instead blindly cave to the accusations of a woman who, the evidence will show, is deeply disturbed."

She jumps when something touches her arm. She looks down to see Scorpia's hand on her sleeve. The stress ball in her left hand is gouged deep, blue chunks wedged under the slivers of her nails. Marks gash into the foam. Her hand spasms on it again, fingers digging in deeper, and her hand will probably hurt later like it did when she spent all day tearing up a notebook but it doesn't now. Scorpia reaches for her hand, but when Catra stills reflexively, Scorpia stops. Catra blinks like that will help.

"The crown will tell you many horrible things, and they will expect you to take Ms. Guerra's word that my client is responsible. They have a long list of allegations, of which they would like you to find my client guilty and condemn her to prison for the rest of her life. What the law demands from you, ladies and gentlemen of the jury, is to consider the reasonable doubt. I ask you to see past the

emotional language and graphic images that attempt to prop up the crown's case. Ms. Guerra has successfully poisoned a number of people against my client, despite the dearth of evidence. Don't let her fool you too."

It's being back in high school all over again. *That girl's crazy*, people said in the hallways, and Catra liked that, after a while, because people stayed away from her. All she had to do was snap her teeth to keep it that way. *Something's wrong with her*, people said, and they were right. She wound up in the vice principal's office so many times, and Mr. Hendricks always told her to stop making trouble, and she didn't bother protesting the handful of times that someone shoved her against the lockers, or dared each other to knock her books out of her hands, or said *feisty bitch, bet she fucks like a beast.* She didn't always start it, but she always ended it, and that's all that mattered.

Weaver would come and tell the other adults *I'm so sorry about this, I'm doing everything I can, I'm glad we're a team,* just like she had for Catra's whole life, and Catra would kick her heel against the chair leg even after Weaver told her to stop because what was the fucking point if she was going to have to gasp for breath later regardless. *Why can't you be like this all the time,* Weaver would say when Catra was limp and disappearing, *so much better this way,* and Catra wished she could be.

The judge is talking again. "What bullshit," Glimmer hisses to Bow behind her, just barely loud enough for Catra to hear. Adora stands up, and Catra follows because she doesn't think she could pry her fingers off of Adora's hand if she tried and because she doesn't want to be anywhere that Adora isn't, because Adora's the only person on earth who doesn't think she's crazy and feral and should just be put down before she hurts somebody.

The hallway is empty when Adora eases the foam away from her. "They're desperate," Adora says. Her hands come firm down Catra's arms, trying to do the pressure thing Emily thinks will help. It's hard to keep track of stuff right now, hard to feel much of

anything. "No one's going to buy that, they have to know it'll never work."

Catra swallows, and she can feel that, at least. "I said I didn't need a break."

"I know." Adora breathes out hard, inhales, holds it, and Catra can see the counts playing out in her head. She's supposed to do the same thing, when she gets upset. "I just - I know it's his job to say she's not guilty, and that means he has to say we're lying, but I'm so sick of hearing anyone talk about you that way when it isn't true. You're not a bad person, you never have been."

You think I don't see you? You think I don't know what you're doing, you little parasite? You can lie to everyone else but not to me. Catra wrings the words out. "Everyone thinks that for a reason."

Adora cups the back of her skull and rests her forehead on hers, hair tickling, skin warm, noses brushing. "Not everyone."

Catra's supposed to look for proof of why her angry thoughts are wrong, when she gets like this. Glimmer with a sparring bag, Entrapta holding out a mini muffin, Bow on the range in the early morning. Scorpia sitting next to her on the step, Fujimura talking quietly to a detective, Camila saying *I love you, I'm sorry.* If she keeps doing Emily's thought exercise she's going to collapse in the hallway. "Okay," she hears herself say, and when Adora exhales with relief she can feel it. "Not everyone."

Adora's breath is warm on her lips, inches away. "He's trying to say you can't love? *You?*"

Catra can't untangle everything she feels right now, but the big glowing thread in the middle is familiar. She can almost feel Adora's lips under hers again, and how much she wants it tugs under her ribs. She doesn't know if her stupid body can handle that, right now, so she slides her arms around Adora's back and puts her head on her shoulder instead, so she won't try.

"You're not poison," Adora says, stroking the back of her head. Catra could stay there forever. "And you're not broken either. You're Catra and you're *amazing* and I'm going to keep saying that until you believe me."

Some days she does. Some days she wakes up and it's easier to at least imagine why Adora likes her. She knows the ordering codes better than anyone else at work, she always knows when Melog isn't feeling well, she can stretch their budget until she manages to fit what they need to survive in it. Some days she even glimpses her face in a reflection and doesn't feel sick. It's not all the time, not even most of the time, but now on a bad day she can remember that she has good ones, sometimes.

"I do," she says, and it feels close enough to the truth, right now. "I believe you."

Adora's never been in a courthouse before. Weaver had court dates every six months for each of them, and she always came back irritated. *Waste of my time*, she used to say, slamming the oven door when she put in the casserole dish. *Because I don't have enough to deal with already.*

Lonnie described court as having to sit with nothing to do for hours while strangers talk - *super boring*, she'd said - but Adora feels like she has too much to do. She's trying to pay attention while the forensic technicians talk, and she's constantly aware of whether Catra is listening too or if she's starting to zone out. She keeps looking at Weaver, even though she doesn't want to. She can't really see her from here, not her face. While the technician talks about facial recognition results, Adora can't tell if Weaver is hurt or angry. She doesn't know which would be worse. She doesn't want to care either way.

When the judge lets everyone go for lunch, Rosetti's aide leads them all to a room with a table and a couch and a television. He says someone will bring them food. Bow and Glimmer start talking to Scorpia about other good things to do in Thaymor, and Catra burrows into Adora's side with her book of number puzzles, and Adora tries to focus on the book she brought with her but she can't stop jittering. Catra shifts so she's pressing down on Adora's jumping knee, but Adora doesn't want to be calm so she can wait. She's so tired of quietly waiting for things to be over.

She slides out from under Catra. "He said there were vending machines around here, right? I'm going to go get water."

She has one cold in her hand and she's debating how many she's able to buy at the ridiculous vending machine price when a voice behind her says, "Ms. Castillo." It's oil-slick, and she recognizes it immediately. "Do you have a moment?"

Adora locks her face polite when she turns around. "No," she says, with more confidence than she has. She steps one foot back, so she has a stronger base of support if she needs it. Horne's still several feet away, hands at his sides, slightly out as if to demonstrate that they're empty. But this is a quiet corner of the courthouse, and he works for Weaver, so her body snaps into the kind of focus she gets on the field, or when tension builds in a room. "People are waiting for me."

"Just a moment," he says. "My apologies for alarming you. I was asked to pass something along."

There's nothing Weaver is going to say that Adora wants to hear. She's manipulative, sick, dangerous, and Adora should walk past Horne instead of pausing. She should go back to the witness room with the people she loves, who love her despite her mistakes, instead of making another one.

"Stella's heartbroken about what happened when you last saw each other," Horne says, face gentle. "She's tried to call you, but she says it isn't going through."

Weaver wants to try to paint over everything as quietly as she plastered over the hole in the wall downstairs, like it had never been there. She wants to make Adora feel guilty and small like she always has, make her shove all this into the box that held it for years.

Adora says, "I have no interest in speaking to her, for any reason."

"She's worried about you. She wanted me to ask you if you're doing okay."

Tell me how you're doing, Weaver would say sometimes, hand on her knee, green eyes full. It was always when the other girls weren't there. Adora would tell her the grade she got, the play she made, and Weaver would say *my Adora, so perfect,* and her heart would beat too fast but it wasn't like when she was panicking. That was because she was happy. Or that's what she thought. She isn't sure, now.

Adora says, "Her chance to show whether or not she cares about me is long gone."

"Stella tells me that she misses you," Horne says. "She hopes you can be a family again."

They never were a family. Adora didn't realize that, at the time, because Weaver said they were, and she didn't know any better. Weaver called Adora her daughter, when she talked to the kids that night, but she can't possibly know what being a parent is supposed to mean. Angella and Glimmer aren't like they were. *Moms aren't supposed to be scary,* Lonnie said on the bus to school, a few weeks after she moved back in, after screaming kept them up late. *Even when mine was using, she wasn't never like that.*

Bow's the only person who's ever told Adora that they have problems with their parents, and he was really frightened to talk to them about changing his major and everything. Adora and Glimmer were together when he called, after talking to them, and

Adora could hear him over the phone, close to tears. *They said they supported me in whatever I wanted to do. They said they were sorry that I didn't feel like I could trust them.* Glimmer told him that she was really happy for him, and Adora tried to imagine what that would even be like to hear from Weaver. She gave up quickly. Her active imagination isn't that good.

Adora sets her jaw. "That's never going to happen. She'll go to prison and she'll rot there."

Horne shifts his shoe against the floor. "She's said aggression isn't like you. She's… concerned, about the company you're keeping."

"Tell her to go to hell," Adora says, heat rising in her cheeks. Of course Weaver was going to know she and Catra were together. It's part of what Adora's supposed to talk about when she testifies, it's not a secret. She's long past caring what Weaver thinks about that. "She doesn't control me anymore, and you can tell her that before you fuck off too. She doesn't want to know what I'll do if I see her outside of a courtroom again."

The corner of Horne's lip twitches. Light catches in his white-blonde hair, blinding as snow. "Tread lightly, Ms. Castillo. I would hate for you to be detained when your testimony is so important to the case. Violence doesn't suit you."

"You don't know me," Adora snaps, before she forces her shoulders down. Her next words are calmer. "Neither does *your client*. She never wanted to. She's never cared about anyone other than herself."

"Stella loves you very much," Horne says. "She wants you to know that."

That's what it's always been about, what Weaver wants. Weaver doesn't love Adora. She loves the little puppet she made, that she formed in her head and then molded Adora into. Weaver wanted her to play sports, wanted her to get As, wanted her to be compliant and easy and gullible, and Adora was all of those

things, and it still wasn't enough. It was never going to be enough as long as any part of Adora existed underneath.

"She doesn't know how," Adora says, and it scrapes in her throat. "She can tell herself whatever she wants, but I know her too well."

"She didn't press charges after you assaulted her," Horne says. "I have the pictures of the bruise you left on her. An athlete in her prime attacking an older woman? I don't think a judge would look kindly on that, would they?"

"She can't *threaten* me now. She can't do anything to me anymore."

"It's not a threat." Horne takes a step forward, and Adora very deliberately doesn't step backwards. "I'm merely trying to impress upon you that she could have had you arrested, but she didn't, because she's always putting you first."

Earlier in court, the forensic expert was talking about how they looked over the house with a fine-toothed comb. When they sprayed the basement room looking for blood, the walls lit up under the new paint, fist-sized spots that inched up the wall as the person making the stains got bigger. "If she wanted what was best for me she would've kept her fucking hands to herself. The only reason why she didn't call the cops was to give herself enough time to bury all the evidence she could."

"Alleged-"

"You know she did it, she put it *on tape*-"

"You're not under oath, you can drop the act. If I were you, I would hope that your girlfriend is a better liar than you are. Is that why you chose her for this little charade? The eyes are a nice touch but must have been difficult to track down. Surely it would have been easier to find something with a little blonde-"

The water bottle bursts when it hits the ground, spraying water around them, and the bang makes Adora jump before she forces herself still. Horne steps back, eyebrows raised, dark spots on his light suit where water splashed up onto him. Adora can barely feel where her terrible new shoes are soaked through by the puddle around her feet.

"Get away from me," Adora says, buzz in her ears, "before you learn how well violence suits me."

"Noted," Horne says, but he doesn't look intimidated. There's victory in the corner of his eyes, the edge of his lips. It doesn't fade even when Adora shoves past him.

She wasn't able to eat this morning as it was, so her retches in the women's bathroom are empty. She squeezes out her shoes, floppy and thin, presses them with paper towels to dry them. If she pushes down with all her strength, her shoulders burn loud enough to drown out the crawl on her spine.

Darla says feeling something doesn't make it true, but maybe she is crazy, this time. Maybe that's why she's thinking about Weaver helping her stretch, when she was first starting field hockey after school. Adora hadn't thought it was strange until her coach walked them through a set and only corrected with words, and the next time Weaver's hand lingered on her hip even longer and Adora pushed the uneasiness away, because she was being too sensitive. Because if Ms. Weaver was actually hurting her, she'd be yelling instead of smiling and telling Adora she was doing so well, and she hated when Adora acted like she was in danger when she wasn't, so Adora smiled back.

Catra snuck into her bed later and huddled hollow against her chest, quiet the way she always was when she crawled in, and Adora looked at the bruises that disappeared under her shirt collar and reminded herself that bad things only happen to bad kids, and Adora wasn't one of them. Whatever that was while she'd stretched wasn't even *bad*, really, and she'd never told Ms. Weaver that she didn't have to correct her form that much, so Ms.

Weaver couldn't have known if it bothered her. Which it hadn't. Because it was fine.

And now Adora's a decade older and all it takes is a few words from someone she already hates and she's worrying about something that doesn't make sense. They weren't in the room with the camera in the wall, and it wasn't something anyone would care about seeing anyway, so why did what he said make her grit her teeth so hard?

Her shoes slap loud and wet on the floor. Adora probably should have told one of the guards about the water, someone could slip. She doesn't want to go back to the machine. She doesn't want to go back to the witness room either, full of people who will know she's upset, but if she doesn't know where Horne or Weaver are, she needs to be with Catra. Being with her is always how she's known Catra's safe.

She runs into Scorpia, almost literally because she isn't focused and she's going to get cornered again and she doesn't realize she's apologizing until Scorpia says, "You're good, I was distracted. I was looking for you, the sandwiches came and-" Scorpia stops as she finishes scanning over her and Adora wants to puke again, or hide, for no reason. "What happened?"

"Water spilled," Adora says, brain scrambling. "Machine must have been defective, the bottles broke as soon as I took them out."

"Okay," Scorpia says slowly. She frowns, because Adora's only a good enough liar to fool herself. "Do you need help? Drying off?"

"I thought I-"

Her shoes are still wet because several inches at the bottom of her pants are soaked. Adora missed the droplets trickling down her calf, somehow. "Oh," Adora says. Tears are tight in her throat but she sounds flat instead.

Scorpia holds Adora's shoes under a hand dryer while Adora squeezes her pants with wads of paper towels. She has to keep

doing her cycles of breathing so she doesn't cry. She thinks it's working until Scorpia says, "It's okay if you're having a hard time. I mean. Everything about this is awful. I don't think anyone's having a great day."

Adora bites the inside of her lip, and she has to focus on not making it bleed. "The trial's a good thing," she says, when she can. It's like a tough run, or a new training day, or anything else Adora's ever needed to push through. Everything will be better, after, when Weaver's in prison and Adora never has to think about her ever again so she never has to feel like this ever again. "We waited so long to get here."

"Yeah," Scorpia says, "but that doesn't mean it doesn't suck. You care about Catra, of course it sucks. It's hard for *me* and you're about a million times closer to all of this. I don't think Catra expects you to be a rock all the time."

What Catra might find acceptable doesn't matter. Catra's been willing to settle for plenty of things she shouldn't have to, and having to deal with Adora is the last thing she needs while the court argues about what kind of broken they think she is. Adora doesn't even have anything to be upset about, but Lonnie and Horne put a picture of herself in her head and it's making her crazy.

Look at you, my beautiful girl, Weaver said, thumb stroking across her cheekbone. *Not everyone is strong enough to love you. Your mother wasn't, but I am, and I always will.*

"I'm okay," she says, lie slipping out before she's even realized she's done it, because Scorpia isn't one of the people she promised not to say that anymore. "I'm just tired."

Scorpia keeps frowning, and Adora needs to stop whatever gears are turning in her head. "You knew something was wrong with Catra, at school," Adora says. "How did you know?"

Scorpia's eyebrows jump. "Um, a bunch of things just came together for me, I guess. She moved weird some days, and she'd be, you know, angrier or kind of - out of it. And she'd say she was fighting but I saw the thing freshman year, in the cafeteria, so I knew how she fought, and I couldn't figure out how anyone was getting these bad hits on her. And her hands sometimes didn't look like they'd been hitting somebody. And you were so protective before you graduated, and Catra sounded so weird when she'd try to explain why she'd been out of school and - I don't know. I guess some part of me put the pieces together."

Adora wants to ask if Scorpia can see the hands on Adora too, if she's like the dust that police use on TV to find fingerprints. There's no way to string those words together and it's way too insane to do anyway. She swallows but the lump in her throat won't go away. Darla tells her to thank people when she wants to apologize. "Thank you," she says, "for helping her when I didn't."

Scorpia shrugs, face scrunching in an expression Adora can't quite make sense of. "I mean. You had reasons, at the time. I'm not still mad about it, if that's what you're thinking. Catra says your foster mom kinda messed with your head too, which I guess she had to, to get away with shit." Scorpia shakes her head, as if to clear it. "Sorry. I ramble. Do you need a hug? I hear I'm good at those."

Scorpia is good at it, embrace firm and enveloping. Adora wants to dissolve into it. Scorpia remembers to get more water before they go back, and they find a different vending machine. Someone with a mop is heading towards the other one, so probably no one's going to break a hip over Adora's little tantrum, and when Scorpia hands her bottles, she pours what focus she can into the cold. Catra says stuff like that helps her. It doesn't do much for Adora, but Catra's always been better than her, whether Adora knew it at the time or not.

Empty plates scatter on the table. Glimmer and Bow and Catra are sitting on the floor, tossing stress balls into an empty wire trash can. "Adora, get over here," Catra says, grinning before she looks up. "We need someone else who aims for a living."

Adora drops down on the floor next to her, and smiles, and takes the ball Bow puts in her hand. It's about the size of a field hockey ball, not that she ever threw those. She doesn't know if this is the one she crushed while the forensic analyst said that he couldn't confirm who was behind the mask. Glimmer's trying to explain something but it already sounds too complicated to care about, so she throws instead of trying to think, and she hits the side hard enough to knock the basket over.

"And that's three points to me," Glimmer says. The victory in her voice sounds plastic. When Adora looks over, Scorpia's looking at her from the table, but she doesn't say anything.

"Come on," Catra says. "That rule was stupid anyway and you know it. You just don't want to admit that my girlfriend has a stronger throwing arm than you."

Bow says something then, and Glimmer replies, and Adora lets go of the threads of the conversation when she realizes she's too tired to care. Catra clings into her side again and Adora scoops up the heavy lead in her chest and tucks it away where it belongs, because Catra's okay right now and that's all she wants to care about. Darla said she might have to compartmentalize more, to deal with the trial, so it's okay. They'll have time to deal with things that matter later.

She's been telling herself that she wants to have a conversation about sex after all of this. When she doesn't have formless nightmares about small arms reaching for her, she wakes up with the dream sensation of Mermista's lips on her thighs. It's better than six months ago, when she'd snap awake to Catra's arms on her waist and she had to pull herself out of bed and shower and repeat to herself that she isn't dangerous and she's not going to hurt anyone, and she believes that now, mostly. Catra's made it clear that she trusts her, and when she said she wasn't ready, the *yet* was implied. Darla says that's something they're allowed to talk about, and she talks about all of their *options* even if Catra's never ready, or never wants to be. Darla says that Adora's allowed

to have needs of her own, and Adora always wonders if that's how Weaver thought about it too.

You always know what I need, Weaver said, smiling, one hand stroking over her hair while the other held the cloth to her arm, where Catra's nails had gouged deep. *I don't know what I would do without you, child.*

A finger taps her forehead and she jumps. "You and that hamster wheel brain," Catra says, affectionate, worry around the edges, and Adora forces the tension out of her shoulders. She's supposed to make things easy for Catra right now. She has one job and she can never seem to manage it.

Catra tugs her bag over by the strap and pulls out the plastic bottle Adora makes her shakes in, wire ball rolling in powder at the bottom. She only reaches far enough away to grab water before she glues herself to Adora's side again. Adora wants to force down one of the sandwiches on the table so she doesn't need it.

"I didn't know you brought that," Adora says instead.

Catra rolls her eyes. The powder darkens at the bottom when she pours the water in. "It's almost like I don't want my girlfriend to starve." She doesn't sound mad, though. She sounds the way Scorpia's hug felt.

You look after Catra, Darla says sometimes. *And she looks after you. That's what a partnership is. She wants to help you as much as you want to help her. It's okay to let her.*

Catra hands her the bottle, bubbles frothing at the top. Glimmer and Bow are explaining the rules to the game to Scorpia, and they seem weirdly extensive. Adora makes herself look at Catra's face. "We'll talk later," she says, and it feels like a promise. "After the trial's over, okay? I can't right now, but I - I want to talk to you."

Something changes in Catra's face, and when Adora looks for disappointment, or frustration, or disgust, she can't find them.

"Yeah," Catra says. "Thanks for telling me how I can help, princess."

The shake is as sweet and artificial as always, and Adora finishes it in long sips while Glimmer explains the rules of the game to Scorpia while Bow tosses the balls one after another, like he's trying to burn off something too. Bow beats them both, and then Adora beats him. Catra tells Glimmer, "Suck it, Sparkles, mine's better," and Adora smiles for real.

She repeats that moment to herself when they're back in court later, while Horne tries to make the technician say that the bloodstains on the walls could have been something else. She catches Weaver looking back at her, and she glares back with all the fire she has. The echo in her head says *my Adora,* and she wants her face to say *never. Never yours.*

Chapter End Notes

> You'll note there are two more chapters planned now! Thank you for bearing with the altered schedule. This is important enough to me that I want to be able to take the time to do it right. Take care ❤️

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

> Reminder that I am not a lawyer or involved in the legal field in any country and there is only so much I can learn from reading articles on the internet. If you are looking for a detailed and accurate courtroom drama, this is not going to be it. (This premise has been legally flawed from literally the first page, there's no universe in which Adora would have been hired to work at LUNA in the role she had, I've meddled with a lot of legal shit already to tell the story I wanted to tell.) Thank you for understanding.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When the bailiff brings Lonnie into the courtroom, Catra shouldn't be surprised. Catra hasn't seen Lonnie since she tied Catra's shoes when her hands didn't work right. Thinking of having to testify herself is the part that has been making Catra stay awake in bed, running through all the ways it could go wrong, until Adora shifts against her back and she remembers how to calm down. Lonnie looks bored, staring at the podium while she says her name in a flat voice. Her dreads are dull under the lights.

Adora's hand kneads hers. Adora's jittering out of her skin, has been all day, and everything Catra knows to help isn't working. The moment she opens her mouth about it is the moment that Adora's going to shut down worse and Catra doesn't know if either of them can manage to not fight about it, with how exhausted they are. She doesn't want to yell at Adora to *fucking stop it, stop insisting that everyone else's problems are worse, stop pretending you're fine when we both know you're not, not trusting each other is how we got here,* but the words are all clustered at the end of her tongue and it will take nothing to let them out.

Rosetti clicks to put an image on the wall monitor. Grainy, blurry, pixelated on the large screen. A child on the floor looking up, green shirt wrinkled, asymmetrical eyes obvious and pleading. The air conditioner rushes almost as loud as Catra's blood in her ears.

"Do you recognize this child?" Rosetti asks Lonnie.

Lonnie doesn't even look up. "Catra Guerra. My, uh, foster sister. We shared a room."

When they were eight and Lonnie moved back in, Adora had to sleep in her own room for the first time. Catra woke up in a panic that night, soaked in more than sweat, freezing, and when Lonnie blinked at her over the edge of the bed she wanted to fall through the ground until she got deep enough to never be found again. Adora always helped her tug the sheets off her mattress, hugged Catra once she got cleaned up, and pretended it hadn't happened in the morning. Adora wasn't there and it was Lonnie's fault.

Lonnie asked if she was okay, if she could help, and Catra told her it was none of her damn business. When Adora came down the next morning and sat next to Lonnie instead of her, Catra spilled milk down Lonnie's borrowed shirt so she'd have to get up. It was worth the *wasteful brat* and smack to the back of her head when Weaver caught her wiping the floor.

"How do you know the defendant?" Rosetti asks.

Lonnie's mouth tenses before she answers. "I lived with her for twelve years, on and off."

Rosetti asks about when they were kids, first. Lonnie answers in dry sentences. *Hit her, locked her in the basement, said she was going to kill her.* Lonnie sounds like she's just managing not to tack *ma'am* at the end the way she used to at school. Catra doesn't know how she's going to stop from looking at Weaver, when it's her turn to sit up there, but Lonnie keeps her eyes on the same spot on the wood in front of her, eyes shifting slightly

like she's following the grain. Her yellow shirt is stark against her skin, and Catra wonders where she got it, where she's been since Catra saw her last. *She hit me once, knocked me down, said I had to think about how I wanted the rest of my time there to go, and I never talked back again.*

Rosetti says, "Did you ever observe sexually inappropriate behavior from the defendant?"

Something ripples under Lonnie's expression, but it's gone before Catra can put it together. "I didn't like the way Weaver looked at her," she says, and there's a note in her voice Catra's never heard before. "It wasn't normal. She wasn't like that, with me. She made it pretty clear that I was there for the money and nothing else, that I'd be fine if I kept my head down, but she was weird about, um, her. Possessive, controlling. Not the way my mom ever was."

It had been a secret, just Weaver and her, so no one else had to know what Catra was, so no one else would look at her with the mixture of anger and disgust that Weaver did. It was supposed to be, anyway, before Weaver sent the videos around. But now Catra knows that has never been true.

"Got her out of bed a lot," Lonnie says. "That last night, when I saw her, I was pretty sure she'd been ra - sexually assaulted."

Glimmer whispers something furiously behind her. Adora said she doesn't like that they have to change the word. Catra never wants to hear it again for the rest of her life, so she can't bring herself to be upset.

Rosetti says. "Can you explain to the jury what you remember from the early hours of November 18th?"

Lonnie's face sets again, and she monotones through the story - getting home from work, seeing Catra's homework scattered, getting the key from the crevice where Weaver hid it. "I turned on the light," she says, and stops. The room is quiet, thick with listening. Lonnie still hasn't looked up, chest heaving, lips tight.

Rosetti asks Lonnie if she needs a break, and she shakes her head. "I turned it back off," she says, quiet enough that Rosetti makes her repeat it. "Because if I screamed, Weaver was gonna wake up and - I'd never seen nothing like that. I'd seen Catra in rough shape before, but not like that."

You're fucked up right now, Lonnie said that night. *I don't think you even know how fucked up.* The picture she paints of Catra's injuries is close to what Catra remembers finding in the morning. Scorpia had hovered, when she woke up, and Catra's voice had rasped when she tried to tell her she could handle a shower by herself. She hadn't looked at the bruises and dried blood smeared under her clothes, just ran the shower as hot as it would go and cleaned up the mechanical way she always did. When aching and dizziness drove her to the floor, she sat and watched pink-tinged water run down the drain.

She didn't look in the mirror that day, wouldn't for months. She's never liked to have to see herself, and she could feel enough of her hair to know that she had to look hideous, ruined, and she wouldn't look like herself again for years. That morning, she didn't want to live for years. She shoved the hat back over the scabs and didn't tell Scorpia to fuck off when she made sad eyes at her, because if she pushed Scorpia away too hard she'd have to leave. She stared down the water Scorpia shoved in her hands and told herself this was only until she was strong enough to get herself close enough to a busy road, so Scorpia wouldn't be repaid with having to deal with Catra's corpse on her kitchen floor.

Her scalp stings when Lonnie describes how alien she looked, naked and beaten and staring. No wonder Lonnie thought she was insane for thinking Scorpia would have wanted her that night, no wonder Scorpia wouldn't kiss her after seeing that thing. It's a fucking miracle Adora did. Next to her, Adora's throat bobs, and Catra knows exactly what she looks like when she's trying not to cry. Adora stiffens for a second when Catra presses her shoulder against hers, before leaning back. Adora's always seen more in Catra than she can see in herself.

"Shit," Scorpia hisses next to her as Lonnie talks, and when Catra looks her face is scrunched up. There's none of the disgust Catra feels on her face. Instead, she looks like when Catra's words get too sharp. Scorpia must feel her looking because she turns her head, and Catra can't meet how much is in her eyes right now. Scorpia's hand hovers over Wrong Melog's head, and she only pets it when Catra nods.

"Thought she was dead," Lonnie says, and her voice wavers badly enough for anyone to recognize. She presses her fist to her mouth for a moment before she says, "Put my, uh sweatshirt over her. Didn't want no one else to see her like that."

"In that moment," Rosetti asks, gentle, "did you think about calling the police?"

"I woulda had to," Lonnie says. She clears her throat, but it doesn't take the thickness out of her voice. "If she was really dead. I would've wanted her to - to get buried proper, and Weaver used to say she was gonna dump her body in the woods to rot, I wouldn't've - wouldn't've let that happen. I just - all I could think was Weaver finally did it, been saying for years she was gonna kill her and she finally did and it was my-" She pinches her lips, blinks. "I tried to get her to leave, before this, but she didn't listen, and I just. I shoulda talked her into it. We just - we didn't get along, she didn't like me."

"When did you realize Catra was still alive?"

"I knelt down next to her so I could, um, take the belt off her neck. I know it - the police said it would've destroyed evidence, if they'd been there. But I didn't think about that. I just thought - I didn't want-"

Lonnie's crying for real now. Her hand is on her face but her whole body shakes and the microphone can pick up the quiet sounds. Catra had never seen Lonnie cry about her before. Lonnie never comforted her when she ached like Adora did. Lonnie told her to hurry up when she moved slow and sore, asked *the fuck*

did you do? when she saw bruises and burns, struck for them to end a fight. Adora looked away when Weaver slapped Catra at the dinner table, but Lonnie watched, face blank. Lonnie had cried about her mom, her siblings, people she cared about, but Catra hadn't been one of them.

You're okay, Lonnie said, when Catra wasn't even conscious enough to know it was her. *You're going to be okay.* She threatened Scorpia not to touch her. They were in the same algebra class sophomore year, and Lonnie always forgot her folder of graded problem sheets on the floor of their room when Catra had missed days of class and had a pile of assignments to finish. When Catra was much younger, she would come out of the basement and find packets from school lunch hidden in Lonnie's drawers, and they'd argue about Catra stealing them, and then the next time more would be in the same place.

"Ms. Davis needs a recess," Rosetti says.

"She'd been through enough," Lonnie manages. "Didn't want her to have to hurt anymore."

After Lonnie leaves, Catra gives Wrong Melog to Scorpia to hold, because Adora turns in her seat to hug her, face tacky where tears escaped anyway. Catra clings back, something wrenching in her chest. Adora's hair smells like the lavender in the hotel shampoo. "I love you so much," Adora says into her ear. "I'm so grateful you're here."

Catra turns them a little, so Weaver won't be able to see Adora if she looks back at them. "Me too," she says.

Lonnie comes back, eyes red, and Scorpia makes Wrong Melog boop Catra's arm when she gives it back.

"I know this is emotional for you," Rosetti says, and Lonnie nods tight. She still hasn't looked at anyone in the room. "Can you tell us what happened next?"

Lonnie says, "She was warm, and I realized she was breathing, and I had to get her out of there. Both of us out of there. I was the only person who could help her and if I didn't, I was scared Weaver was gonna finish the job later."

"Had you ever reported the abuse before?"

"When we were kids. Nobody cared, they didn't listen to me. Weaver locked me in my room and told me to consider my choices, Catra got hurt worse and hated me, it didn't fix anything."

"What did you believe would have happened if you had called the police on November 18th?"

"Thought Weaver would get out of it. Thought she'd get to Catra again and get to me and-" Lonnie exhales long, harsh. "Maybe it was stupid, but I just - I couldn't think about anything else but getting Catra out of there."

Lonnie shoved clothes in Catra's bag, wiped her face. "She woke up while I was helping her get dressed," Lonnie says, "all confused. Her scalp was already bleeding and I didn't want to mess with it too much, but I think she got hit in the head. And her voice didn't sound right, she couldn't say a lot, I figured because her throat was hurt. But she was talking, and she could move a little, and I knew if I even said anything about a hospital she might not go with me. She said she knew someone who could pick her up, and I thought maybe they could talk her into it. I just wanted to get her out."

"In your initial police report you said this friend's name was Scorpia Tanno, right?"

Scorpia shifts next to Catra. "Yes," Lonnie says, picking at something under the wood of the stand. "I only met her that night. I didn't know anything about her, but Catra trusted her. Enough, anyway. I don't think she was, uh, thinking straight. I went with 'em, tried to make sure she was gonna be safe there."

She clears her throat again. "Then I, um, I went to my mom's place."

"I think the jury might be wondering," Rosetti says, voice gentle, "why you wouldn't go to your mother for help earlier, if you were aware of the abuse escalating. Could you explain that?"

Lonnie's head jerks a little, like she wants to shake it. "She - she had a heroin problem, when I was a kid. That's why I was in foster care, um, because she - couldn't take care of us, then."

"Us?"

"My sisters and me. And my, my brother but he never lived with us, he was removed at birth. She's clean now, has been for almost six years. I love her but-" Lonnie grimaces, quick before it disappears. "I didn't want to bother my mom," Lonnie finally says. "She doesn't have a lot."

"What did you tell your mother on November 18th?"

"Told her I needed somewhere for a few days. It just, uh, it turned into a couple years, now. There's not really room, for me, but I can't afford anywhere else."

"What did you tell her about why you needed somewhere to stay?"

"Nothing," Lonnie says, quiet. "She feels really bad, about how things happened, and I just - I knew she'd be upset. And I didn't want to talk about it. She kind of assumed Weaver had thrown me out and I didn't correct her."

"Did you consider leaving the defendant's house any other way?"

Lonnie's shoulders twitch. "We didn't have anything, I, um. I applied for a housing program but I hadn't gotten it yet, I was saving up for a deposit, Catra was still in school and Weaver wouldn't let her get a job, it-" She stops, blinks at that same spot on the stand in front of her. "I could stay out of the way, most of

the time," Lonnie says. "I thought if Catra was just - more careful not to set her off, we'd make it. Clearly, it didn't work."

Rosetti smiles when she says she has no more questions. Lonnie rubs her forehead like it hurts, eyes still red. Catra can feel the exhaustion like it's in her own body. Horne stands up, walks up to Lonnie. Lonnie doesn't look at him, the way she hasn't looked up this entire time.

"Ms. Davis," he says, "you were eighteen when you left Stella Weaver's home, weren't you?"

"Yes," Lonnie says. Her voice has flattened again.

"So you were legally an adult, right?"

"Legally."

"You held down a job and went to visit your mother on a regular basis, didn't you?"

"Yes."

"And Ms. Guerra went to school?"

"When she was allowed to, yeah."

"Legally, Stella wasn't even required to care for you anymore, correct?"

"I don't know why she didn't kick me out when she could've." Lonnie says, eyes hardening. "I don't want to know what's going on in her head."

"She was your foster mother for twelve years, right?"

"Yeah."

"And during all those years you allege that she struck you once?"

Lonnie nods. "I broke something and she lost it."

"You didn't report that to anyone, right? We're supposed to take your word for it?"

"I'd just lost any legal relationship with my mom, I was ten, I was scared." Lonnie says, tense, "I saw how opening my mouth went."

"You're referring to the statement you made to a school staff member the previous spring, correct?"

"Yeah," Lonnie says. "Catra's hands were all red and blisters and peeling, she didn't do that to herself."

"But Ms. Guerra did injure herself as a child and adolescent, didn't she?"

Catra's hands ached across the knuckles, where they used to hit the wall. When Horne talked to the technician who found where she'd punched until they bled, he said all that indicated was that Catra was violent and unstable. She used to press on bruises until her ears buzzed, sometimes, but Horne doesn't mean that. He means what Milagros used to write to explain why Catra had marks on her.

"Not like that," Lonnie snaps. "She didn't boil herself or whatever actually happened, we were nine."

"According to official records, Ms. Guerra told her social worker that she had spilled bleach while trying to cover up a mess she'd made and hadn't known how to clean her hands properly, were you aware of that?"

Ms. Weaver doesn't know if this was an accident or if you meant to injure yourself, Milagros said. *Think you can clear it up for me?*

Accident, Catra ground between her teeth, thinking about what she could do to herself so she never had to have this conversation again.

"Catra covered for her all the time, I don't know why. Wouldn't even tell me what happened."

"But you didn't witness that alleged incident, did you?"

"No. She was just all messed up in the morning."

"So you don't know for a fact that this was an intentional act of my client, do you?"

"I know it's the kind of," Lonnie's face pulses with the profanity she wants to use, "thing she would've done."

Horne says, "You didn't see the injury occur, did you?"

"No," Lonnie snaps. "Didn't have to see it, I lived there for years, I saw enough to connect the fucking dots."

The judge reminds Lonnie that she isn't allowed to curse here, and she mutters an apology but her jaw keeps working.

"And, although you claim to have been aware of Ms. Guerra being sexually abused for years prior to that point, you never alleged that to an adult, did you?"

"Adora told me to never say nothing," Lonnie says, voice tight. "Said if we said anything Catra would just get hurt worse, and she was right."

"Yes or no," Horne says, "there's no official record of any of your allegations?"

"Except for that one time," Lonnie says, "no."

"Catra's caseworker determined that allegation wasn't true, were you aware of that?"

Lonnie jerks her head up, for the first time since she entered the room. "I know what she said, she was never going to believe any of us kids over Weaver." Lonnie's face darkens as she glares at Horne. "I'm no liar, I know she did it, I didn't have to watch her melt a kid's skin off to know it was her."

Horne's voice drops, the way Milagros's would when she said *I know you're upset, but*- "This was shortly after the court had to delay your return to your mother's custody, because she failed a drug test, right?"

Lonnie's cheek pulses when she grits her teeth. "Yeah."

"So you were angry at Stella that you couldn't go home yet, weren't you?"

"I was always angry at her. The kind of stuff she'd say to me, the kinds of things I saw her do." Lonnie looks at Weaver for the first time, glare sharp. "She knows how I feel about her."

"Angry enough to try to shut down her foster home, right?"

A chair creaks. Lonnie jerks her head slightly, like she's trying to shake something out of it. "I wanted someone to help Catra," she says. "That's all I wanted."

"You thought that, if Stella was blamed for Catra's accident, you'd go back to living with your mother, didn't you?"

"No," Lonnie says

The light catches in Horne's hair when he walks. "You live with your mother and your sister now, correct?"

"Yes."

"And you said you don't have much money. How much did of any future compensation did Ms. Guerra promise to share with you if you committed perjury for her?"

"Nothing," Lonnie snaps. "I haven't even talked to her since the night we ran away, and I wouldn't lie for her even if I did. We weren't friends."

"But you'd lie for your mother? Your baby sister?"

Lonnie's face is showing all the language she isn't allowed to use, and Catra knows what Lonnie swallowing that back looks like. "This isn't about my mom. This is about that monster paying you."

"You traveled to Bright Moon, where Ms. Guerra lives, a month ago. You really didn't see her?"

"I went to see Adora," Lonnie says.

When Catra looks at Adora, question in her eyes, Adora shakes her head, just a little. *Tell you later*, she mouths.

"Adora Castillo is in a relationship with Ms. Guerra, isn't she?"

"Yes," Lonnie snaps, "but they didn't offer me shit. This bitch put a fucking camera in the wall, I don't know how you can-"

The judge reminds her that she can't curse in the courtroom, and Horne ends his questions. He turns away from the jury and smiles his fake oily smile at Weaver, and she smiles back the same way she used to when they were in public and she had to pretend Catra was a kid she liked.

Lonnie leaves out the side door as soon as the judge says she can go, as quickly as she can. Catra suddenly can't let her disappear. Adora stays put when Catra drops a kiss on her cheek and puts Wrong Melog in her lap and tells her that she'll be right back.

Lonnie's a few hallways over, sitting with her arms on her knees, pressing her palms into her biceps. Her face is gritted tight. She doesn't look up when Catra sits next to her. Catra tries to think of what Bow would say. "Thank you," she says, "for doing that."

"Look," Lonnie says, voice sharp, "I fucked up, okay? I know I shoulda taken you to a hospital, I know you could've fucking died if your throat or brain had swollen up. I fucked up every day, including the last one. You don't have to tell me."

"I wasn't going to yell at you," Catra says. "You - you saved me, you didn't have to."

"Sure, I should've left you to be fucking murdered for real next time," Lonnie snaps. "Fuck, what's *wrong* with you?"

Catra knows her line. *Leave me the fuck alone or you'll find out,* teeth bared, fists tight. That's what she and Lonnie do - Lonnie says something to her, or makes a face, or ignores her with a tension in the air that Catra is sure means that Lonnie hates her and wishes she would die, and Catra snaps back or punches or destroys something that makes Lonnie's face go hard when she sees.

Catra doesn't want them to be like that anymore. "A lot's wrong with me," she says, and Lonnie flinches. "But I'm working on it. I'm trying."

Lonnie blows air out through her mouth, the way Emily tells Catra to do when she's getting worked up. "Good." Her voice is rough.

Catra says, "I know I was awful to grow up with. I'm sorry."

"Don't." Lonnie shudders, pulling her hands up to the back of her neck to grip until her knuckles shake. "All the shit you - that would fuck up anybody."

Catra tries to blink past that. "I wrecked your stuff all the time," she said, and she sounds younger than she means to. "Stuff from your mom, even after you couldn't see her anymore - I punched you so many-"

"And sometimes I hoped you'd get grounded so I'd have our room to myself. Sometimes I could hear you down there yelling and shit and I wanted you to shut up so I could sleep." Lonnie tugs one of her locs. She hasn't looked at Catra once. "Sometimes my baby sister acts up and my first instinct is to hit her to make her behave. I don't, I'd rather die, but - that whole situation was fucked up, Cat, I don't think anyone would have come out of that okay."

It's been a long time since Lonnie called her that. Maybe before her mom regained custody, back when they smuggled playdough

home from pre-k so they could make fragile toys from it before it dried. All three of them shared the room, then, and they'd have three misshapen little dolls hiding under their beds, drying on a book so they didn't stick to the carpet. Adora let Catra have Lonnie's, after she went home, and she kept it until summer when Weaver found them and smashed them and said she should have expected an animal to be a thief too.

"Yeah," Catra says, "I didn't. But I'm working on it. Adora too."

"I'm glad you have her." There's a bitterness in Lonnie's voice that Catra didn't expect.

"You have her too." If this was Adora, Catra could hug her now. Lonnie's never been like that. "You have us both, if you want."

Lonnie lifts her head then. "You don't owe me shit," she says, cold. "I did one thing for you once, something I should've done way earlier than I did - you don't have to repay me for that."

Catra shakes her head. "That's not - I care about you," she says, and doesn't realize it's true until she hears it. "You'd have to do more than that for me to be your friend if I didn't want to."

Someone calls Lonnie's name down the hallway before she can answer. When Catra looks, it's a woman and a little girl, beads swinging in her hair. They both have Lonnie's eyes, skin, solid shoulders. Catra would mistake Lonnie's mother for her if she didn't know better, from the shared angles in her pose. Lonnie has the same tangled emotion on her face that she always had when she got ready to get out of the car at the visitation center.

Catra says, "I'll let you-"

Lonnie pulls out her phone, taps the screen quickly before putting it back. Catra isn't sure where her own phone is. Probably in the bag at Adora's feet that has her sour candies and water. "Adora gave me your contact, now you have mine."

"Thank you," Catra says, and she hopes that Lonnie knows that she doesn't just mean the number.

Lonnie shrugs. "Whatever. You'll call me?"

Catra nods, fullness in her chest that it takes her a moment to recognize. Lonnie's mom and sister are only about ten feet away, now, and Catra leaves before they can try to talk to her. Lonnie's mom's voice carries down the hall. "When Bianca said she saw you going in the courthouse I didn't believe her. You in some kind of trouble? I'll help you, you know I will. Talk to me, baby girl."

Catra never liked when her mother called her that. A baby was only one thing to her, then - something small and worthless and vulnerable, helpless to stop anything in the world that wanted to hurt it. The way Lonnie's mom says it sounds like *someone precious, someone worth protecting*, and Catra isn't sure which Camila had meant.

Lonnie's voice is quieter, but Catra can still hear it. "Mama, I gotta tell you something."

She runs into Adora and everyone else on her way back to the courtroom, walking fast. Adora hugs her, cups her face, and Catra wants to kiss her more than she wants anything, right now, but not in front of so many people. "I'm okay," she says, before Adora gets a chance to ask.

They go to the park that afternoon. It's not the one they used to visit by the high school, where Adora ran until her shirt soaked through, where Catra climbed up in the tree by the playground and followed Adora with her eyes and tried to ignore the clenching in her lungs that she couldn't name. This one is too close to the city center to be entirely quiet, and the movement of the birds in the scattered trees keeps grabbing Catra's attention.

She tries to get them space alone somewhere calm, instead. In the garden, cars still hum in the background, but bees buzz over it. There's some creeping insect on the bench, and Adora puts her

hand down for it to crawl on, the way she used to with ants on the playground. Catra never liked the barely-there prickle of little feet like Adora did, but she would get her face down next to Adora's hands to see the ant up-close, body bubbled like the animals from the school fair. Adora was always so gentle with them. She's gentle now too, even with the tension in her shoulders.

"Do you remember the butterflies?" Adora asks, eyes on the bug on her finger. "In Ms. Layton's class?"

The tank with the caterpillars was near where Adora sat, and Catra could watch them both at the same time. When she got angry and threw things, she threw them away from the tank. They were supposed to draw the lifecycle, and Catra tried to do two pictures of the butterfly, so she could give one to Adora. It wasn't very good, but Adora caught her working on it and demanded to have it, and she brought it to her next visit to her grandmother to show off.

"Yeah," Catra says.

"Bow said they did a project like that at his school too. Guess it's universal." Adora puts the bug down on the ground, where it immediately heads into the tangle of flowers by the edge of the path. Adora squints at one of the red buds. "I definitely used to know the name of that one."

"Tulip," Catra says. Weaver had them in front of the house, a warm splash of colors next to the daisies and pale lilies. They're probably dead now, rotting under the dandelions that were always growing in to choke the things Weaver wanted there. It was Catra's job to weed them, finding sawblade leaves hiding under the flowers and tugging them out of the ground. The milky liquid that oozed out of broken roots made her hands sticky. She tried to eat a dandelion one summer, when she was hungry enough to be dizzy, and the petals crushed bitter between her teeth.

"Tulips," Adora echoes. The sun catches on her face, on the pale line over her cheekbone where she got stitches playing hockey in sixth grade, and Catra's watched that face and wanted for too long. She's been waiting, terrified that if her stupid body can't handle it, Adora will never let her try again, but she can't take it anymore.

"I want to kiss you," she says, heart thudding already over the rumble of a car in the distance.

Adora blinks at the bug before her head snaps up. She opens her mouth, then closes it. A gear turns behind her creased brow before she speaks. "You want to?"

"Yeah. If that's - if you-"

"Yes," Adora says, eyes tightening the way they do when she's trying not to cry. "Yes, of course, I-"

They'd kissed countless times, in the eighteen months they were dating before everything fell apart, but it's different, this time. Something echoes against Catra's neck, but it's not real. She immerses herself in what is real - Adora's cheek under her palm, the bee buzzing inches away, the sweet chapstick on Adora's lips. Light glows through her closed eyes. She makes sure there isn't room for anything else, filling her head up with here.

Adora mirrors her, this time, more careful than with the insect in her hand. She presses closer only when Catra does, hand skimming around to her shoulders and holding tight. When Catra's heart starts to move from excited-fast to panic-fast, she draws back an inch, noses still close to touching.

"Okay?" Adora asks, brow worried.

There's a tear under her eye that Catra sweeps away before she kisses her again. Catra doesn't pull back until she has to catch her breath. She needs both hands for the tears on Adora's face, now.

"I don't remember being that bad at this," Catra says, fighting to keep the worry out of her voice.

Adora shakes her head, swallows. "I just didn't think - I was okay if you couldn't ever - it's-"

"I want to," Catra says, when Adora breaks off. "I want to figure it out, and I want it to be like - to be here. With you. It's better than before. I don't know how long it's going to take, for anything more than this, but I want to try."

Adora opens her mouth, and Catra beats her to it. "I know I don't have to," she says. "I know you're not - going to leave. I want it for us, but also *me.*"

Adora's face is hard to look at, too many things tangled on it, but when Adora kisses her hard all Catra can think about is her. She remembers always wanting more, closer, until she could pretend that she didn't exist anymore. She doesn't want to do that, now. This makes her alive, and for once it doesn't feel like she must be siphoning it off Adora. It's easier this time to shove everything else away, like sweeping fallen leaves off the windshield in the fall. When a voice rattles against the back of her head, it's something she's able to ignore.

Catra pulls back when Adora starts to shake, breathing uneven. Catra doesn't know when their hands laced, but Adora's grip is tight enough to feel in her bones. Adora's eyes are closed, shoulders bow-string taut, and when Catra brushes her cheek again she all but flinches. Catra doesn't know what went wrong. "Sorry," she says.

Adora shakes her head, face crumpled. "Not you."

Please, Catra wants to say, *please let me help.* "You can tell me," Catra says, and she knows how hollow that would have sounded to her.

"It's stupid," Adora grinds through her teeth. "M'being stupid."

"No, you're not." Catra kisses Adora's forehead and the thin layer of sweat there. "I promise you're not."

The wind shifts the flowers around them. Adora sobs heavy like a storm breaking, crashing, fingers digging into the back of Catra's hand. "Sorry," she gasps out, and Catea doesn't know if she even knows what she's apologizing for.

"Whatever's wrong," Catra says, "holding it doesn't help. Trust me, it just keeps eating you."

Adora locks her free hand on her knee, closes her eyes for a long moment. "I don't understand," she manages. "I didn't care about this before."

"Let me help figure it out," Catra says, quieter than she means, while she watches Adora try to wrestle her composure back.

Adora's throat bobs before she speaks. "Lonnie came to campus, that's when she talked to me." Adora jerks her head. Her eyes are still closed. "She, um, the details don't matter, but - she thought that Weaver was, was, not the way she should have been, with me too, and-"

Catra had thought this was probably about Weaver somehow, but it still makes something zap in the back of her head. Weaver loved Adora. That was what she always said, always drilled into both of them. Catra knew that wasn't really a good thing, now that she can see how Adora was bent and twisted under the weight of it. But Adora was safe from the Weaver who forced Catra out of herself so she could flood in instead, because Adora was smart and helpful and good for anything else. She was all the things Catra wasn't, and that's why whatever horrible thing lived in Catra's skin had to drag Adora down with her. That's been as real as the sky, the grass under her feet, things she'd never had to think about.

"Lonnie wasn't *right*, she thought it was - a lot more than it was, it wasn't anything really, but-"

If the way Weaver acted around Adora was love - smiles, attention, *you're so smart, so good, so perfect* - then it was also love when Weaver's voice and hands went soft with Catra too, once she learned to disappear instead of fighting. When Weaver stroked her hair and cleaned her face and used her gentle voice when she said *that's it, monster, I know what you want.* She thought she heard Adora's name then, more than once, quiet enough that Catra might have been making it up with how much she wanted to pretend she was with Adora instead. Weaver had always been possessive with them both, and she'd never thought about what that meant.

"I don't think it was normal," Adora says, and Catra knows the note of shame in her voice too well. "Made me feel, uh, weird, sometimes, but it wasn't - I don't know. I'm not making any sense."

"You are," Catra says, something hollowing where her lungs used to be. She wants to be surprised, to be able to say that she doesn't see it when she looks back, but she tries not to lie anymore. She kisses Adora's cheek, and she expects the salt on her lips.

"It doesn't *matter,*" Adora says, thick with frustration, "but that's what's - I can't stop thinking about it and-" she snaps to a stop, and when Catra nudges her jaw she shifts it enough to pull her skin from between her teeth. "Sorry. The moment was perfect and I lost it over nothing."

"No," Catra says, limbs heavy, "it wasn't nothing."

"It's not-" Adora grits her teeth loud enough to hear. "I didn't even care, then, it wasn't-"

Sometimes when Catra's voice kept going and going siren-loud, after Weaver shut her up she'd say *stop whining, this doesn't even hurt. You'll know when I hurt you.*

Catra says, "Glimmer would say it wasn't okay, right? Her mom? Bow? Lonnie sure as hell didn't think it was nothing."

"You can't pretend it's even close," Adora says, "to what-"

"You're not playing for Etheria in the fucking trauma olympics," Catra says, voice rougher than she wants it to be. She pushes their foreheads together, like she's young enough to still think she can shove her thoughts into Adora's head that way. "It's not a competition, there's no minimum amount you have to bleed before-"

"Catra," Adora says, and no, no, Adora can't say her name like she doesn't get it, when there's not another person on earth who's going to get it more than her.

"No." Catra manages not to smash her head against Adora's thick fucking skull. "For once in your life, listen to what I'm saying before you decide if I'm right."

It's not really fair, and Catra opens her mouth to say she didn't mean it, but Adora murmurs, "You're right. I'm sorry."

Catra closes her eyes, trying to pull together the thoughts ricocheting inside her head. "Saying it was nothing because you think it was worse, for me - that doesn't help me. Stop using me to tell yourself to feel bad. Fuck that, no. She could have done a lot worse to both of us, and she didn't. That doesn't mean she should get a pass for what she *did* do."

Adora's quiet, for a second. The wind whips through the trees, tugging at the strands on the side of Adora's hair that Catra smoothed on the drive over. She moves, and her lips brush Catra's in question. The kiss is more desperate, this time.

"I don't want it to matter," Adora says, close enough for Catra to feel the air on her lips.

"I know," Catra says. Her stomach aches. She wants to be able to open Adora's head and pull out the thoughts that burrow into her

like maggots, but she can't. "But it's allowed to."

A bird drops into a tree nearby, chittering loud enough to drown out the sound of their mouths together. They stay there for a while, after, trying to name all the flowers they can see, and when Adora starts in about how foxglove is a heart medication Catra sets her head on her lap and dozes for what feels like the first time in days.

Chapter End Notes

> Adora's pov will be back next chapter, these scenes got too long to share a chapter with anything else.
>
> On a personal note: I'm not doing well emotionally right now, and this fic is challenging to write on a good day. It's very emotional for me and it's especially difficult to work on when I'm not in a good place. I have over 20k drafted for the future chapters, and I've been fighting through because it's important for me to carry this through to the end, this really means a lot to me for reasons I can't fully articulate here. But a. for those same reasons I want to be able to finish this the best way I can and b. if I hurt myself to write this, I haven't been listening to a word of what this series is trying to say. I have to do what I hope anyone triggered by this will do, and take care of myself first.
>
> My goal is still to aim for every 2-3 weeks, but I can't make promises about the timeline anymore. I have a therapist, I'm going to be fine, but my health takes priority over finishing this on the schedule I wanted to follow. You might see other work from me, and that doesn't mean I've given up on this - just that I need a break. Thank you for understanding, love you all for reading 💜

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

> Recurrent reminder that I am not a lawyer or involved in the legal field in any country and there is only so much I can learn from reading articles on the internet. If you are looking for a detailed and accurate courtroom drama, this is not going to be it. Please do not tell me how I'm doing this wrong. Thank you for understanding.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It's warmer than Adora expected in the witness box. Between the lights and the nerves and the new dress, she already has a narrow river of sweat trailing down her back.

While she's sworn in, she makes herself look at Weaver. Like the last time they had spoken, Weaver's face is playing confused and sad and pained. But she's angry, whether the jury can see it or not. Adora knows how to read that on her the same way creatures in a forest know a storm's coming, gut instinct. Darla says she learned to be attuned to it, when Weaver's rage was one of the worse things that could happen.

But Weaver can't do anything to anyone anymore. Adora shoves away the rush in her ears, flip in her gut, cinch in her shoulders. She's not going to be weak anymore. Weaver's mad, *good*.

Rosetti runs through the easy questions first. Her name, age, what she's studying at BMU. Rosetti pulls a photograph up on the big screen. "Do you recognize anyone in this picture?"

It's their kindergarten class, all but two faces blurred out. She'd barely looked at the pictures of herself that she'd been sent, after the police went through Weaver's house, and she'd forgotten that her teeth gapped as badly as they had. She doesn't think she'll stop being surprised by how young they look.

"Yes," she says, just as Rosetti opens her mouth to prompt her. "That's me on the left, in the unicorn shirt, and Catra's on the right." Ms. Bell made them go by height for the picture and Catra sulked that she had to be in the front.

"Catra Guerra?"

"Yes."

"How did you know Catra?"

"We were in the same foster home," Adora says.

"Do you see your foster parent here today?"

"At the second table," Adora says, and she focuses on making sure her nerves don't come out in her voice when she looks Weaver square in her eyes. If she focuses on her pupils, she can't even see what her face is trying to do. The anger in the air thickens. Adora's stupid hand rattles under the table and the back of her head snaps at it to stop before Weaver sees, even though she can't see from where she is, even though it doesn't matter if she does, nothing she thinks matters anymore, Adora doesn't *care.* "In the gray shirt," she says, more clipped than she wants to.

"Let the record show that the witness indicated the defendant," Rosetti says, and Adora flicks her eyes out to the gallery. It's easy to find Catra, Glimmer and Bow behind her, Scorpia at her side. Catra taps a cupped hand over the left side of her chest, half a heart.

You can do this, Catra told her around three this morning, when they gave up pretending that they were going to be able to sleep. Crickets chirped outside and the hum of the heater twisted into whispers, but Catra's fingers knotted in the back of her shirt and Catra kissed her like she could quiet Adora's brain that way. Nothing has turned down the volume in her head for a long time, but it used to. Maybe that can again, someday.

Adora told her *I know, I'm ready.*

She's run through every question a dozen times in her head. She can finally do something to help. It should feel like a relief to stop being useless. She shouldn't be timing her breathing, *in four, hold seven, out eight*, like Darla makes her practice.

"What can you tell the jury about living with the defendant?"

Adora stumbles over what she's prepared, because she can feel the fury now, electric in the air. Sometimes she would be in a different room, and when the yells thuds cracks started she'd run and hide until she couldn't hear it even in her head anymore. Sometimes they were between her and the door, so she stayed frozen deer-still as it got worse and Catra curled up on the floor like the dead spider Adora found in the windowsill and the crashing terror in her chest said Catra was going to die and Adora wasn't going to be able to race with her on the playground ever again but Adora didn't gasp, because she'd have to breathe to do that.

The first time she got a referral at LUNA where she had to tick the box next to *physical abuse,* she thought through water for the rest of the day. She filled out her report and submitted it and kept working, but Bow had to say her name twice to get her attention. She didn't feel anything. Three days later she snapped at Catra about a speck of food left on a clean plate, and Catra hurled back that she could wash them her own damn self then, and Adora put down the plate before she threw it and Catra held her when she sobbed on the kitchen floor. Adora said she was tired.

I'm so tired, Weaver said one evening, while Adora wrote an essay in perfect small letters. She could almost keep the shake out of her hand, even if she still heard pounding from downstairs. There was a streak of blood on Weaver's knuckle that she must not have noticed. *At least you understand. You're the only one I can trust.*

"She got angry a lot," Adora says. She might sound normal to someone who doesn't know her. "She'd hurt her. Catra, I mean.

She could be very violent."

Rosetti sounds gentler when she asks, "Was the defendant ever violent to you?"

"No." Adora's louder than she means to be. "But I would try to take care of Catra, after, if I could. I'd try to help."

She pulls it all to the front of her mind - the injuries she carefully hugged around, the cracker packets she shoved in her pockets, the riddles she copied out of books at the library to read through the door. When Catra had to go to the hospital, she'd slumped half-conscious in her booster seat, groaning when the car went over bumps, and Adora had tried to figure out which arm was broken so she didn't hurt her worse if she held her hand. This is the truth she's here to tell.

"I was too young to really do any good," Adora says. On the screen, the version of her from fifteen years ago is smiling for the picture. "But I tried."

"Did you ever talk to anyone about this?"

When she walked into her first grade classroom, she told Ms. Layton that Catra was home sick. She couldn't focus all morning, thinking about the cold fury on Weaver's face the night before as she dragged Catra to the kitchen. *School tomorrow,* Catra had said before Weaver opened the door to the basement, voice crackling and stuffy. *Wanna go, sposed to-*

Weaver grabbed her face over the large dark bruise. Adora looked back at her homework so she wouldn't see, but she couldn't cover her ears. *You think they don't hate you there too? Not even I want to fucking look at you right now.*

Adora lingered when it was time to go to recess, and she told Ms. Layton that Catra wasn't sick. Ms. Layton crouched in front of her to see her eyes better. *You can tell me anything, Adora,* Ms. Layton said, and Adora thought about how hard Catra would have had to cry to sound like that.

When she tells the story now, there's the same dread in her gut. Rosetti asks, "When Dolores Milagros came to speak to you, what did you tell her?"

"I told her I'd lied."

"Why did you retract your statement?"

Adora swallows. "She told me she'd talked to Ms. Weaver and Catra and they'd denied it. I didn't want to contradict them. I was young, Catra was my best friend. I wanted her to be safe. I thought agreeing with them was the only way to do that."

I know you're not trying to hurt me, Weaver said, brushing her fingers through Adora's hair, pain in her voice. *You're a good kid. But it does hurt when you make people think I'm a terrible person. They'll take you away from me. Is that what you want?*

No, Adora whispered, and the pit in her stomach got worse.

Rosetti says, "The next time Dolores Milagros came to interview you, what did you say?"

Adora shapes her hand into the half-heart shape on her leg. "I said everything was fine. Every time someone asked me, I covered for her. I was scared to make her upset again."

She was supposed to say *angry.* That's the only emotion of Weaver's she can care about. There aren't windows in here. Her dress doesn't have sleeves, which should be good because she's sweating, but she's freezing and her fingers keep reaching for cuffs that aren't there.

Glimmer helped her pick out this awful dress a week ago, when she asked Adora what they were going to wear and they both realized she had nothing. Lonnie had had a yellow court dress, growing up, because she had to go every six months to see if DCFS thought her mom was ready to get her back. Adora had only dressed up once, for Razz's funeral, faux satin black with lace. She'd shoved it under the dresser afterwards and it's

probably still there now, almost thirteen years later, unless the police found it when they searched the house.

"How many more times did you speak with Catra's social worker?"

"Twelve times," Adora says. She had to look through the file to learn that, paper rough under her fingertips. She had to read *foster sibling denies any allegations* on almost every report. "I never - I always covered for her. I didn't know what else to do."

Rosetti's shoes tap a little on the floor when she walks. "When did you stop living with the defendant?"

Adora explains about school, and hockey, and sobbing in the car on the way back to campus. Her hands grip tight over her elbows. The damp patch forming under her bra makes her skin itch. *I don't know why you even applied there,* Weaver said when Adora showed her the BMU scholarship letter that April. *You can't go that far. What are we supposed to do with you so far away?* When Adora didn't do a good enough job hiding her upset, Weaver swept her loose hairs behind her ear and said *of course I'm proud, but I thought you knew better than to do something so selfish.*

Catra held the letter with careful hands, eyes wide, and said *let's go to Bright Moon*.

"After Catra left, I looked for her," Adora says, "and I realized - a lot of things. I couldn't keep in contact with Weaver anymore. Not after everything she's done."

Rosetti smiles, just a little, to say that she's doing well. "Are you in a relationship right now, Adora?"

When Rosetti first told her that this was going to be part of her testimony, Adora balked. She hated herself immediately, because she loves Catra, she doesn't want to care who knows it. Rosetti says it looks like a conspiracy if they don't mention it. It's already come up, Weaver knows by now. This shouldn't be difficult.

You always choose her over me, Weaver told her once, when she caught Adora on her way up the stairs, book in hand. *She's got her hooks in you deep. Maybe you'd be better off if she was gone.* And then Adora had breathed through the cold that washed over her and insisted that she could help Weaver too, that she'd do the chores Catra couldn't do from the basement, that she'd always do everything she could, and Weaver had cupped the back of her skull to kiss her forehead and said *that's my big helper, I love you so much.* Adora felt like clothing out of the dryer, soft and warm.

She doesn't know why she's thinking about that now. It makes the almonds she ate in the car twist dangerously in her stomach.

"Yes," she says. When she looks back at where Catra's sitting, Catra smiles big even though her eyebrows pinch. *love you,* she mouths. "Yes, Catra and I started dating that January. It's been over two years now."

Rosetti asks about LUNA next, what she did there. It's harder to use the words she used in training, now. They feel too detached, too clinical, when she knows the picture of them is still on her right, and everyone's looking and that's what they're picturing, and Weaver's there and-

"I thought I could do good there," Adora says, trying to focus on her script. "We needed the money, yes, but I also wanted to do something good."

"In your pre-employment screening," Rosetti says, "you were asked if you or someone you knew had experienced sexual abuse. What did you say?"

"I said no," Adora says. Maybe no one else can hear the tiny rasp in her voice. She's supposed to say she thought that was the truth. She doesn't know that for a fact, anymore.

Rosetti asks about that July morning. Adora walks through the beats they'd practiced, the sterile technical terms, and tries to listen to her own rhythm more than her words. Sometimes she

doesn't recognize that Adora, who filled out three reports before she got to that one, who let images flicker over her eyes, who saw the person she loves most in the world for almost three minutes before her own denial cracked.

Rosetti picks up her remote, clicks, and Adora doesn't want to look. She sees it enough in her nightmares anyway. "Do you recognize this person?" Rosetti asks.

It's the woman in the mask, cut off oddly so she's the only one in frame, and it's so obvious now. Adora saw Weaver every day for almost eighteen years, she knows her from the angle of her shoulders, the tilt of her head. She doesn't need a face. There's no way for Adora to mistake her unless she was already used to letting facts slide off of her.

"Stella Weaver," Adora says, looking back down to trace one of the grain lines on the witness stand.

Click. "I know this is difficult," Rosetti says, "but can you confirm for the court that this is the same child you saw?"

It's cropped in around her face, like it had been for Lonnie's testimony, but she remembers the rest. Adora knows this face better than her own. The hand is in Catra's hair, mouth open to scream, and Adora can *hear* it, and she looks away before she throws up on the wood of the box. Closing her eyes doesn't help, because it's still there. She manages not to cover her ears. She vaguely registers that Catra's eyes were shut, in the picture. Rosetti would have shown them open if she could. That's not what Adora remembers. She doesn't want to think about what she remembers.

"Ms. Castillo?"

She has a job. Weaver's watching her fall apart, Catra's watching, and she doesn't have the right to be this upset about something that didn't even happen to her, but Catra doesn't want her to think

like that, and does it matter whether Weaver *wanted* to do the same to her if it never happened, or-

"Ms-"

She *has a job.*

"Y-yeah," Adora says, coughs. "Yes."

Rosetti says, "If you need a recess we can take one."

They spent a lot of time talking about Adora taking breaks if she was getting overwhelmed. Everyone made her promise to do it - Rosetti, Darla, Bow and Glimmer, Catra - and she thought she could. But taking a break is only going to prolong this, and this is awful enough.

She shakes her head. Rosetti brings a paper up to her, asks her to confirm that it describes what she saw, and she looks at Angella's name at the end, signed in her smooth script. Angella would have seen the whole thing. This report would have everything Adora ripped her eyes away from, and she's not supposed to do that anymore. She gets four words in and has to grip her knee until it hurts. She isn't supposed to do that either.

"Yes," she says, pushing the paper away. She doesn't even sound like she's dying. "I saw the beginning of that."

"You went to the defendant's house a few days later," Rosetti says. "Why?"

Chills echo down her arms, ripple along her spine, as she explains what happened. The girls aren't scheduled to testify for either side, and she could tie herself into knots worrying about why. Adora wishes she knew what they would say if they were here. She wishes she knew the kinds of things they hear in the echo Weaver's voice that lives in their heads.

"I think some members of the jury may be wondering," Rosetti says, snapping Adora back to the clicking of the stenographer,

"whether Catra ever discussed any of this with you before last summer, especially in light of the fact that you're in a romantic relationship. Can you speak to that?"

Her head feels like cotton. She knows the words she needs to say. It's like the pages are soaked, letters blurring together when she tries to remember. "After she ran away, um, she showed me her hair and she told me it was bad, but we didn't - didn't talk about it." Adora tries to clear the thickness out of her throat so the jury can hear her, because if they don't understand her, she's failing. "She can tell you, when she's up here, but it's hard for her. It's hard for both of us."

"When you spoke to police," Rosetti says, "you said that you recognized Catra after about three minutes. Why wasn't it sooner?"

Adora knows what she's supposed to say. *I was surprised, I couldn't see her face, the video quality was poor, the perpetrator was wearing a mask.* All of the excuses laid out clean.

"I didn't want it to be them," comes out instead. "I thought I was wrong. I hoped I was wrong."

Rosetti pauses for a long moment. Then she says, "Tell me more about that."

She should say it was a mistake, an accident. If she doesn't, she makes herself look more like a liar than Weaver could have hoped. She can't change her story again, half of her testimony is trying to address the changes she's already made.

If she lies, she buries it deeper, for longer, and it keeps eating her wherever it's hiding, hollowing her out. If she doesn't, maybe one of the kids that left Weaver's house in the dim pre-dawn, backpack on her shoulder, won't tell herself that she was crazy too.

"If it was them, then I hadn't made things up, when I was a kid, then I didn't - then it was all real."

Adora saw them a hundred times - at the end of the hall, the corner of a doorway, anywhere where she wasn't supposed to see - Weaver with her hands on Catra's shoulder or jaw or hip, crowding in too close, saying something too quiet to hear, and Adora learned quick to look away from it so she didn't see the expression on Catra's face. She doesn't remember it now, but she can guess.

Come on, Adora, Weaver said, exasperated, when Adora squirmed away from her in a changing room once when she had been old enough to dress herself for years. *Stop being ridiculous.* And Adora stopped, because she didn't want to be ridiculous, and if she couldn't figure out what was wrong with the way Weaver smoothed her clothes, nothing *was* wrong. Maybe she really did need help. Maybe all moms were like this.

Adora killed her first mother by being too difficult. She didn't want to make the same mistake again.

In four, hold seven, out eight. Rosetti hasn't tried to redirect her, so she must be doing something right. Catra's face is pinched like she's upset, but when she sees Adora looking, she nods. There's a fire in her eyes.

"She told me I got confused, I was paranoid, I imagined things. It was easier to believe it wasn't real. That's what I did for years and years, but-" She knows there aren't small eyes blinking at her from the shadows in the back of the courtroom, but she sees them anyway. "I can't do what's easier anymore."

Adora tries to hold onto the relief that finally floods in. Rosetti smiles when she says they're finished. Catra gives her two thumbs up, and Bow and Glimmer and Scorpia do too. Weaver watches, and Adora looks away when she realizes she's trying to figure out what's hiding under her face. It doesn't matter.

Before a hockey game started, Adora would look at the other team, braced in position, in the moments before the ball was released. Coach Hope had already spoken about their strengths,

weaknesses, and what they were likely to try to exploit in the Alliance, but Adora tried to measure the challenge in stark colors ahead of her, the people who would try to get between her team and victory. When she does the same to Horne, now, he comes up lacking.

Adora didn't tell anyone about the conversation she had with Horne, earlier this week. Either it was allowed, in which case it doesn't matter if it made her upset, or it was against the rules and the trial would get delayed and they'd have to go through this all again in a few months. Adora can't do that. She doesn't want to make Catra and Lonnie do that.

She's not scared of Horne. If he thought that he could manipulate her, he miscalculated. All Horne has against her are words, and Adora's survived worse than his.

Horne says, "You lived with the defendant for sixteen years, is that right?"

"Yes."

"And in that time," Horne says, "your testimony is that you were untruthful at nearly every opportunity to raise concerns about your foster care placement, correct?"

"Yes," Adora says. "I didn't think I had a choice."

"And you also assert that you lied on your job application to access highly sensitive material?"

"I believed I was being truthful," Adora says, "at the time."

"And you testified that you gave a false statement to police last summer, didn't you?"

"The whole statement wasn't false, and it wasn't intentional," Adora says, careful. "I provided what I believed to be true at the time."

"To clarify," Horne says, light catching in his eyes, "your testimony is that you've lied almost non-stop for your entire life, right?"

"About this, yes."

"But you're being truthful now, correct?" His voice is dry, a twig before it snaps. "You're aware of the consequences of committing perjury?"

"Yes," Adora says, and it echoes back loud through the speakers.

"It's also your testimony that Catra Guerra was untruthful at every opportunity as well, correct?"

Adora breathes before she answers. "Nothing else was safe."

Horne walks up to the box, slides a paper to her, points to a particular line. He brings an odd smell, maybe a cologne, ozone and metal. "Can you tell us what that says?"

It's something from Dolores Milagros, so Adora's hackles rise immediately. The text itself doesn't help. "This is a lie," she says, bitterness thick in her mouth.

"Please read this section," Horne says. She can see the edge of one of his canine teeth, pointy where it peeks through his lips.

"'Catra is highly manipulative,'" Adora reads, tension building in her chest. "'She uses emotional and physical outbursts to control the behavior of those around her. She is often cruel and vindictive towards others, particularly those close to her.' None of that's *true*."

"That's written by Catra's social worker, isn't it?"

"Yes," Adora says, and she doesn't manage to keep her voice as neutral as she wanted to. Angella says Milagros is on 'adminstrative leave' while DCFS looks into Adora's complaints, while the trial is unresolved. Thinking about her still makes Adora sick.

"Her social worker has known Catra since she was a toddler, hasn't she?"

"That woman never knew her. She saw what she wanted to see and nothing else."

Another paper. "This is a statement from your first grade teacher, Natalie Layton, in your own social worker's annual report. Can you read this portion?"

Adora hadn't known that Ms. Paterson even bothered to speak to her teachers. She never saw her file, there could be anything in there. She pinches her leg under the table so she doesn't grit her teeth. "'Catra and Adora are alarmingly enmeshed,'" she reads. "'Adora's emotions seem to follow Catra's - when Catra has a good day or a bad day, they both do. Adora is markedly more at ease when Catra is absent.'"

Adora couldn't breathe on the bus when she had to ride alone. She would face the window and watch everything outside turn into a blur, and tell herself that she was fine and she had to stop being so stupid, and when the bus went over the speed bumps that meant they were only a few minutes away from school, she would shove it all in the depth of herself, paint on the heavy normal face. She didn't feel much of anything, then. She just pushed through the day until she could go home and find out if she was going to tussle with Catra about who was taking too much blanket in front of the TV or make up stories about mermaids and fairies with her forehead pressed to the door.

"I wasn't *at ease*," she says.

A third page. An incident report for Adora. Junior year was difficult. Adora was applying to colleges, and Weaver said she was proud of how much Adora had accomplished, but everyone had a shorter fuse. Catra got in more fights, Lonnie was at her mother's house most days, Weaver came to Adora's bedroom to smooth her hair and say *you know no one else will love you like I do*, and Adora would say *I love you too, I always will.*

"'Adora was involved in an incident during a transition period today. She attempted to intervene in a physical altercation, where she assaulted two other students. She was reminded that violence is unacceptable and that further infractions would result in more serious consequences. Her guardian was notified,'" Adora says. Her voice doesn't fade at the end.

Horne says, "This altercation involved Ms. Guerra, correct?"

Adora nods before she remembers to speak. She heard the fight before she rounded the corner, the sounds of punches and shoes scuffling on the floor and *fucking try me, bitch*, and Adora doesn't remember a lot between that moment and when Catra's elbow hit her ribs. Catra's eyes went wide immediately and she drew her arms in, and she probably would have run if the resource officer hadn't shown up. Someone told Adora later that they hadn't known she could throw people to the floor like she had.

The assistant principal said Adora could go back to class, but Adora sat with Catra until Weaver came. Catra took the ice pack off her eye and picked at the plastic cover and snapped at Adora when she told her to put it back. When Weaver arrived in the doorway with tension in her shoulders, she told Adora *I hope she didn't jeopardize your future* and Catra flung the ice pack on the floor.

"I can only find records of you being violent twice," Horne says, "this incident and when you came to Ms. Weaver's house, and in both cases the incident was about Ms. Guerra, wasn't it?"

"I love Catra," Adora says, and it's not the kind of answer she practiced for cross, but it's true. "That's not a crime."

"Remind me how long you have been in a relationship with Ms. Guerra?"

Adora blinks. "Over two years."

"The rest of those sixteen years you've known her, you were siblings, weren't you?"

"We weren't a *family*," Adora says, even if she isn't sure that's true. She doesn't have another word for what she and Catra are to each other, but she knows what he's implying and that isn't right, she won't let him say that.

Horne arches his eyebrow, the way that Catra worked for weeks to master as a kid. "Would you say it's normal for foster siblings to become romantically entangled?"

"Nothing about how we grew up was normal," Adora says, neck prickling, "and we're not doing anything wrong."

"The relationship was Ms. Guerra's idea, wasn't it?"

"Like all good ones," Adora says, "it came from both of us."

"You would both be aware of survivor compensation funds through your former employer, correct?"

It was in LUNA's materials for survivor outreach. Adora hadn't even bothered to bring them home when she knew they'd only make Catra angry. Catra's advocate must have told her, because she came home from one of their meetings this winter with a different pamphlet with the same name, frustration knitted into the corners of her eyes. She kicked the couch twice before she could talk. *Can't wait to get my royalties*, she'd spat.

"There's not enough money in the world to make this worth it," Adora says.

"Let's go back to August for a moment," Horne says. "You claim that you were concerned about the possibility that Stella had additional children in her custody, correct?"

"Yes."

"And you claim you didn't know what you were going to do until you got there, is that correct?"

"I don't just claim it, that's true."

"It's about two hours to travel to Ms. Weaver's home from Bright Moon, correct?"

Adora thinks it was less, that night. She was probably speeding on the near empty roads, just her and big silver semis and thoughts running through her head. "Yes."

"So this wasn't an impulsive decision, was it? Didn't you have ample time to think about what you planned to do when you got there?"

She doesn't remember much of the drive. She just remembers the way her jaw hurt by the time she got there, muscles clenched. "I don't know what I thought about."

"You're aware that your actions that night constitute physical assault?"

"I'm aware," Adora says. Shivers curl along her spine.

"You claim my client is able to inflict significant harm - you say she has done so as recently as two years ago - but when you came into her home and harmed her, she didn't defend herself, did she?"

"I don't know why she didn't hurt me when she could have," Adora says. She realizes she's looking at the floor, at the shadows spooling out from where Horne paces, and she drags her eyes up. "I don't know why she did a lot of things."

"You testified that your statements vindicating my client were untrue because you were frightened, correct?"

"And manipulated, yes."

"You went to my client's home alone, in the middle of the night, and attacked her," Horne says, "Those don't sound like the actions of someone intimidated or controlled by my client, do they?

"I wasn't scared she was going to hurt me. I used to be, but I haven't for a long time." Adora doesn't realize her fist is pressed to her chest, where it aches, until her knuckle digs into the muscle. "I didn't want her to hurt the kids who were there."

"There was no indication that Stella was anything but a loving and supportive parent to those children, was there?"

It's okay to be upset, Weaver said, after Razz died, when Adora sat dry-eyed at the table wondering if she was a heartless demon for not crying. Catra washed dishes, faucet low enough for her to hear. *She cared for you, in her own way, even if she couldn't handle you. It's okay. I love you, I won't leave you like she did,* she said, and the weight she hadn't known was there lightened on Adora's shoulders.

Adora shoves the memory away with all the rage she can muster. "You can't always see it," she says. "Not having marks, that doesn't mean they were okay."

"They witnessed you assaulting their guardian, didn't they? They were upset?"

Adora talks around the lump in her throat. "Yes."

"Isn't that the reaction you would expect from children seeing their loving caregiver be harmed?"

Rosetti objects, Horne withdraws the question. Adora thinks about holding a phone in her hand, while Catra was out in the snow, dialing 9-1 and pausing with her finger over the final number.

She isn't sure how much longer cross-examination takes. Horne keeps digging at it from another angle and Adora parries as best she knows how, as the light through the windows stretches into bars crawling up the wall.

"You testified that you didn't identify the defendant immediately because you 'didn't want it to be them.' Do you usually only see what you want to see?"

"Sometimes," Adora says. She feels every hour she was awake last night. She was careful about how many cups of coffee she poured this morning, because she didn't need anything else to tie her in knots, but now she'd take the jitters over the exhaustion setting into her bones.

Horne takes a step closer to the box. His voice drops, sweetens. "Your testimony is that your memory has changed, is that right?"

She tightens her hand on her knee. "The way I interpret it has changed."

"Isn't it possible that your enmeshed relationship, with someone who has a documented history of being manipulative, is skewing your memory?"

"No," Adora says. More sweat inches down her back. "I know what I know."

"But you didn't nine months ago?"

"I hadn't put the pieces together yet," Adora said. "I had to rethink a lot of things."

"Did Ms. Guerra help you 'put the pieces together'?"

Yes, but - "She could barely talk about it."

"Yes or no," Horne says, green eyes sharp, "did she help you 'rethink'?"

Adora promised to tell the truth, but she can see the web he's building. "Lots of things helped."

"No further questions," Horne says. There's still frustration in the air, enough to taste. Adora grips her knee hard while she waits for the judge to tell her she can go.

Rosetti stands up instead. Some of Adora's disappointment must leak through because she says, "This will be quick."

Adora nods, limbs heavy.

"When you told me you didn't want the abuse to be real," Rosetti says, "why was that?"

Because then there weren't more horrors she didn't stop. Because then Catra didn't keep it from her. Because then Adora didn't make it worse. That's all true, but it's not enough.

The air conditioning rattles almost as loud as her heart. When Adora was sworn in, she promised to tell the truth. She doesn't always understand how to know what's true or not, not the way someone like Lonnie does, but she understands a promise.

"Because she said she loved me," Adora says. She should say Weaver's name. She gestures towards her instead. She looks away before she tries to identify the emotion that bursts on Weaver's face.

Rosetti steps closer, eyes like chips of glass. She waits.

Adora tries to swallow but her mouth is too dry. There's a water bottle on the stand with her, but she can't remember how to open it. "She said - and I-"

I do so much for you girls, Weaver said, adjusting the ice pack on her arm where the ring of Catra's teeth bruised. *No one appreciates me. I could die today and none of you would shed a tear.*

I would, Adora said. Her fingers were still cold from digging in the freezer to get the ice. *I love you.*

I love you, child. Weaver's other hand stroked down over her face and lingered on her chin, thumb brushing her lip. *There's my good girl, my Adora,* she said, and the warmth that bloomed in Adora's chest stayed with her all day, thawing all the way to her fingertips.

"I shouldn't have cared about her, she's dangerous and sick and - the things I saw her do-" Adora's voice doesn't sound as old as

she feels. "But-"

Tucked under a big arm, book open on her lap, stuck on a word. Weaver tapped the first letter, warm against her side. *Sound it out, you know this one. What does M say?*

Your turn, Weaver said, pulling her shoelace, and Adora tried to make her clumsy fingers tie the bow. Weaver put her hands over Adora's to show her again. *You'll get it, you're my smart girl.*

Weaver smoothed her graduation gown over her shoulders, tucked a lock of loose hair behind her ear, cupped the curve of her jaw. *You grew up so well, so beautiful.*

Her hand is on her face. Adora pulls it back to lay limp on her lap. She shrugs. "She never loved me. She just played twisted mind games. They worked, for a long time." In four, hold seven, out eight. "But not anymore."

She doesn't know how everyone gets to the witness room before her, but she doesn't care. As soon as she steps in, Bow and Glimmer and Scorpia and Catra sweep up around her, with enough distance for her to be able to choose to close it. "You did amazing," more than one person says. She was unsteady when she walked down the hall, trying to sift through the fog and figure out if things had gone well or not, but now it feels like seeing the scoreboard at the end of a game, when the cheer rises on their side of the stands.

Catra's on her right. The floral perfume Scorpia wears clings to her hair. Adora loves her eyes, colors rich. "So fucking proud of you," Catra says, and it sends a zap along Adora's nerves. "You killed it."

"I did okay?"

Everyone nods. Catra clasps her hand, nails smooth on Adora's skin. "You did perfect. No one could have done any better."

They'd planned to go into the Whispering Woods after court, to a lookout over the city. Scorpia says you can see the stars from there. Adora thought she would be agitated and panicky, since that's how she's felt after nearly every day so far, but the soft drone of the car lulls her to sleep. For the first time in almost a month, she doesn't dream of little faces she can't name.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you for all of your support as I take this at the pace that I can handle right now. Catra's POV will be back next chapter, which is on its way. Thank you for understanding, love you all 💜

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

Standing reminder that I am not a lawyer or involved in the legal field in any country. Thank you for understanding.

If you've read this far, you know I don't typically warn by chapter, since the work tags cover it and I would have the same warnings for every chapter. This chapter covers those topics more in-depth to a point that I felt was outside the norm for this fic, if not for this series (past the first scene break). Nothing is more graphic than we've had before but the content is particularly heavy and I don't want this to catch anyone off-guard. There's a summary in the end notes if you choose to skip this one, since the next chapter will refer back to this one. If you found the prequel fic to be too much, take that into account because this is similar in content. Take care of yourselves, I love you all.

▶ Tap here for warnings

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora's asleep by the time both cars get to the lookout. Catra makes sure her neck's at a comfortable angle, Scorpia's spare sweatshirt shoved between her and the window. She looks peaceful when she sleeps. Adora's earned some rest.

The sun is starting to set. Scorpia points out different parts of the city in the dying light - their high school, her neighborhood, the aquarium they're going to tomorrow. "Told you that you can see most of the city from here," she says. "Perfuma's better at finding stuff than me."

Bow asks about Perfuma, and now that he's got Scorpia going the conversation will continue for a while. Catra tries to trace her bus route home from school, but she gets lost in the identical rooftops. Any of the buildings she's looking at could be Weaver's

house. Any of them could be where Camila used to live. She doesn't know if they had a house or apartment or a room in the shelter, and that never bothered her before.

"I've heard about Heart Blossom," Fujimura says, a few feet to her left. Catra usually tries to pretend she isn't there. "They have a couple of locations in Bright Moon. Glimmer, I think our lilies in the front yard are from their nursery."

Weaver had lilies out front too. Catra remembers how the petals snapped when she pulled flowers instead of weeds. "Can I ask you a question?" she says, before she thinks.

Fujimura is good at hiding her surprise. "Of course."

It's stupid. Even if Fujimura wants to help, she might not be able to. Maybe Catra's just humiliating herself for nothing.

Listen to me, baby girl, Camila said to the kid who would barely look at her. *I'm gonna get out of here, and then I'm gonna be your mom if it's the last thing I do, okay? I promise.* And then Camila was gone, and maybe it was easier to believe that she'd been lying than to think that Catra wasted the only time she had with one of the few people who cared about her.

"I, um - can you do me a favor? After," Catra waves her hand, "all of this is over."

The other conversation continues, in the background. "I'll do my best," Fujimura says, and that's something Catra likes about her. Fujimura doesn't make promises she doesn't know if she can keep.

"You, um. You know people, right? People who know things."

Fujimura nods. "Usually if I don't know where to find a particular piece of information, I know someone who does. What are you looking for?"

"My - my mom, she died. Almost ten years ago, now, and. I just-"

Catra doesn't even know what she wants. It's not like they're going to find a note, or a journal, or anything else that will tell her how Camila really felt. It's not like it *matters*, ten years too late.

Catra says, "It's kind of stupid, at this point, but I just want to know, um, more than what I do now, about her. There wasn't a lot in the file from my worker, and she sure as hell wasn't going to tell me anything that she didn't legally have to."

"There are multiple channels we can explore," Fujimura says, and the softness in her accent doesn't condescend. "Also, the successor of your disgrace of a caseworker might be more forthcoming with any information the department may have."

Catra chances a look at Fujimura, and she looks calm, controlled, shoulders back. There's not an ounce of anger in the air. Fujimura says, "It's worth thinking about if you want to sue the department, when this is over. I think you have grounds. Money isn't going to make up for their failures, but it might change things there going forward. There's no excuse for her misconduct going unchallenged for as long as it was. It was her job to keep you safe, and she didn't even approach that obligation to you."

Catra definitely doesn't want their money, but she hadn't thought about things changing. Milagros had been there for years. How many other kids had been on her caseload? Were they better off without her if the next worker was just as bad? The thought of having to come to court again makes her stomach clench hard enough to hurt. "Maybe," she says. "After all this."

"I'll find out what I can about your mother," Fujimura says. Catra would have identified pity in her voice before, but she isn't sure now. It sounds more like sympathy, she thinks. Fujimura grabs her phone. "What was her name?"

"Camila." Catra can picture her still, when she thinks hard enough. She doesn't know how long she's going to be able to do that. "Guerra, I mean, we have the same last name. I don't, um. Know

where she was in prison, or where she died, or anything, really. Sorry I'm not much help."

"A name gives me a lot." Angella Fujimura looks at her, and she recognizes something in the expression. "You deserve to know about her. You deserve more than that, but if that's what I can do for you, that's what I want to make happen."

Adora wakes up twenty minutes after the sun sets, while Bow tells them the stories he's heard from his dads about the stars. Grass prickles under Catra's fingers, and the city lights up in its own constellations.

Catra has slept like shit all week, but tonight might be the worst. She doesn't testify until Monday, but before court is dismissed for the weekend, Rosetti's scheduled to present evidence.

Catra still gets dreams, shadows thick and choking, red electricity burning her skin, and even though she knows it's not real, it's more terrifying than any memories she has from when she was older. When she told Emily about it, she felt like she was confessing to still having an imaginary friend.

That sounds more resourceful than strange to me, Emily said*. You had to make sense of the situation, and that was how.* Emily didn't know if seeing what really happened would help. Catra doesn't know if it'll ever go away if she doesn't. She knows that's going to be something Horne presses her on, next week, but it's more than that. So much of her life is gone already, and if she can get back any part of it, she wants to grab it with both hands.

Adora begged to see it with her, weeks ago, when Rosetti told her this was coming. She'd argued until she couldn't talk anymore. *I just want to help you,* she said. *I'm sorry I wasn't there before. Let me fix that now.*

I don't want you to see me like that, Catra said. Adora was sick last time, she crashed and panicked and could barely touch her for months. Catra asked Bow instead. If Bow can never talk to her again, afterwards, it'll hurt but she'll survive it. If Adora can't get past it, Catra doesn't know how she'll ever get up again.

The sun dawns pink and gold, sifting through the blinds of their hotel room. While Catra tries to get her hair to lie flat, Adora says, "You don't have to watch it, you know. You don't have to prove anything to anyone."

Catra lets out her breath. "I know I don't have to," she says. "I want to. I - I need to see it."

Adora nods, pressing a kiss to her temple as she passes. "I love you," she says. "I'm proud of you no matter what."

"I love you too," Catra says. She's said it for years, and for so many of them, fear pulsed underneath it. It's strange to realize that *I love you* doesn't mean *please please stay* anymore.

At breakfast, everyone's even more subdued than they've been all week. At least no one's dumb enough to say something that will underscore how much this feels like a funeral. "This is stupid," Catra mumbles to Glimmer, who's waiting for the waffle maker to finish while Catra scoops eggs on her plate.

"Fresh waffles are one of the few pleasures in life," Glimmer says, glancing impatiently at the timer. "They have Nutella packets here, I'm going to have the best breakfast Etheria has ever seen."

"Not that." Catra makes an effort not to slam the lid of the metal serving dish closed. "Everyone acting like they're going to a fucking execution."

"God, I wish." Glimmer must see something different on Catra's face when she looks back, because she turns away from the waffles entirely, shoulders softening. "It's going to be a hard day for everybody, even for us waiting outside. I think we're all just, I don't know. Gearing up."

"You think I shouldn't have asked Bow to stay."

Glimmer shakes her head. "No, he wants to. He's honored that you asked, honestly. Very moved, got all weepy about it. Not that I told you that."

Catra rolls her eyes, but it doesn't make her feel like she's full of worms the way it might have a year ago. Bow asked to hug her, after he agreed, and he's good at hugs.

Glimmer's waffles beep, and Catra brings her plate of eggs and toast to where Adora's poking at a yogurt and sipping from her shaker bottle, listening to Bow tell her about an excavation project his brother's on. Scorpia's meeting them there, but she texted Catra a heart when she woke up, just like she has for every day of the trial so far.

People caring was a web before, waiting for her to stop struggling so they could trap her, tie her down. Now it feels like a net laid out to land in before she hits the ground, and she doesn't know when that changed.

Adora kisses her before she's supposed to leave the courtroom, lips soft and warm. "Remember," Adora says, voice cracking, "aquarium after court."

"Gonna find a fish as ugly as you," Catra says, grabbing her hand to squeeze it.

Adora squeezes back, face twitching where she's clearly trying to seem okay, and Catra suddenly doesn't know why she wanted Adora to leave. Adora *has* seen her like this. She's seen Catra furious and cruel, empty and limp, sobbing and choking and covered in snot, but she's still here.

"You can stay," Catra says, "if you want to."

Adora sits back down, knees pointed towards hers. She looks over Catra's shoulder, probably at Bow and Catra can hear him getting

up behind her. She'd have to turn away from Adora to look, so she doesn't. "I always want to," Adora says.

There weren't many people here to begin with, and with Bow and Glimmer and Scorpia gone, it feels emptier. A tall woman takes notes on a yellow pad, and Catra can't imagine being able to have that level of distance. She doesn't look to see if Weaver is here, because she doesn't want to know if she is.

"Ladies and gentlemen," Rosetti tells the jury, "what you're about to see will be difficult to watch. But it's a testament to the defendant's seemingly endless capacity for cruelty. In particular, I'll draw your attention to the child's face, and I think you'll find that her identity cannot be in question."

Catra hates when Rosetti talks about her like she's a prop, a tragic little pathetic creature to pull out tears. She fell off playground equipment once, and she half-thinks she'd intended to splat on the ground instead of thudding on mulch. When she cried the substitute crouched down next to her and said *oh you poor thing*, and Catra bit the hand that got too close to her face, and then the sub said something else.

The video's hazy, looking older than it could possibly be. There are dolls that look more real than this kid does, mistake eyes wide, shirt loose on over narrow shoulders, face blank. Weaver in the mask looms, snarls, and Adora flinches harder than Catra does when a slap echoes. Adora sandwiches her hand between both of hers, and when she tightens her grip neither of their hands can shake.

Weaver looks different from here. Catra's brain skitters away from remembering the mask, most of the time. Even now, when she's old enough to stop seeing smoke spilling out from under it, when she knows it's a video and the only person near her is Adora, she has to fight not to shut down when she sees it. She has nightmares with a spidering creature with a red face, long nightmarish limbs, and maybe that's what it looked like from

where the kid looks up, but from the wall where the camera sits Weaver looks human again. It's not an improvement.

Her voice distorts when she talks, and Catra's not sure if that's in the video or her own head. *Something's fucking wrong with you. Are you like this on purpose? I swear, sometimes I feel like you were put on this earth to make my life hell.* The kid shakes its head, and it doesn't look like much of a monster like this. It looks like a girl Catra might see at work, trailing her mom's shopping cart, complaining that all the other kids bring Oreos for snack and it's not fair that she only gets pretzels. Catra's always been a good actor.

Weaver wrenches her fingers in the kid's hair, pulling its head sharp, and the kid's eyes squeeze shut, arms jumping at its sides before dropping. *Do you think I'm blind? I'm always watching, you dumb piece of shit. I know what you're doing.* The kid says something, mouth moving, but it's too quiet to hear. *Only you'd be stupid enough to lie to me,* Weaver says, shoving the kid to the floor. *I know what you are. I know what's in your sick little head.*

Catra floods cold. Weaver said it often enough, she shouldn't be surprised. For all she knows, it was in the one Adora saw already, but Adora still has such glowing memories of this kid, so she can't know about this. Adora's still holding her hand - tighter now, as she probably notices Catra freeze up - but Adora's good at looking away, too.

Catra should be watching what's happening instead of following their shadows spilling out on the floor around them, stretching out towards the walls. They don't hold the kid down, don't hurt it, because Weaver's angry hands do that. But they're there, reflecting how the kid and Weaver move. *Come on, brat, you can take it. Don't act like this wasn't what you wanted.* The kid doesn't move much. But it winces and cries, loud and pathetic even after Weaver shoves its shirt in its mouth to shut it up.

The kid's little animal eyes glaze fast, and Catra half-wonders what it's pretending is happening instead. Catra imagined a lot of

things, before she got good at blinking out. Sometimes she was a ghost, slipping out of her bones and up through the floor. Sometimes she beamed up into a spaceship, sent into the deepest emptiest space, where no one existed for light-years around her. Once, there was a fly on the wallpaper, and she imagined having red scaly eyes, six hairy legs, small and fast enough to dodge anything coming through the air to squish her.

Maybe it's pretending that the shadows are turning on it, buzzing static on its skin. Maybe that was easier than having to admit that this person was going to walk it to the bus stop in the morning.

The kid stiffens when Weaver digs in deeper, biting down on the fabric in its mouth while wounded sounds keen out of it, and the echo of that pain slices through Catra, sharp as a blade. Weaver's a human instead of a spider but still so much bigger, stronger. A predator tearing off chunks from a carcass with her teeth.

Stop that whining before I shut you up for good, Weaver says over the noise, steel in her voice, and the kid spasms before it quiets. Even as fuzzy as the video is, the kid is shaking badly, chest snapping with aborted sobs. Catra remembers the fear, suffocating like the feet of dirt over her that she might not deserve to have.

Sometimes, when they were a few years older than this kid, Catra would wake up to Adora holding her hand an inch from her face to feel her breath. *Sorry,* she'd whisper, pulling back. *Bad dream.* Catra doesn't know if this kid has curled up behind the bush yet, waiting to see if she'll feel the ice crystals form in her blood or if her whole body will be numb by the time she freezes. She doesn't know if she's already trying to think of how to put herself out of her misery before Weaver gets the chance.

Everyone can see, but only Catra can feel how the carpet rasps on her back, how the wallpaper pattern spins dizzying around them until she can tell herself that that's why she feels sick. Only Catra knows that when it's over and the video cuts and the light goes out, the kid's going to roll over as much as she can and hit the

floor until her hand hurts too much to keep going, and then yank fibers out of the carpet until she's too tired to do even that, and then close her eyes and dream about being anywhere else on earth.

On the screen, Catra flails an arm, and Weaver slams it down hard enough to send a sharp pain up to her shoulder. A scream rips out of her throat, loud even through her shirt. Weaver's hand is big enough to fit over her mouth and nose and press tight, and Catra writhes in silence.

Oh, little monster. The anger in Weaver's voice has gone cold, mocking. *Maybe I should dispose of you now, save us both some trouble. No one will miss you*.

Adora makes a desolate noise next to her, quiet, and Catra jolts, chest burning where her breath was frozen. She'd thought about Adora too, when she was pretending to be somewhere else. Sometimes, the only thing that got her walking after Weaver made her stand up was thinking about washing this off and going to Adora, where she could be a person again.

Adora flinches when Catra collapses into her, but her arms come up tight around Catra's back. When Catra turns her head to press her ear to Adora's chest, her hand comes up to cover the other, blocking the sound coming out of the speakers. With her eyes closed, all she can see is dark, safe. Catra can hear Adora's heartbeat through her shirt, loud, strong even when it skitters, and she can breathe again.

She blurs, then, fading in the safety of Adora's arms. She doesn't know how long it is until the sound changes, dropping lower, larger. Catra pulls back enough to hear shoes shuffling on the floor, doors opening. "They're taking a break," Adora says, chest vibrating when she talks, voice ragged. Her hand shifts off Catra's ear to stroke the hair over her temple. "How can I help?"

"You are." Catra's mouth is clumsy. Something presses into her hand, and it's one of her sour candies wrapped in cellophane. It's

hard to open one-handed, so Adora holds one end to let Catra untwist it. Green apple bursts sharp on her tongue, and slowly works her back into her body. She can hear sobs, but Adora's breath is steady, and when Catra touches her own face it's dry.

"It's somebody on the jury," Adora says. "A couple people."

Catra tilts her head to look, but she spots Weaver first. She can only see the back of Weaver's head from here, hair long and dark against her blue dress. She turns to say something to Horne, and Catra's surprised for a moment to see skin instead of smooth red where her face should be.

Catra looks down, pets over Wrong Melog's thick fur. When she focuses, she can imagine it purring like real Melog does. She never had a stuffed animal, when she was a kid. She thinks she might have liked one.

"You know I would have missed you," Adora says, tears in her voice. "Right then, I know I was missing you. Whenever I heard, I would - I would wait for you to come up. I couldn't sleep when I heard you."

"I know," Catra says. "She lies. She always has."

Adora circles her hand on Catra's back, while Catra sifts her fingers through Wrong Melog's fur. "Did it help?"

Catra feels worse than she did this morning, raw and aching. But instead of monsters and magic, she remembers the same woman it's always been, and the same child. *I'm proud of that little girl,* Emily said a few months ago, when they talked about the shadows. *She figured out how to live through an impossible situation by herself. Nobody taught her how, and it must have been so hard, but she survived it anyway.* At the time Catra snapped back that she was done talking about it, fury and disgust churning in her stomach, and Emily let her change the subject. Emily sounds a little less crazy, now.

"I think so," Catra says. "How are you?"

"I don't know." The circles Adora's tracing don't pause. "But thank you, for letting me be here."

Quick steps make Catra turn her head, sit up. Adora's hand stays planted on her back, grounding, when Bow drops into the seat next to them. "You okay? Both of you?"

Catra tries to stand and her legs noodle out before she manages to get more than an inch off the chair. Bow catches Wrong Melog before it falls and Adora steadies her with an open palm, not grabbing. Catra says, "Working on it."

"We're going to be alright," Adora says, as Scorpia appears next to her. "Thank you."

Something taps Catra's shoulder, cold even through her shirt. A soda bottle, condensation on the bubbled plastic. When she looks behind her, Glimmer looks back, wiping her hand on the side of her skirt to dry it.

"Sprite?" Catra says. "Really? Is my day not bad enough?"

"The machine didn't have Coke." Glimmer smiles back and it's strained. She keeps looking at Adora, furrow in her forehead. "I think you'll live. Adversity builds character."

"And you call yourself my friend." The bottle is cold in her hands. She's not allowed to drink it in here - isn't sure Glimmer was technically even allowed to bring it in - but the cold is good.

Bow gestures at Wrong Melog. "Can I pet them too?" he asks, even though he was literally just holding it.

Catra shifts it closer to him. "Go nuts."

He scratches behind Wrong Melog's ears, the way real Melog likes it. "I'm glad you're here," Bow says out of nowhere. "In general. I know you didn't ask, but I wanted to make sure I said that."

Catra doesn't know what to say. She shrugs. "Had help," she says. "Keep having help. Like, literally from you."

"And I'm glad I can help. I like being your friend."

Catra doesn't want to look back at the table where Weaver's sitting. She doesn't want to know if Weaver can see her like this, vulnerable in a different way than she'd ever been in front of her.

"I fucking hope so," Catra says, "because I think you're stuck with me now."

Bow's teeth flash white in his mouth when he smiles, back of his hand bumping hers, and that's what landing in the net must be like.

They go to the Thaymor Aquarium after they're dismissed from court, the way they planned. Catra's class had a field trip here, sometime in elementary school. Ms. Torres came to the classroom, said *let's take a walk,* which is when she told Catra that she couldn't go. *This isn't a punishment,* she said, *we just can't trust you to be safe there.* She had to spend the day with Ms. Torres instead, helping her organize the decompression room toys, picking coloring pages to copy, washing the stretchy strings that had collected lint. On the way home, Adora gave her a map with jellyfish on it, and Catra managed to keep it for almost three weeks before the next time she got so angry she started ripping anything she could reach.

She's wanted to come here for years, but today her attention skitters. This was Adora's idea, and she tries to care about what Adora's saying about the similarities between a human and whale skeleton. She can recognize Adora trying to distract her, and usually it works better than this. The hairs on the back of her neck stand up and don't go down, like Weaver's watching and waiting

for her to fuck up and prove she isn't supposed to be here. *I said you could come out when you could act like a person, and you're just not capable of that, are you?*

"Catra?"

She blinks at the placard she definitely isn't reading. "Yeah?"

Adora's eyes flicker over to Bow and Scorpia and Glimmer, who are cooing over penguins. "Come with me," Adora says, taking her arm, and Catra would follow Adora anywhere.

When they get to the tunnel, fish swimming past and over them, Adora stops to face her. It's quiet here on a Friday afternoon. Adora runs her hands down her arms and Catra feels the tension flow out. "What's wrong?"

Catra shakes her head. "I don't know."

Adora swallows. "Are you still thrown off from earlier? That's okay. I know I am."

Maybe. She feels too naked today, like one of the ventworms painted on the walls, soft places stuck out of the rock. "I don't know. I just-"

The words keep repeating in her ears, *I know what's in your sick little head.* That's not going to go away, no matter how thick the walls around Weaver's prison are.

"Take as much time as you need," Adora says, trailing down to her hands to hold them.

She closes her eyes, breathes. Catra needs to just tell her. Adora's never spit her out, no matter what she finds. She knows Catra isn't who she used to be.

A toddler runs past them, disappearing into the room past them, apologetic parents trailing behind. "We'll talk when we go home, or back to the hotel or whatever," Catra says. She focuses on

slowing down how quickly her heartbeat slams. "Let's just - I want to think about something else for once."

"Yeah," Adora says. She squeezes Catra's hands before she lets them go. "Bow says there's sharks around here somewhere."

Everyone else is there when they find them. Bow and Glimmer banter about whether sharks are smooth, and Scorpia makes faces at the stingray, and Adora tries to match the tropical fish in the tank with the laminated guide. "Help me find this red one," Adora says, tapping a fish on the corner of the guide. "It's supposed to be here somewhere."

Catra spots a lumpy gray face peeking out of a hole in the rock. "Look," she says, "found that fish I was talking about."

Adora squints at it, and then at her guide. "That's a wolf-eel. I'm looking for a rosy-"

"No," Catra says, grinning. "The one as ugly as you."

The uneasy feeling won't go away. It's silly, because she's with her friends, she's with Adora, Weaver's in a cell with guards keeping her from getting out. She has a whole weekend before she has to think about court again, she shouldn't still be on edge.

When she ducks out to the bathroom after an hour, it's less because she needs to and more just to be behind another door that locks. There's two empty family bathrooms, and she's ready to sit on the floor in silence for a few minutes while she figures out how to get her stupid body to calm down for once.

A foot slides into the bathroom door before it closes, and the door pushes in enough to let someone else through. Horne locks the door behind him, eyes narrowing. He's taller than Weaver and almost as broad as Scorpia, casting shadows that crawl up the wall. Catra tightens her grip on her bag, calculating where she can swing it to knock him down.

"Ms. Guerra, forgive my indelicacy. It's just so hard to find you without your guard dogs."

"Get the fuck away from me," Catra says. Her tongue sticks in her dry mouth.

Horne shakes his head. "It is not my intent to harm you. I merely wish to discuss the situation as it stands. I'm confident we can come to an agreement."

"This isn't a fucking negotiation," Catra spits, aware of the bag in her hands and ready to swing. She's not an idiot. If this was a conversation they were supposed to be having, if he wanted it to be a conversation at all, they wouldn't be having it in a single-stall bathroom. "The situation is that I show up and tell the jury what that bitch is and you lie to them about it. That's it."

Horne raises an eyebrow. "Do you know how hard it is to get something completely removed from the internet?" His eyes are too bright, glowing green. "The crown reports that they have a hundred and sixty-three files. Not copies, distinct files. You have no idea how many there really are, do you?"

Weaver could have recorded it every time, when her hands were burned and weeping, when she had a final in the morning and she was trying to review parts of a cell whenever she surfaced, when she'd been locked in for four days and her nails were bleeding from peeling up wallpaper. There have to be hundreds.

"It's way too late to try to blackmail me with that," Catra says. Her skin is numb. "If she wanted to use them to shut me up, she should have kept them to herself in the first place."

"I noticed that nearly all of your people left today." Horne tilts his head and it's so like Weaver that she wants to turn and vomit in the toilet behind her. "How many do you want them to see?"

Catra listens to her breath coming in through her nose, out through her mouth. It's too fast. She forces herself to *think*. Giving her more evidence against Weaver makes no sense. He

doesn't mean it. He's desperate, because they're winning and Weaver's going to rot in prison until she dies and he knows it.

"Did Weaver send you because she's scared," Catra says, heart skittering, "or is this your terrible idea because *you're* scared?"

Horne bursts forward. He grabs her hair, her hip, and her arms stop striking out. Her mind goes dead silent. "Impressive," she hears. "That works even better than Stella said it would."

She had something in her hands a second ago. Her knees are buckling, everything collapsing, and if she's lucky she'll blink out and wake up alone. Weaver always said a man would be worse. She said a lot of things. A quiet corner of her head is starting to panic about how long it will take before someone comes looking for her, and she liked these clothes, and she doesn't know if he has a condom, and-

"Here is what will happen, little one." Horne lowers her on her melting knees, leans her against the wall. "You can take the stand on Monday and tell the jury that you wanted to punish my client for the crime of raising you, or you can vanish. Obviously I have a strong preference, but I'm generous enough to grant you a choice."

Catra can feel the cool tile under her knees, against her shoulders. Hear the drip of the faucet. Smell whatever lemon bullshit that gets used to clean this place. "Tell Weaver to go fuck herself," she manages, forcing the words between her teeth.

Horne's hand is still fisted in her hair. He turns her head to look up at him, and her puppet body doesn't resist. "From what I saw this morning," Horne smirks, "you'd rather she fuck you. Quite an appetite you had, didn't you?"

Catra was there too, she heard how she screamed as she was dying. She doesn't remember how to scream now. Horne's forearm lies across her cheek and she manages not to lean into it even though carpet is gravel on her neck and red flashes across

her vision when she blinks. He moves her again and a sound jumps out of her chest without her, low and broken. Horne hums a *shh* over it.

"Relax, little one," he says. "There is no need for you to suffer."

This isn't supposed to happen anymore, she thinks, dizzy. Emily talked for hours about how Catra's supposed to be in charge of what happens to her, and Netossa did too, but here she is again. She always knew those rules didn't apply to her. Monsters don't get to pretend to be people.

"Stella said that she never gave you enough credit," Horne says, thumb idly shifting on the bone of her hip. "She said you're smarter than you look. She also said, if she's indisposed, you'll need someone else to keep you in line. Ms. Castillo isn't capable of it, is she?"

Adora. She's a couple rooms over, watching jellyfish, dappled light drifting over her. Catra can let her ghost go find her while this happens, and ask her what the sign says, and let the sound of her voice hum on her jangled nerves. Her body is moving, tile hard under her, but she can push that away and remember how it feels to have Adora next to her instead.

Adora looks at her, gray eyes deep. *You promised.*

Yeah, Catra says, tightening their clasped hands. *I'm here. It's okay.*

"-more compliant than she led me to believe." The voice is far enough away that maybe it was one of the fish.

You promised you'd take care of you too, Adora says. The tentacles behind her head look too soft to sting. *It can't just be my job.*

Catra's chest seizes. *You saw me this morning. This is what I am. This is what happens.*

No, Adora says, *that's what Weaver told you, because she was tired of being fought.* Adora lifts their hands, nails catching the blue light, and Adora's teeth flash. *You've never listened to anyone in your life. Are you really going to start now?*

Catra always tried to run from the sensations, disappear so she didn't have to hear or feel or taste, but she digs into them now. Her shoulder blades ache on the tile. Under the cleaning scent is a smell like ozone, a cologne maybe. She tastes metal, harsh on her tongue. Her scalp prickles where he's still holding her hair.

His other hand runs along her face, brushing her lips, thumb slipping barely past where they lie open and lax. *This doesn't happen anymore*. Catra jerks her head enough for her teeth to reach skin and she bites past tasting blood. Horne makes the pained noise now. She bucks, driving her knee up hard until it hits resistance, and she strikes again, again, again, snapping like a spring released. She can't smell his cologne over the smell of blood.

He comes down harder, pinning her legs to the ground, forearm against her throat and pressing down with his whole weight, and *no no not anymore.*

"What a shame." Horne's voice echoes with another beneath it while Catra slams her fists against his arms and clamps her jaw with all the energy she has. "Some creatures are destined only for destruction."

It's the same, burning in her chest and screaming in her head, but she can't even gasp with her teeth locked in his flesh. She can't panic, but the way to stop panicking is to breathe and she can't - she can't-

Come on, Catra, Adora says against her ear. *You're not done. Not yet.*

Her thrashing hand finds something and she rips with everything she has. Once, twice, and then Horne rears back, hiss sharp in

her ears. She keeps kicking, punching, all the jagged fury that's bottled in her core since she watched herself die this morning, maybe since the first time she was pinned down and she got up different. "No," she says, and she sounds too loud to her own ears even over the pained grunt she knocks out of him. His face is open with blood, eye flooding red, and she only pulls away when he reaches for her again.

She stops running when she's breathing hard enough to struggle. She's outside, and she has no idea where she is. The building she's next to has steps, so she sits. She fixes the button on her pants when she finds it undone. Her mouth still tastes like blood, and when she wipes her lips her fingers come back tacky red. People walk past and Horne's not going to attack her again on the sidewalk, even if he comes after her. She's not too far gone to know that.

She finds her phone in her pocket. She has two missed calls. "Catra," Adora says, "is everything okay?"

"Yeah," Catra says, autopilot. Adora's saying something else but she doesn't hear it. Her throat hurts when she swallows, but if it's anything like the first time there will be no marks. She can find a way to explain away the blood on her shirt. If she's careful no one will see where her arms and legs might bruise. She can pretend this didn't happen like she did a thousand times before, and then she'll have a chance to look at Weaver in court and tell her to have fun in hell.

Weaver's in jail because of what she's done. Horne should be too.

Catra says, "No," and Adora stops talking. "No, I, um. I need help."

"Where are you? Are you safe right now?"

"Yeah, I'm outside somewhere, I just - I ran for a long time."

Adora's quiet for a moment, and Catra can hear her freaking out from here. Catra says, "Weaver's lawyer, he found me. Wanted to

- like Weaver did. Anyway. I got away."

Adora's breath is sharp. "Oh," she says. "Are you-"

"I hurt him. I think - maybe pretty bad."

"Good." There's a rich current of anger under Adora's voice, and when Catra knows it isn't directed at her, it makes her feel giddy, like when Weaver was arrested. "Whatever you did, he deserved worse."

Catra shares her location with Adora when she asks. "I'm coming," Adora says, "just stay where you are."

Catra sits on the step while blood dries on the tips of her fingers. The sun is warm on her face. Adora hasn't hung up the phone, and she keeps talking about nothing. "I'm almost there," she says, more than once. Catra lets it drum like rain against her ear, lets Adora's voice calm her like it has for years.

Chapter End Notes

▶ Tap for summary from court onwards

They're going to be okay, I promise. Happy ending incoming. Next chapter should be up in the next week or two, or whenever I stop fussing with it. I'm doing better than I was - thank you all for your support.

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora flies down the street, Bow at her heels. She can see Catra from a block away, drawing her like a magnet. There's a dark stain on her shirt, tuck loose, and Adora tries to focus on keeping her feet under her in her slippery flats instead of worrying about that.

Catra jumps up when she sees her, relief splashing across her face under the smeared blood. "It's not mine," she says, loud enough for Adora to hear.

Adora gets close enough to pull her in, where Adora can hear her breathe and know that she's ~~safe~~ ~~okay~~ alive, but Catra steps back before they can touch. Of course she needs space right now. Adora's never stopped being selfish.

"You gotta call Angella," Catra says, all in a rush. Adora doesn't think she's ever heard Catra call Angella by her name. "We need to - she'll know how to handle stuff, with the police."

"What?"

"It's-" Catra gestures with a red-streaked hand. "Evidence and shit. I need it to put him away, right? Lonnie said if you mess with the," she swallows, "crime scene, it destroys all that. So call, so we can get this over with. I don't have her number, or I would do it, but-"

"No, I can, I can." Adora forces air into her lungs. It doesn't help. She tries to get her phone out of her pocket but her fingers keep slipping on the unfamiliar slacks. Bow pulls up next to her, breathing harder than Adora's panic wants her to, and Catra tells him to call because Adora's clearly incapable of it.

Adora thought she was helping, this morning. She could *do* something, then, but now all she can do is look at Catra covered in blood and press down her every instinct screaming to fix it. She's useless again. Horne found Adora outside of court too, days ago. If Adora had told Angella, or Rosetti, or *anyone*—

"Adora." Catra's voice is firm. "Look at me."

Red smears her lips, jaw, chin. It flakes dried from her fingers, darker where it settled into the knuckles. Above it all, her eyes blaze. "They didn't kill me, either of them," Catra says. "And I'm going to make sure they both fucking regret that, okay? Are you going to help me?"

"Any way I can," Adora says, and they're the truest words she's ever spoken.

They're all exhausted when they get back to the hotel, after Angella carries them through the police report and the assessment at the hospital. Glimmer brought clothes from their suitcase, green shirt and leggings that Catra had packed for lazing around the hotel tomorrow, but instead she's sliding onto the bed, fatigue written into every inch of her, when Adora triple-checks that the door is locked behind them.

"C'mere," Catra says, arm out, and Adora doesn't even take off her shoes before she crawls onto the bed with her. Catra pulls Adora flush to her like she can blur their borders if she tries hard enough. She buries her face in Adora's neck, hair-tremor running through her as Adora strokes down her spine.

Adora brings her other hand to the back of Catra's head, but her fingers barely touch before Catra makes a quiet sound that Adora can't interpret until she says, "No, not my hair."

"Okay," Adora pulls her hand back. She heard the skeleton of the story, at the station. She knows they had to wipe her hair for DNA. The horror of that feels far away, next to Catra stopping her when she needs to. "Thank you, for telling me. How can I help?"

Catra finds her hand, lacing their fingers. "Stay," she says.

Adora puts a little pressure against Catra's back, into the point of contact that she didn't tell her to change, so they can both feel that neither of them are going anywhere. "Nothing could make me leave."

Catra shifts enough to look at Adora's face. Light spills in on her cheekbones, freckles scattered in constellations. "I could. If I wanted you to. You would let me."

Adora wants to kiss her. "Yes, always. Do you want me to go?"

Catra pulls close again, arm tight around Adora's waist, hand squeezing hers. "Don't fucking dare."

Adora closes her eyes, and opens them again when all she can see is Horne's face. What would have happened, if she'd told someone? Would it have even mattered? Would someone else have attacked Catra if Horne didn't?

"She liked to grab it," Catra says, voice even but not flat. "My hair. Just to - made it easy to move me around, I guess. Put me wherever she wanted me. Maybe that's why she took it, when she was going to kill me, I don't know."

Adora presses her lips together, trying not to remember what the slices on her scalp had looked like. She can't think about that, right now, not when Adora is useless to keep her safe.

Catra laughs, short and harsh. "Joke's on her though." She brings their clasped hands to the ends of her hair, just past her shoulders, voice thick with victory. "She got rid of the shit she touched, this is *mine*."

"It was yours then too," Adora says, and if she pulls Catra tighter to her chest maybe it'll stop aching. "All of you has always been yours."

Catra's muscles settle. "I think she told him what made me - shut down. What's the word? Dissociate. He said she told him about me."

Adora hums so Catra knows she's listening, hand stirring firm along her spine the way that she's always calmed her, and if Adora draws comfort from it too that's okay. If she pays attention to Catra's back moving with the rhythm of her breathing, she can't think about when they were almost in this position, Catra staring half-lidded and limp and if Adora wasn't touching her, knowing she was warm, she might not have believed she was alive. Adora knows it isn't either of their fault, now, but the memory still hurts. She doesn't know if there will be a time when it doesn't. Catra's almost as soft in her arms now, but that comfort is real, this time.

"I thought he was going to-" Catra flinches, light. "He was there and I couldn't - for a long time I couldn't do anything. I was so scared."

Adora strokes her thumb over Catra's knuckle, rocks them slowly with her breath. *You're safe now, you're okay,* she wants to say, another comforting lie she can't let herself believe. "I've got you," she says instead, and Catra burrows deeper into her arms.

They must fall asleep like that, because the light through the blinds is weak when someone unlocks their door. Adora tightens her grip, because she told Catra no one else could get her to leave and she meant it. It's Glimmer, hair glinting in the dim light. "Hey," she says, and Adora isn't embarrassed enough to move. "My mom wants to talk to you guys. Or just you, I guess, if Catra's asleep."

Catra stirs but doesn't wake. Adora swallows so she doesn't cry. "I can't leave."

"Mom's in the hallway, you guys can be right outside the door. I'll stay here. She has an update I think you should hear."

The possibility that Angella knows what's going on is what gets Adora out of bed. Angella is as calm as always in the empty hallway, checking something on her phone. "How are you doing?" Angella says.

Adora can't believe she has to ask, she'd been with them all afternoon. "She's exhausted," Adora says. "I don't think anyone can expect her to be okay right now."

"I'm concerned about Catra too," Angella says, "but how are *you* doing?"

Something wells like blood in her chest. Adora bites her lip so she doesn't totally lose it. "Glimmer said you had an update."

"Horne is in custody," Angella says. "At the hospital."

Adora thinks of all the things she would do to make him stay there. After Catra called, Adora would have torn the building apart looking for him if Catra hadn't needed her more than Adora needed to rip his throat out. "How bad did she get him?"

"From what I was told, he has a number of lacerations to his face, especially the lower eyelid, and extensive damage to the eye itself. They put stitches in his eyelid and the bite wound on his hand. Surgery was performed on his eye, but they're not sure if it'll ever work again. The detective I spoke to said he was in a lot of pain when he came in." Angella sounds like she does when she talks about the work Glimmer does at LUNA, proud. "You can both get some rest, for the time being. I expect we'll be able to return to Bright Moon in the next day or so. There's no judge in Etheria that wouldn't declare a mistrial under these circumstances, even if Horne was in any state to appear, which it seems that he isn't."

"He cornered me too. On the first day." Adora shifts her weight and manages not to throw up. "He didn't - touch me, at all. He just talked. I, um. I got upset, but it wasn't-" *breathe*, "it wasn't like this."

"He shouldn't have been speaking to you outside of court," Angella says, in her talking-to-survivors-voice that doesn't belong here. "That would have justified a mistrial on its own."

"And that's what I was afraid of." Adora realizes she's gripping her fists too hard, digging in her nails, when her palms begin to ache. She doesn't know who she's trying to keep her composure for. She doesn't work for Angella anymore, it doesn't matter if she thinks Adora's not tough enough. She already knows. "I didn't want to know if it wasn't okay because I could handle it, I didn't want us to have to do this again - I just wanted this to finally be over - it's supposed to be *over*-"

"Adora," Angella says. "Take a breath."

"It's never going to be over. We're just going to keep living it all again and again and - I kept my mouth shut, just like always, just - and now Catra's hurt *again* and if I'd just-"

"Adora," Angella repeats, which is when Adora notices how fast she's talking. Angella speaks slowly, smooth as water. "Nothing that happened to either of you when you were children was your fault. I do wish you'd felt like you could speak up about Horne, because you shouldn't have had to interact with him after he ambushed you, but this isn't your fault either."

"I know I couldn't - do anything, when we were little, but I could have stopped this if-"

"If you'd known that Horne's conversation with you was improper, and if you'd known that he was later going to attack someone, Catra or not, would you have reported him?"

Adora hopes so. She nods when the words don't come out.

Angella's voice is softness over steel. "You didn't make this happen, Adora. Only Horne gets the blame for what he's done."

Adora swallows bile. She feels very small, suddenly, a bottle tossed in the waves. She can't stop Catra from getting hurt. She's

useless.

"I know today is difficult," Angella says, "but you will get through this. Catra showed incredible strength today, and so did you."

If Adora ever had strength, she can't find it now. The tears slip past her. "I don't want Catra to have to be strong or brave or anything else," Adora says, words cracking in the middle. "I want her to be *safe*. I want to tell her nothing like this will ever happen again and I want to be telling the truth."

Adora can't look at the face Angella makes then. "I wish I could promise you that, Adora."

"But I can't-" Adora takes a breath when her voice goes high and twists. "I can't do it. I can't keep watching her get hurt."

Angella's quiet for a moment. When she speaks, her accent is thicker than before. "It was very difficult for me, when Micah died. It was sudden - he kissed me goodbye one morning and by the afternoon he was gone. With my parents, there had been some time to prepare, but when Micah passed, we had no warning. As much of a nightmare as every part of that experience was, the hardest part was watching my daughter have to go through it too."

Her eyes shift to the door behind Adora, where Glimmer's keeping vigil. "I lost my husband, but it's not the same as losing a father, especially as young as Glimmer was. It was challenging for quite some time, for both of us. But Micah and I raised her to be resilient, and she made it through the time of crisis, and she keeps making it through every day we have to live without him. Someday I'm going to pass as well, though I hope not for decades, and I know that will be awful for Glimmer. But she'll survive that too."

Adora doesn't feel like she's surviving, today. "I'm trying," she says, wiping her eyes like she can shove the tears back inside. "I know I'm supposed to be better than this."

"There's no 'supposed to,' Adora, not for this. There's no 'better' either. Everyone copes in their own way."

This isn't even the worst it's ever been. This isn't Catra sobbing in her arms when her mom died, or hollow and quiet with a rope in her hands, or shoving her icy face in Adora's neck to muffle her cries while her fingers thawed. This isn't standing frozen in the corner, waiting to see if she'd be allowed to help Catra off the linoleum or if she'd hear screaming through the floor later. "I used to be able to power through, though. All the time. Something awful would happen and I'd keep going like nothing had - but now-"

Now she needs to go back to Catra, and stay next to her for the rest of their lives, because it's always been true that if they're holding each other they're okay. Now she's losing the fight not to sob in the hallway, another thing she's gotten worse at.

"That's a good thing," Angella says, voice soft. "You're not blocking yourself off to survive anymore. You're safe, so your brain is allowing you to feel the things that were too dangerous before."

"We're not safe!" Adora takes a deep breath, and then another, until she thinks she'll make sense when she speaks. "Anyone could just come up to her and - even if she can fight them all, I don't want her to have to. We shouldn't have to. It was supposed to be over."

Angella moves her arms out to the sides, and it takes Adora an embarrassingly long time to realize that she can hug her. There's a scent on Angella's clothes that reminds her of Razz, mild and floral. "We can't promise the people we love that they'll never hurt again," Angella says. "But we can support each other, so we recover. That's all anyone can do."

Glimmer's showing Catra something on her phone when Adora comes back in. Catra draws Adora in next to her, like she can barely tolerate the distance too. "Bow won't play this game with

Twinkle anymore, so now someone thinks she's going to get another sucker." Catra's voice doesn't match the words, smooth and low the way she does when she's trying to soothe.

"Then you are chicken," Glimmer says.

"I'm prioritizing." Catra brushes her thumb under Adora's eye, where her rubbing hands didn't get all the moisture. "What did Sparkles Senior say?"

"They got him. You sent him to the hospital."

In court, Rosetti wanted the jury to see two children, beaten and broken and helpless. Horne tried to show two adults, angry and vengeful and scheming. Watching the vicious smile splash on Catra's face, Adora feels more like Horne's version of them, and she doesn't think that's a bad thing.

Four other people come forward by the time Horne is indicted, all connected to former clients being charged with production. He takes a plea deal for twenty-five years before any more women surface, and before forensics finishes with his computer. His glass eye wanders. Stella Weaver's trial is rescheduled for the following January, to give her new lawyer time to prepare.

Angella asks Adora to come by LUNA a few weeks later. "When you're able," she says, but Adora recognizes how Angella sounds when she's trying to break bad news.

"Hey," Glimmer says, swiveling in her chair as Adora goes past, but she can't stop. Angella didn't ask for Catra, and Adora knows why.

Angella's office door is too loud when it shuts. She looks up, phone to her ear, and when she sees Adora her face flickers. "Let

me call you back," she tells whoever's on the other end of the line, and Adora drops into the chair across from her.

"How have you been?" Angella asks.

"Just tell me whatever it is," Adora says. She pushes a hand down on her jumping thigh. "Or show me. I know there's something."

Angella turns to unlock her computer, and Adora was right. She's never wanted to be wrong so badly in her life. "I'm going to show you an image," Angella says, "and I'd like you to tell me if you recognize this place."

Adora nods, sour taste on her tongue already. She doesn't know what she's more scared of - that it'll be something she remembers or something she doesn't. Adora was an infant when Mara died, and she was the only child in the house for two years, and she doesn't want to think about those facts too long.

Angella turns the monitor around, and she knows those walls. Her bed is made like always, birthday cards and awards and Catra's drawings taped to the wall by her bed, and she can see the edges of some of the trophies she won. There's a thick layer of pixeled grain over everything, and Adora's seen that before. There are no people in frame, but Adora did enough in and around that bed, when she thought she was alone.

"Yeah," she says, having to clear her throat halfway through. There's none of the horror she felt last time. Just a big hollow numbness where what she's feeling should be. "Yeah, that was my room. At her house."

Angella spins the monitor back. "That's what I suspected," she says, voice soft.

One thought is able to worm to the surface of Adora's frozen mind. "How - do we know how far it spread?"

"A woman in Alwyn was arrested earlier this month," Angella says, "for material she was producing. She had a collection of hard

drives that she said she didn't have the passwords to. She said she was storing them for a friend."

That should be good news. The crown police told Catra that it would be easier to hunt down the videos they'd already identified, and if Weaver's files have been found then they know exactly how many there are to try to get rid of. Adora's been so guilty about having given Weaver time to hide them. This has to be good for the case against her, too.

It doesn't feel like good news.

"None of the footage with you matches anything in our databases," Angella says. "I think it's entirely possible that it never left this hard drive."

Adora feels distantly like she's supposed to be grateful for that. She's not. She says, "The kids that were there, after us. Did she hurt them too?"

Angella says, "You know I'm only allowed to talk to you about your own case," which might as well be yes.

Adora doesn't scream. There's no point.

"Adora." Angella leans forward, and Adora bends towards her despite herself, always starving for something from her. "This isn't your fault. Many people should have stopped her years ago, and none of them did. At no point was that ever your responsibility."

"I know," Adora says. The pit of guilt isn't gone, but it's much more shallow than it used to be. Even if she still finds herself in it sometimes, she knows she doesn't belong there. "But it isn't fair."

Angella nods, face heavy. "It isn't."

They call Catra together. Angella explains about the woman in Alwyn, why Adora's here. Catra says she's coming to get her. Bow works at the archery range now, but Glimmer takes one look at Adora before she asks if she can hug her. Adora says yes before

she can think. It helps though. Glimmer's hair smells like strawberries.

When Catra arrives, she holds Adora like she's trying to keep her from flying apart. "I've got you," Catra says, heart steady under Adora's ear.

A week later, Adora wakes up in the dark, cars rushing outside. Catra's warm against her chest, and for a moment part of her mind thinks she's going to see a door on the right, next to her desk, field hockey sticks against the wall. She shrinks into her skin when she remembers that she isn't there, and she remembers what *was*.

Melog was curled behind her knees, and they ruffle when Adora moves her legs enough to ease out of bed. She has a list from Darla of what she's supposed to do when this happens - coloring, exercising, cleaning. She finds her colored pencils, but while she's looking for her anatomy pages she spots something else.

The manila envelope is thick, creasing at the edges. When Adora opens it, there's an origami heart tucked inside, on top of the photographs. If there was a system to organize them, it was lost somewhere between Weaver's house and here, so they're a collage of different ages and places. But they're all of Adora.

There's a handful from school events or birthdays, but they're mostly from practice or games. There's one from every sport Weaver made her try - soccer, softball, basketball, track. The field hockey pictures span a decade. From these alone, no one would think that two other kids also lived there.

"Hey," Catra says, blinking bleary at her from the doorway. "No midnight parties without me."

Adora shakes her head. "Just because I can't sleep-"

Catra sits on the couch next to her. Her hair frizzes where it air-dried after her shower last night. "If your party is going to include history in the middle of the night, yeah, you gotta invite me."

"It's not a big deal," Adora says, and winces when Catra raises an eyebrow. "It's - I'm just thinking."

"Yeah," Catra says, "that's *my* point."

"I put them away before." Adora rubs a thumb over the corner of the photograph on top, Adora playing in the snow. She has a snowball in her hand, eyes focused. Adora remembers practicing her pitch with snowballs, but she hopes Catra or Lonnie are just out of frame. "But - I don't know. I wanted to see them tonight."

Catra leans her head on Adora's shoulder, looking down. "Oh, that I remember," she says, grin bright in her face when she sees Adora with the snowball. "Lonnie didn't stand a chance."

They flip through, and when Adora doesn't remember the context, Catra does. They're always good memories - games won, races run, songs performed in her shaky soprano while their teacher mouthed the words wildly off-stage. Catra says the good things, anyway.

Adora's blowing out candles for her eighth birthday. She's the only person in the picture, because Weaver is taking it, and no one else was there. The next day Catra gave her a notebook paper card and Adora gave her a chunk of saved cake in a napkin.

"That's the year you got that unicorn toy, right? And we made wings for it? What did you call that thing?"

"Swift Wind," Adora says. Catra colored rainbow wings that wrapped around his back, and Adora pretended he could fly out of their window and go and go. She's not sure what happened to him.

"Yeah, Swift Wind." Catra hums, eyes flicking up. "Did he sing? I feel like he liked to sing."

Adora liked to sing, once. She isn't sure when that changed. She puts the picture face down. "He wasn't good at it."

Catra shrugs. "He's already a flying rainbow unicorn, he can't have everything."

There's a baby in the next one, wide-eyed, swaddled up in a green blanket with a blonde lock of hair escaping onto her face. Razz had a picture of Mara by her bed, Adora knows what she looked like. Mara holds the baby against her chest, looking at someone behind the camera.

"Aw," Catra says. Her eyes are too tight for her tone. "So you've looked weird from day one."

Weaver can't have taken this picture. Adora doesn't know where it came from. Part of her hopes it's Razz behind the camera. Maybe it was her other parent, who she's never even wondered about before. Adora doesn't like seeing herself that small, so she flips to the next.

Adora's standing at the edge of the field in her red uniform for the Thaymor Horde. She'd been in the left midfield then, with her field hockey stick and a grin.

Catra leans forward to look closer. "Oh, this must have been just after you started, you outgrew that red stick pretty quickly."

Weaver took this picture for a reason. Adora tries to see whatever Weaver saw, whatever special thing there was about her, but she can't. There's just a kid with skinned knees, flushed from running, hair puffing out of her ponytail. She remembers how much the uniform itched. *Smile,* Weaver would say at the end of the game, and Adora would already have one on her face because she was fast and good at scoring and her coach said she was going to be amazing and Ms. Weaver did too and she felt like she was flying-

"Wait," Catra says, grabbing her hands, which is when Adora realizes that she's torn the picture in half. "What are you doing?"

The words tangle up. She doesn't want these to exist anymore and she isn't sure why.

Catra taps the picture. "None of the shit Weaver did is her fault, right? If it's not mine, it definitely doesn't get to be yours."

"I know," Adora says. "But *she* took these pictures and it just feels like-"

Weaver's eyes saw this moment, chose to save it, and Adora doesn't want to wonder what she saw every time she looks at it. She can't undo what's already happened - the kid she used to be doesn't even exist anymore - and she can't do anything, can't even ask *why did you do it, why didn't you do worse, when did you decide that this was what love meant-*

"I need her to stop looking at me," Adora says.

"Okay," Catra says, voice soft. She slides the ripped halves from Adora's fingers. "Just - can you let me put them away then? I'll take them out of the apartment if you want, I'm sure Angella would hold them for us. I - I don't want you to destroy them and wish you'd done something different, later. You can't replace them."

This isn't only Adora's to destroy, anyway. These mean something to Catra too. "I just wish I knew," Adora says. "I wish I knew why she did anything. I know there's not an answer, not a useful one, but I just - that's what I want."

Catra slips the torn picture into the envelope, sets it aside. "Yeah," she says. "Me too."

Adora's birthday is July 19th. They're given tickets to Bow's rock climbing gym and Adora falls off three different bouldering routes. "At least you bounce," Catra calls down from halfway up the wall. She didn't hesitate when Bow offered to belay her, holding the rope so she doesn't fall.

Two days later, Adora takes out her phone after therapy to a dozen texts and missed calls. All the texts say some version of *call me*. Catra, then Glimmer. "Catra's okay," Glimmer says when Adora calls back in a panic. "Do you want to talk to her?"

Catra's voice is too flat over the phone. Weaver's dead. "Apparently she died in her cell," she says.

Adora closes her eyes, focuses on what matters. "And you're with Glimmer and Angella?"

"Yeah." The music from Glimmer's Switch plays in the background. "She says I'm better at this game than you are, by the way."

"I tried *once*," Adora says. She's just outside the door of her therapy office, and she has the odd thought that Weaver couldn't even give her the decency to die before therapy, and now she has to wait a week for her next session. If Darla called her back in right now, she doesn't know what she would say.

"If you're better now, come prove it." Catra's tone changes. "And I want to see you."

When she gets to the Fujimuras' house, light floods out of the windows into the wide driveway. She can see Bow and Glimmer and Catra from here, sitting at the table in the kitchen. They haven't seen her yet. They look like they're having fun. Catra was glowing with excitement when Weaver was arrested, and she must be even happier about this. Adora should be happy too. She wants to be happy about it.

Adora had nightmares about finding Catra dead for years, but after Razz died, she woke up in a cold sweat for Weaver too. Sometimes she pressed her ear to the door of Weaver's room, listening for her breathing. One night, she was shaking and shivering enough to open the door, go up to her bed and tell herself that she was being ridiculous, everyone was fine. Weaver blinked awake and took Adora's shoulders before she could suppress the whimper that clawed up out of her throat. The fury

that flashed on Weaver's face was gone fast. *What's wrong, child*, she asked, and when Adora stammered out her dream, Weaver outlined her face with her hands and said *I love you more than them, Adora. I'll never leave you.*

And she didn't, because Adora left first. If Weaver had her way, she'd have kept Adora snared in her web until there was nothing left of her, the empty perfect shell Weaver wanted. Weaver was manipulative and sadistic and dangerous and the world is far safer without her in it. Adora should be happy she's gone.

She stays in the car so long that Catra calls her again. "Hey, princess," Catra says, "did you get lost?"

"I'm here," she tells her.

Catra pauses. "Do you want to come in or should I come out?"

Adora wants to sit in the car until she becomes a better person, someone who can look at the person who hurt her and want them gone, instead of someone who let Weaver worm so far into her head that she started to want her there. Adora takes long enough to answer that Catra knocks at the window.

Adora says, "Do you want to talk about it?"

Catra blinks back. "Do you?"

Fireflies flicker in the grass. Adora knows the word for the weight on her chest, the empty space she can't place, and the disgust tastes almost stronger than the grief. Adora's long outgrown her excuse for caring about someone who didn't deserve it. She doesn't know if the tears fighting to spill are for Weaver or for herself.

When Adora says, "I don't want to feel like this," she's surprised. The words don't hurt when they flow out, like she'd expected them to, so she keeps talking. "Weaver hurt so many people - us, those kids, and who even knows who else, she was a *nightmare*.

The world is so much better without her in it, so I don't know why it - I want to be happy, that she's dead, and I'm not."

When Adora's voice stops, Catra pauses before she says, "I'm not happy either. If it helps."

Adora knows the bite in Catra's voice isn't for her. "Yeah?"

"Yeah, I'm fucking furious. If I could, I'd pull the bitch up and kill her again." When Adora looks at her, Catra's shoulders are bunched, hands fisted in her lap. "You don't even want to know all the thoughts I've had, Adora, it's - fuck. I wanted to kill her a thousand ways, but-" Her teeth bare. "I keep thinking about how she's never going back to court, which makes no fucking sense to be pissed about, I didn't even *want* to testify. I was terrified to have to talk about it and get my fucking life picked apart and have to have everyone look at me like - but I wanted her to hear that she was never going home, never seeing a kid again, never getting her life back. I wanted her to *hurt* and now-"

"Maybe it did hurt," Adora says, stomach churning at the possibility. "We don't know how she-"

"Angella says she was in solitary most of the time." Catra blinks hard. "'Protective custody,' she called it. She didn't have a popular set of charges. Which means somebody might have killed her if they had the chance, but probably she did it herself."

Weaver said that Mara wasn't strong enough, when Adora asked. She said Adora was better off without her. Adora has her file, now, though she's barely touched it. The first page is a document from Mara's doctor. *Patient states that her depression is getting worse*, it says*. She reports that she's worried she's going to cause her baby harm, and she thinks her daughter would be safer without her.* When Adora was young enough not to know how Mara died, she liked to imagine it was like in a movie, a hero carrying her child out of flames or gunfire only to succumb as soon as she brings her baby to safety. The truth doesn't feel that different.

"And solitary is - I used to hear shit, sometimes. See flashes in the dark that weren't there. It fucks with your head. But I was stuck in there until she decided to let me go, but when she was locked up, she got to choose to end it. She wasn't supposed to get to make choices anymore." Catra's teeth grind loud enough for Adora to hear. "She wasn't supposed to get to take anything from me anymore. Always got to get the last *fucking* word, not enough that she already did it once." Catra hits the seat under her, lips snarling. "God, I hate her so fucking much. Hated, I guess. Fuck."

Adora wonders if someone told the girls that Weaver's dead. They were never scheduled to testify, though maybe that would have changed, with the new evidence. Angella still won't tell her anything, and Adora still can't see children playing without worrying about them. They probably hate Weaver too.

"Anyway." Catra clears her throat, turns her head back to Adora. "That's why I got a round in with the punching mat thing, earlier. Do you need one?"

Adora shakes her head. She's drained out, hollow.

Catra looks at her, pupils huge in the dark. "It's okay," she says, quiet, "if you're sad. I get it."

"There's no - I hate her too, so much, but-" But she let Weaver worm so far into her head that there's a hole where she used to be, even though it's been years since Adora last had a civil conversation with her. She feels insane. "I *left*. It doesn't make sense."

Catra's face twitches. She picks at the knee of her jeans. "It makes sense."

The lights are still on in the Fujimuras' house, windows bright. They have blankets on their couch, knit with puffy yarn, that are warm to curl up under when they watch movies. Catra puts her

fingers on the glass, breathes the way she does when she's trying not to panic.

"She was nice to me," Catra says, "sometimes. Well. Less mean, I guess, since she was still-" Catra pauses, twitches, "-raping me, but she was gentler when I didn't fight. She acted like she wanted me to exist, for once, like I was good for something, like I wasn't..."

Catra trails off. Fireflies reflect in her blown pupils before she blinks, jerks her head. "Adora, messing with us was kind of her whole thing, and she was good at it. It's not going to go away overnight."

"But she's gone," Adora says, "she's *been* gone. How long are we going to be-"

Catra grimaces. "I don't know, how long did I lie to your face in our own apartment?"

Adora's shoulders bunch involuntarily. "That's different."

"It isn't," Catra snaps, before her jaw relaxes. "My point is, this stuff takes time, right? Slow as shit. But I'm not the same as I was three years ago, and neither are you."

Three years ago, Adora was eighteen, a handful of days away from moving into the BMU dorms. Catra spent every night in her room, and Lonnie made every excuse to avoid her, and Weaver talked a lot about how she didn't know how she was going to manage by herself. *I had hoped that some of you children appreciated me, after everything I've done for you*, Weaver said, while they drove to buy sheets long enough to fit the dorm beds. *But all of you will leave me the second you get the chance.* Adora promised she'd call once a week and visit as many weekends as she could, gut churning, and Weaver sighed. *Someday you'll understand*, she said, *how much it hurts to be away from someone you love.* Adora insisted that she was sorry and she would be home as often as she could and she was sorry again,

dizzy, anxiety crawling up her spine, and she could tell Weaver didn't believe her, and she felt like she was dying. That girl couldn't even admit to herself that Weaver did anything wrong, let alone tell a courtroom full of strangers.

Three years ago, Adora thought she was responsible for keeping Catra in line, behaving, safe. Today, Catra found their friends when she didn't want to be alone. Lights dance in the grass, and the crickets are out. Adora isn't sure she remembers how to play Mario Kart, but she's willing to try. "Let's go inside," she says.

When they open the door, Bow pauses the game and Angella gets the popcorn and Glimmer starts to banter with Catra about whether kettle corn is a dessert or a snack. Bow gives Adora the other controller, and it's just as awkward in her hands as she remembers. Catra is somehow better at Mario Kart than Adora, but Adora loves how she laughs when she gets someone with a shell.

The letter arrives two weeks later, battered, with a large forwarding sticker over Adora's name and the address of her BMU dorm. It doesn't have a return address but even without the red *Mailed from a Correctional Facility* stamp, Adora recognizes the spiky handwriting like it's her own. The corners are nearly worn through, battered.

There are two folded stacks of paper inside, a name on each. Adora's is much thicker, Catra's is a single page. She puts Catra's back, even though she doesn't know if Catra will want it or not when she gets back from work. It's probably a mind game. It's *definitely* a mind game. Adora knows better than to open it, but she does anyway.

Pen colors change throughout, tight script crammed into the margins. It rambles so much that it feels more like a diary than a letter, even though it addresses Adora directly.

-such a good child: caring, smart, beautiful, everything I could have ever wanted, you'll never know the sacrifices I made to keep

- never intended to leave you with the mess I made, because I knew that you wouldn't have the stomach for it, but I had no - always loved you, Adora, whether you believe me or - knew you were something special - know you're better off without me.

There's pages and pages, covered in cramped script, letters that Weaver helped show her how to shape. Later, Adora taught them to Catra, sitting on Adora's bed with a notebook and pencils and misplaced determination, in the place they thought was safe. The paper crackles where she holds it too tight. She can feel the person that Weaver wants her to be, sitting up straight, turning towards her like a daisy facing the sun. Her brain echoes with *you were everything I could have ever wanted.* Even with the past tense, it's all she wanted to hear for years. She doesn't think Weaver means it the way she would have heard it, and she'll never be able to ask now to know for sure.

Adora's still sitting across from the letters when Catra gets home. "They're from Weaver," Adora manages, throat filled with sludge.

Catra slides onto the couch next to her, wraps her arms around her, grips tight enough for Adora to stop exploding inside. Her breath is paced out slow. "That good, huh," she says, voice heavy.

"She said-" Adora can't remember anything she said, anymore. "I don't know. I didn't really read it."

Catra glances at the letters, one thick and one slim, and her expression flickers. "Did you read mine?"

"No. Do you want me to?"

Catra shakes her head sharp. She sticks out her hand. "Give it."

Once Catra has her letter in her hand, she goes into the kitchen and pulls the lighter out of the drawer, the long one they use when the gas stove clicks and clicks instead of catching. She sticks the edge of the letter in the flame and drops it in the sink and watches it, fire dancing at the edges of the paper, curling as it

burns. Adora thinks she can see two words, dark in the glowing flames, but she can't make them out before they're gone.

Adora swallows the lump in her throat, seeing it burn. The paper in her own hand crumples in her fist. Catra turns to her and holds out the lighter. "I didn't finish reading it," Adora says, mouth dry.

Catra glances at it, face tight, before she says, "Is there anything she could say?"

Maybe Weaver apologized, in the letter, somewhere that Adora missed. Maybe she said that she knew exactly what she did to them, and she wished she could go back in time so she could raise them and support them and care for them the way a parent should. Maybe she said that she was proud of who they've managed to become despite her.

Adora stretches the limits of her imagination, and then she asks herself Catra's question.

Adora's letter takes longer to burn than Catra's does. Adora keeps relighting it until it's nothing but scraps, individual loops of script among the ash.

Chapter End Notes

> One more chapter left! Thank you all for bearing with me. I'm putting the finishing touches on it and it should be up in the next week or so.
>
> Love your comments and support, thank you all ❤️

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Six months later

The stage is bright, but Catra's used to it now. She has the nightmare less and less often, but tonight she's back here. Weaver looks across the stage at her and she doesn't freeze this time.

"You're dead," Catra says.

"Why would that matter?" Weaver comes towards her, shadows curling around her body, feet barely touching the ground. "I'll always be here, little monster. No one else is going to fix you."

"No." Catra stays on her feet, fists up in front of her, firm. "You raped me. You abused me. You tried to *kill me*. The only monster here is you."

Lights shine stark on the lines of the mask. "All that rage," Weaver says, soft, mocking. "Same little beast. You can barely control yourself in your own-"

"Shut up." Catra doesn't raise her voice, but the words still echo. Weaver's closer than she was a moment ago and Catra doesn't know which of them moved. "It's my turn to talk now."

Weaver reaches out to grab Catra's hair or throat or face, but draws back sharp, hissing. There are four parallel lines on her hand, and when Catra looks down she can see claws at the ends of her fingers, blood-tipped. Weaver's eyes gleam through the narrow slits cut into the mask. "Still a wild-"

"I said it's my turn." Catra's claws flex in her hand. Weaver glares silently. "I was never going to hurt Adora, not the way you said I

would. You knew I wouldn't. You just couldn't stand that she cared about me more than she was ever going to care about you."

Weaver wasn't stupid. If she had eyes in Adora's room, she got whatever sick thing she got out of peeking in, but she also knew how often they both hid there together. Catra wasn't a danger to Adora, and Weaver knew that. Adora only went to one person when she was upset or hurt, and Weaver knew it wasn't her.

"And even if I had been dangerous, you should have gotten me help, real help. I was a kid, there's nothing I could have done to deserve the way you treated me. There's no excuse for what you did, to me or Adora or any of us. And you know that. That's why you're dead."

Weaver's voice twists with disdain. "I don't expect something like you to understand."

"You couldn't live with what you did," Catra says, "but I can. I'm going to."

A shadow strikes down at her, but it passes harmlessly through like the imaginary thing it's always been. Catra grabs the arm that snaps towards her, grip tight, blood flowing rich around her claws. "You didn't kill me when you had the chance and you're *never* getting another one."

"You can tell yourself I'm gone." Weaver steps through her grasp, and when Catra slashes at her again, she's behind her, voice sharp in her ear. "You can pretend there's anything in you to love. You can let all the people you've manipulated tell you that you're worth something. But I know, and you know."

"You are gone." Catra's chest aches, her ears ring, but she's on her feet, claws sharp. "You're gone and I'm here."

Catra wakes with a purring weight on her hip, legs tangled with Adora's, fingers stroking through the hair at the back of her head. "We're trapped," Adora says before she kisses her. "Melog won't let us leave."

Catra runs her hand down Adora's arm. "Oh, what a nightmare."

Adora smiles, light casting her hair gold, muscles lax. "Sleep okay?"

Catra nods. "Dreams," she says. They both still get them, and Catra's not sure they'll ever stop. It's okay. On the rare mornings when they still leave her with ice in her chest, waking up to Adora and Melog and the life she's made for herself makes it dissipate quickly.

Adora laces their hands. "Love you," she says, and they say it so often that it shouldn't still feel like a gift, but it does.

Catra curls into her, moving enough for Melog to jump off. "Love you too," she says, "even though apparently you found us a homophobic cat."

It's Catra's day off, and Adora's winter break doesn't end for another week, so they get to have a quiet breakfast. The food bank has the strawberry jam Adora likes. They're going to visit Lonnie's family over the weekend, to help them pack. Angella helped them find a place in Bright Moon with rental assistance and enough room for three beds, and as much as Lonnie complains about moving being a headache, Catra knows she's excited.

There was a storm last night, and even as early as Adora likes to wake up, the kitchen is lit bright by the reflection off the snow. Adora's just taken a bite of her toast when Catra says, words spilling out of nowhere, "She said it was my fault."

Adora blinks, swallows. "What?"

She'd been so scared to say it for so long and, in this moment, she can't remember why. "Weaver, she - she said I wanted to, um, to hurt you, when we were kids, and that's why I was always all over you all the time. She said that's why she had to, to abuse me."

Adora puts down her toast. "That's not true."

"I know," Catra says, and she does. "But I wanted to tell you."

She can hear birds outside. Melog eats the food that they wouldn't touch until their humans were in the kitchen too. Adora stands up and comes around to her, pressing their foreheads together, hands cupping her face. "Thank you," she says, and in the morning light she looks like she's glowing. "I'm so proud of you."

The drive to Thaymor gets shorter the more times they do it. Lonnie's organized, writing contents on boxes, and her sister Izzy follows her around like a duckling. "Let me help," Izzy says, gummy hands grabbing for the permanent marker.

"You can't write yet." Lonnie holds the marker over Izzy's head, but she smiles when her back is turned. "If I get any more help from you, I'll have to start over."

"I can so write," Izzy grumbles to Catra, pointing to the wall by the bookshelf. Someone's tried to clean it, but faint crayon letters still stand out against the white paint.

Catra can't imagine what would have happened to them if they'd drawn on anything that belonged to Weaver. She pushes that thought away before Izzy can sense that she's stressed. It happened a lot, when they first started spending time with her. Once Izzy had a tantrum, arms thrashing, legs kicking, screaming, and Catra's shoulders went so tight they were sore for days after. Adora shook for half of the drive home. But every visit gets easier.

"Let's get some paper so you can show me how great you can write," Catra tells Izzy. "I bet you can't write my name."

The storm is coming soon, but they take Izzy to the playground before Catra and Adora have to leave, where Adora chases her long enough to wear them both out. Lonnie shoves her hands deeper in her pockets. "I applied to that store where you work, in Bright Moon," she says, not looking away from where Izzy darts across the equipment.

"Stalker," Catra says, smiling.

Lonnie shrugs. "You seem happy enough. Figure it can't be that bad."

Catra hadn't thought about it for a while. Maybe that's what being normal is like. "I seem happy?"

She can feel Lonnie turn to look at her. "Yeah. Is that - I thought I could see through your bullshit, but-"

"No," Catra says, surprising herself. "You're not wrong." Izzy shrieks with delight as Adora nearly catches her, and Lonnie twitches. "What about you?"

Lonnie doesn't answer for a long moment. "It doesn't matter. We're going to move, have more space. That'll help. Maybe I'll talk to somebody."

"If there's anything we can do at all," Catra says, "we will. You know that."

"Yeah," Lonnie says, quiet. "I know."

Izzy comes flying back across the playground, barrelling into Lonnie at full speed, knocking her back a step. Lonnie scoops her up, hugging her tight before putting her back down. "Okay, Miss Hurricane. You're not the only storm that's coming."

They walk all the way back to the apartment when Lonnie realizes that Izzy's hat is gone. Adora offers to get it, since she knows where it could have fallen, and Catra comes along. They find it under the slide, where Adora had thought it might be, and Adora's dusting the mulch off when she freezes.

"What?" Catra says, trying to follow the line of her gaze, but she doesn't see anyone she recognizes. There's just kids in scarves and mittens on the snow-dusted equipment, puffy coats flickering as they run.

"She's one of them," Adora says, squinting, "I know she is."

"One of what?"

"The kids." Adora is staring now. "From Weaver's house, the *kids*."

Adora lets go of her hand to step forward. "Adora," Catra says, "you can't just-"

And then Adora's gone, and Catra isn't faster than her anymore. There's a girl on the jungle gym, perched at the top, staring down at Adora as she runs up. Catra tries to remember how old Adora thought they were, when she saw them over a year ago. She doesn't look much older than the pictures of Catra from the trial. Her hat has a bright red pom-pom on the top, tassels hanging by her ears.

Adora walks towards her and then stops, like she's finally realized that she can't just start talking to a small child that doesn't know her. The girl glances to the side of the playground, where adults talk and don't look over, and Catra barely reaches them when the girl says, "You're Adora."

Adora breathes in sharp and pushes up onto the lowest bar. "That's right." Her voice sounds wrong, shaky. "What's your name?"

"Hazel," the girl says, gloves squeaking with how tightly she's holding the metal under her. Her brown hair is long enough to cover her face.

Catra comes up next to Adora. Hazel pinches her eyebrows at her and Adora says, "This is Catra, we were Ms. - we both lived there too, before you."

"She didn't have pictures of you," Hazel tells Catra, frowning. "Just Adora."

Catra doesn't throw up on the mulch at the thought of the kid seeing what Weaver did have. "I was the one she didn't like," she

says, and Adora twitches next to her.

Something dark flickers in Hazel's eyes, rippling through her like a flinch, and Catra knows, she *knows*. "You're not a bad kid," Catra tells her, words welling like blood in her mouth. "No matter what she said."

Hazel drops down inside the dome, feet landing solid on the ground. She locks her fists under her elbows. "You met me five seconds ago," she snaps back. "You don't know me."

Catra wants to. She wants to ask her if she also knew how to fit under the couch, if she knew what steps creaked on the staircase so she didn't wake anyone when she was walked back to bed. Catra knows she can't, because she would never want someone to ask her the same questions. Instead she says, "I knew her, and I know she lied."

"Shut up," Hazel says, face scrunching angry, shoulders up. "Shut *up*, you weren't even there."

Catra asks, "She put the cover on the light switch, when she left, right? Downstairs. To keep it dark. But that stopped being scary after a while, because when the light was on it was worse."

Hazel's lips go tight. She doesn't answer, but her face says enough.

"The empty patches in the carpet, where you could feel the plastic mesh under, that was me. Maybe she fixed that. There's sixteen stairs down to-"

"What do you want," Hazel says.

Catra knows what Hazel expects to hear. She doesn't know what this kid needs, what might have helped Catra if she'd had an adult who understood. She sits, resting her arms on the bar in front of her. Her coat keeps the cold metal from biting. "Can we talk for a minute?"

Hazel doesn't answer, but she doesn't leave either.

Adora shifts her weight. Catra had almost forgotten she was there. "I'm going to find - are you here with someone?"

Hazel's eyes flare. "Don't tell her," she snarls, and Catra remembers that thought echoing in her head a hundred times. *Do you think she'll talk to you again after she hears how awful you are? She'll know you're not worth it.* "I'll say you're lying. I'll tell them you tried to kidnap me and you'll go to jail and you'll die there like she did."

Catra tries to remember how Ms. Torres used to sound when she talked, how Emily talks when Catra is losing it in session. "I think Adora just wants to say hi," Catra says. "She's been worried about you for a long time. We both have."

"Good for her." Hazel kicks the mulch at her feet. "If you take Naomi away from me I'll kill you."

Catra feels it all in her chest again, shame and rage and fear. She wants to be able to tell Hazel that she doesn't need to worry about people rejecting her, but Hazel won't believe her and Catra doesn't know if that's true anyway. "Who's Naomi?"

"My foster mom. A nice one." Hazel glances at the cluster of adults off to the side, arms still stiff at her sides. "She can't be your mom, she's *mine*."

"Too late for me." Catra can't quite keep the grief out of her voice. "But I'm glad you like her."

"She's the *best.*" Hazel exhales, shoulders softening. Tension releases in Catra that she didn't even know she had. "Naomi's nice even when I'm not. She's the best mom I ever had."

In the corner of Catra's eye, she can see Adora walking down the playground, towards the adults. "Do you know how old I am?" Catra asks, to make Hazel look at her.

Hazel blinks. "I dunno. Thirty?"

"Twenty-one - twenty-two, soon." Catra can't imagine being thirty. She's still distantly surprised that she made it to eighteen. "I didn't think I would be alive this long, but I am. It's good. I'm none of the things she said I would be, because I got to decide that, not her. And so do you."

Hazel's lips narrow. She sits, shadows spilling over her face, stark on her skin. "Do you want to be?"

"Do I want to be what she-"

"Alive."

Catra breathes. She's glad Adora left. Catra talked to Emily about this, a few months ago. *Ending a life is so much power,* Emily mused. *It wouldn't surprise me if some part of you was trying to take that back.* Catra remembers climbing on top of the monkey bars and imagining her head cracking open on the ground, looking at the janitor's big jugs of cleaning solution and wondering how much it would hurt to drink. Catra can't blame herself for wanting to die on her own terms instead of Weaver's, and she can't blame Hazel either.

Hazel's hand fidgets on her lap while she waits for her answer. "Now I do," Catra says. "I didn't, for a long time, but now I do."

Hazel looks at her, something hungry in her face. "Growing up helped?"

Catra has to do this right. She wants to reach into Hazel's head and pull the voice out, the one that's still in Catra's head too. On a good day, it's a mumble; on a bad day it shouts so loud she can barely think until she works to control it. Emily says it'll go away someday. Catra doesn't know if she believes that, but being able to turn the volume down is better than it's ever been. Hazel deserves that too.

"Talking to the right people helped. I told them what she did and I was so scared that they were going to hate me, but they didn't. They told me she'd lied, about being something awful. And they helped me find a future that I want to see."

She doesn't want to promise this kid that anyone is safe. *You have a mom who loves you,* adult after adult after adult told her. *If you keep spreading lies, you'll wind up in a hospital*, Milagros said. Her elementary school counselor looked at her with eyebrows raised and said, *So you want to die? Do you even know what that means?*

"I can't tell you who your right people are," Catra says. "I wish I could."

"Naomi's nice." Hazel blinks in the shadow. "She doesn't yell ever, even when I hit and break stuff. She lets me keep food in my room and wear a swimsuit in the shower. She says sorry when she brushes my hair and it pulls."

Catra can't remember Weaver coming near her with a hairbrush to do anything other than hit her with it. "Naomi sounds amazing," Catra says, through the tightness in her throat.

"She says she isn't special, people are supposed to be nice." Hazel picks at the mulch, face blank. "I'm not nice."

Past her, Adora's talking to a short woman, coiled hair stacked up on her head. Gray clouds are starting to gather overhead, dimming the light.

"It's hard for me too, sometimes." Catra curls her fingers into her coat sleeve, away from the cold metal. "It doesn't make us bad. We're still - we're still people. It just means we have to work a little harder sometimes."

Adora and the woman's voices drift on the wind as they start to walk over, and Hazel looks at them coming with something clouding her face, and Catra's made a huge mistake, she's been one of a thousand voices saying *of course your mom loves you*,

and it's going to haunt her forever. "Listen," Catra says, voice fast and quiet. She tears part of a page out of her book, scratches her phone number down. "If you ever need it, if - if - I don't live that far away, okay? Find a way to call me. I'll come, I promise."

Hazel takes the paper, tucks it into her boot. "I'll tell Summer too," she says. "I'm going to her foster brother's birthday next Saturday."

Two girls, Adora had said. "Summer's your friend?"

Hazel nods, eyes dark. "She was the good kid."

"There aren't good kids and bad kids," Catra says, "not in the rest of the world."

"Yeah," Hazel says, "that's what Naomi says too."

Adora and the woman who must be Naomi crouch next to the jungle gym. "Hey, munchkin," the woman says. She has stress on her face, but not surprise.

Hazel looks back, and Catra knows what pretending not to be scared looks like, feels like. Hazel has none of that. "Hey."

"We have to go home before the snow starts," Naomi says, "but maybe we can hang out again another time."

Adora looks at Catra and she tries to smile back. Catra says, "We'd like that, if you want to."

Hazel worms through the bars out of the jungle gym, and her long hair clings to the metal as she steps away. She asks Naomi,"Can they meet Miri?"

"I think that depends on if they like cats, sweetheart."

"We have a cat," Catra says, "their name is Melog."

"Their names are a-lit-er-a-tive," Hazel says, pride in her voice, and Naomi gives her a high five. Catra doesn't want to assume that no one can act this well, but she knows Weaver couldn't. She still fights not to drag Hazel away from her.

When they've trailed Hazel and Naomi back to their minivan, Naomi says, "Okay, Haze, how do you want to say goodbye today?"

Hazel waves, and everyone waves back, and Catra can't move until the car disappears around the corner. "We'll keep track of her," Adora says, like she's trying to reassure herself. "We exchanged numbers, and Naomi really seems-"

"I need your phone," Catra says. "Right now."

Adora lets out her breath. "Catra, the police called her about the hard drive. I didn't have to tell her anything."

"Not that." Hazel's not going to call Catra if the yelling in her head gets too loud, and Catra's way too far away to do anything even if she does. Izzy and Lonnie are starting to walk home, so Catra doesn't lower her voice. "The kid wants to die, I gotta - gotta make sure someone's paying attention."

Adora hands over her phone immediately. "She told you that?"

"She asked if I did, I fucking *promise* you she's not too young to-"

"No, I know." Adora's freaked out, but she can handle that herself.

Hi, it's Catra, we met at the park just now, she types. *Something Hazel said-*

This is stupid, Naomi's not going to listen to her, she-

The phone buzzes. *It was so good to meet you today,* the text from Naomi says. *I'd really like to talk to both of you again, and I know Hazel wants to see you all again. Please let me know when*

you're back in town, or if there's a good time for us to come to you.

Catra writes, *I'm worried about something Hazel said that sounded like she may want to hurt herself. I wanted you to know that.*

She hits send before she can think about it, hands sweating, and Adora kisses her when she hands it back. Adora fidgets and says, "What did you tell her? When she asked. If you want to-" Her voice cuts off sharp, tight.

Catra looks at Adora's face, her eyes, makes sure Adora can see she's telling the truth. "Not anymore. My therapist is helping me stay that way, and I'll tell you if I need help, okay? I promise."

They hold hands as they walk quickly back to the Davis' building. They don't beat the snow, and Adora keeps tugging Catra's hood back up when it falls down. They walk past brick buildings, and Catra wonders again if she's been here before, when she was too young to remember. Angella poked around, like Catra asked her to. She found a few documents. Camila asked three times for the visitation to move to another center. She said it was almost two hours to get there, the buses were always late, her boss was threatening to fire her if she left work any earlier. She said *I love my daughter, I'm trying.*

When Milagros wrote back, she said that the foster parent had three children and was already struggling enough, and that Camila should reconsider if visitation was something she was up for. *Being a parent is a commitment,* the letter said. *Maybe it's worth thinking about what you can offer your daughter, compared to the family she has now, and whether or not regaining custody is the best choice for her.* Camila stopped showing up two weeks later.

Angella says Milagros doesn't work at DCFS anymore. She also found a lawyer who took Catra's case against the department, along with a handful of other former foster youth. It moves slowly,

like everything, but maybe things will be better for Hazel and Summer. Maybe Catra can have that moment in court to say *this was wrong,* and maybe it will change something.

Naomi texts back before they leave the awning. She says that they know about Hazel's history with suicidal thoughts, that her team is working on it, that Naomi's grateful that Catra told her regardless. *I'm really glad that she trusts you,* Naomi says, *and I hope that if there's anything I can do for you, you'll trust me too.*

They stop at the apartment one last time before they go, to give back the hat and say goodbye. Izzy hugs tighter than a five-year-old should be able to.

One and a half years later

Eight months ago, Catra got down on one knee on their anniversary date when the bread came out, and Adora cursed because she had planned to do the same when dessert arrived. "Then we could celebrate with cake right away," Adora said, happy tears still in her voice. She can eat cake now, most days.

Catra grinned and said, "Just admit that I'm still faster than you," even though that hasn't been true for many years.

They set up the balloons and tables in the Fujimuras' backyard, to celebrate after they come back from the courthouse. The reception is going to be small, for a wedding. Adora's about to start graduate school, Catra's still settling into her manager position. Their budget is small, but it fits the people who matter most. After Adora finally decides how to arrange the tables, Angella says she has to show them something. It's a decoration that looks like rain, by the lights strung along the side of the house, something on strings cascading down the wall, and Catra inhales sharp. Adora winds an arm around her waist.

"You didn't have to do all that," Catra says, voice thick.

Angella reaches out to adjust a strand. "I had help."

"Yeah." Catra laughs wet. "I can guess which ones Glimmer did."

When Adora looks closer, she can see the tiny cranes, one after another. "My daughter has many talents," Angella says, "precision not among them."

Catra laughs again, rubbing her face. Bow's going to be upset if she ruins her makeup. He spent almost twenty minutes on it. How anyone could find that much to change about Catra's face, Adora didn't know. Adora had been nervous that it would make her look like someone else, but she looked even more like herself, somehow.

"A thousand," Catra says. "The folding must have taken forever."

"We can spare a few hours for the people we love," Angella says.

Catra squeezes Adora's hand on her waist before she surges forward, pressing her head to Angella's shoulder, arms wrapping around her. Angella hugs her back, runs a hand over her hair. It falls nearly to where Catra's shirt tucks into her slacks. Some of the cranes are silver foil, catching the afternoon light. Bow tells Adora later that he redid all of Glimmer's, grin caught in the corner of his mouth.

It's not far to the courthouse, and Catra looks radiant in the suit she picked. This is the only reason Adora would ever agree to go to a courthouse again. She keeps brushing her hair off of her neck - she can't remember the last time she wore it down, but when Catra wakes up before her, she plays with it more often than not. Catra's face when she came out of the bathroom this morning, still in her BMU t-shirt and basketball shorts but hair styled, confirmed what Adora had suspected. Glimmer and Bow come as their witnesses, and they have enough whispers behind their hands that they're definitely cooking up something, but the idea of a surprise can't make her more jittery than she already is.

The clerk checks their IDs, confirms their names and birthdates, and Catra holds Adora's hand when it fidgets. "You look amazing," Catra says, after they're given their number for the waiting room, when Adora can't stop fussing with her dress. There's not much to fuss with - it's simple white and gold fabric, just shy of floor length. Glimmer had cried when she saw it, and Catra smiled and said *you're always beautiful, princess, but that's breathtaking.* Adora doesn't feel as uncomfortable in it as she'd thought she would, when Glimmer asked if she wanted to look for a dress. When she talked about it with Darla, they decided that it's because she trusts the people who will see her in it.

"I don't care about that," Adora says. "I'm just - I'm excited."

Catra lifts their clasped hands, kisses Adora's knuckles carefully. Bow told her if she smudged her makeup again he wasn't going to fix it. When Adora first suggested getting married, over a year ago, Catra said *it's just a piece of paper, Adora.* And it is, but Adora wants to cover the city in it, play it on the news, fly it behind a skywriter. She loves Catra and she wants to be able to tell people *this is my wife.*

After Catra proposed, she said she wanted to be able to get Adora on her health plan when they aged out of their state-sponsored insurance, but she got as weepy as Adora did that evening, so Adora knows she cares about more than that. Catra only tells half-truths when they both see through them, now.

"I love you," Catra says, and Adora says it back before she does another excited loop of the waiting room. Her pulse drums in her ears and she automatically takes a deep breath to slow it, even though she knows she's not panicking.

The justice is clearly in a hurry, flitting between them and the room next door, but she doesn't act even a fraction as anxious as Adora feels. "Adora Castillo and Catra Guerra," she reads, before looking at them. She pronounces their names almost completely correctly. "You've come to me today to be united by marriage

under the Crown of Etheria. If you both come freely, please take each other by the hands and reply, 'we do.'"

They face each other, then, and Adora's distracted by the scatter of freckles over Catra's cheekbones, the lashes that frame her eyes. Catra's mouth tenses, and pauses, and it isn't until she squeezes Adora's hands that Adora remembers that they'd been given instructions, and they speak in unison. "We do."

"Do you promise to support each other with kindness and respect through all times, difficult and easy, and to honor this commitment for as long as your love shall last?"

In the corner of Adora's eye, Glimmer leans into Bow. Adora feels the tears she knew were going to come, and she doesn't fight them. Catra is tearing up too, but they manage their reply together anyway.

"Then by the power vested in me by the Crown, I pronounce you married."

Adora blinks. It feels too easy, that a minute ago they weren't married and now they are. "That's it?"

Catra's grinning at her with the kind of smile that's impossible to look away from. "Do you want to do it again? Divorce is a whole process, I think, but-"

Adora kisses her, quickly because she knows their appointment is only for ten minutes, but she can't not kiss her, right now. It's intense enough to make up for the speed.

They get sent down the hall to finish the license, and Adora has her pen over the marriage license before she realizes something. "Wait," she says, "do we need to change our names? One of our names?"

Catra explodes with laughter, making the clerk jump. "You figured out everything else," Catra giggles, "fucking seven drafts of the seating plan, but you didn't think about your *name*."

"Clearly neither did you," Adora shoots back. The clerk smiles politely, and Adora tries to focus. "Do you want mine? Do you want me to take yours?"

"You don't want mine, you're going to have the same problem I do." Whenever Adora picks up Catra's meds, she has to spell Guerra before she says it, because no one can ever figure out where her first name ends and the last begins. "And that's not even - are you ready to find out how many ways someone can misspell it?"

"People pronounce the Ls in mine half the time though." Castillo was Mara's name, Razz's name. Adora tries on *Guerra* in her head, and it feels like leaving them behind.

"At least that sounds anything like-"

The clerk clears his throat. Catra tells him that they'll figure it out later. They sign with the names they were born to, and Adora tries to do the script the way she practiced in notebooks as a child, neat instead of the scrawl she puts on progress notes in the clinic. "Congratulations," the clerk says, putting the stamped paper in her hands.

Glimmer and Bow don't wait until they get outside to cheer and hug them, and Catra doesn't stop them from hugging her too. Her smile is the kind that used to be just for Adora, and maybe someday it'll stop feeling special to see it in front of anyone else.

Perfuma's flowers are all over when they return from the courthouse. They're only tropical ones, the kind that can't grow in any Etherian garden - heliconia, anthurium, birds of paradise. They spill across the tables, winding around each other, vibrant splashes of color on the white tablecloths.

"It's beautiful," Adora tells Perfuma, who fusses with an orchid on the potluck table. "Thank you. I couldn't have imagined it could look this incredible."

Perfuma beams. "Luckily, they're not half as beautiful as you today."

Catra looks over from her conversation with Scorpia, grin turning mischievous. "Excuse me," Catra says, "that wife's mine, get your own."

"I volunteer," Scorpia says, and they both burst into laughter. Perfuma rolls her eyes and adjusts the orchid again, engagement ring winking in the sunlight.

Adora did fuss over a seating chart for days, looking for an arrangement that will make everyone happiest, but people fall into place. Lonnie perches on a chair next to Kyle and Rogelio, listening to Bow tell a story that he probably got from Sea Hawk, which means it's about fifty miles away from the truth. Glimmer rolls her eyes at a particularly emphatic gesture, but she's got that soft look on her face that she always has when her boyfriend gets excited about something. Entrapta lingers at the edge of the circle, occasionally scrawling something in her notebook and eating a mini calzone.

Hazel, Summer, and Izzy found the paper and cup of colored pencils that Adora made sure to put on their table, and they're conspiring about something, whispering furiously. Anything they're making is going to be streaked with grease from the empanadas Naomi brought and Izzy can't stop eating, and Adora can't wait to see it. The adults - Angella, Naomi, and Lonnie's mother Nikki - are deep in conversation, and it's almost a jolt to remember that Adora's an adult too.

Catra got up to get more dumplings a few minutes ago, and when Adora looks, she's standing at the table by the cranes, where the photos are. They have a lot from the past few years, from Adora's graduation and birthdays and the trip to Mystacor. They decided on the picture that Adora likes best, where they're lying on the beach. Catra's eyes are closed, calm, as the sea breeze ripples through her hair, and Adora's building a castle in the sand next to their towel. There's two others, in their own frames, much older.

After the mistrial, Angella asked around. Catra's mom had a sister who hadn't been able to take a toddler when the social workers called twenty-one years ago. The woman they met in the Thaymor library had sobbed when she saw her, and Catra stared at her mismatched eyes whenever they surfaced. *You look just like her*, the woman said. *I've worried about you for so long, baby girl. Cami wanted you so bad.* The woman said that she understood that Catra wasn't ready to be her niece, and maybe never would. She gave them the pictures anyway.

Catra said she only wanted one at the wedding, because Adora only had one with her mother, and it had taken her weeks to choose. The toddler was focused on the brown cat in her arms, clutching it tight. The woman was looking at the girl on her lap, smiling. The lock of hair in her face didn't obscure her eyes, mirror to Catra's. If Adora didn't know Catra as closely as she does, she might mistake them for each other.

Adora stands behind Catra and wraps her arms around her shoulders. Catra grabs her arms, squeezing tight. "I'm glad we put these out," she says.

"It was Scorpia's idea," Adora says, glancing at where Scorpia sits. She's sinking into Perfuma's eyes, like they're the only ones out there. If this is what they're like at someone else's wedding, Adora can't imagine how sappy they'll be at their own. The idea makes her smile.

"Yeah, occasionally she has a good one." Catra presses on Adora's arms where they wrap under her ribs. Not looking away from the picture of her mom holding her, she says, "I think I want to keep my name."

"Then you should." Adora rests her chin on her shoulder. "Me too. We can hyphenate, I guess."

"Great," Catra groans. "The worst of both worlds. I can't wait to try spelling Guerra-Castillo to an overworked receptionist."

"If you think we're putting *your* name first-"

"Excuse me," Summer says, polite as always, holding a paper tightly. When Adora looks, she can see Izzy and Hazel chasing each other around the far end of the yard, Hazel's hair flowing in the wind.

"What's up?" Adora asks.

"It's for you," Summer says, handing her the paper. It's not perfect. Or even good, really, but Summer's nine. But Adora can make out herself and Catra, riding unicorns with rainbow manes.

"Izzy said you like unicorns, and I didn't bring a present," Summer says, ducking her head. The apology is clear on her face.

"This is amazing," Adora says, and Catra murmurs agreement. "It's a wonderful gift, Summer, thank you."

Summer twitches, once, quick. "Sorry it's messy," she says. "I tried but I couldn't do it any better."

Adora met her for the first time at Hazel's birthday party the March before last, red dress pressed, hair pulled back smooth, fiddling with the fork next to her plate. The pop-it Naomi gave her sat untouched on the table. When Adora sat next to her and started asking questions, Summer told her that she likes history and Spanish and gymnastics and piano, and she talked like she didn't edit herself in her head. She kept straightening her place setting, eyebrows pulling tight until she's done, but soon enough she was fussing with it again. Adora took her fidget cube out of her pocket while she listened, and after about five minutes Summer asked about it.

Now, Adora turns the picture around so Summer can see it. "I love this so much," she says. "It's more beautiful than anything anyone else could make, because *you* made it, so it's important to me."

Summer flushes, but she doesn't protest. Hazel runs up and tosses an arm over Summer's shoulder. Her cheeks are red too, loose hair sticking to her face. "Are you done yet?" she asks. "Izzy wants to play Robot Battle and that girl with the crazy hair had great ideas."

"It hasn't even been five minutes, you're so impatient," Summer says, but her voice isn't harsh.

Adora waves towards the open end of the yard. "Go play. I have to find somewhere special to put this."

The girls run off, and when Adora looks back at Catra, she has that look in her eyes, wistful. "They're going to be okay," she says, and it's not a question.

Adora puts Summer's drawing on the table with the other pictures, edges pinned down under the frames so the breeze can't catch it. Glimmer turns on the Bluetooth speaker, filters the music Adora chose across the yard. It'll be dusk soon, and the dimming sun makes way for the lights strung around the yard to shine.

Adora dances with her wife, and maybe someday that word will stop feeling like a magic spell. Neither of them really know how to dance, and the video they watched two weeks ago didn't help, so they mostly stand there and sway. They're at just the right height for Catra to lean her head on Adora's shoulder.

I don't need anything fancy, I just need me and you slow dancing… heaven's here, it's right where you're standing…

"Sap," Catra says, and the mockery in her voice is affectionate.

"I get it from my wife," Adora says, and she can feel the smile tugging at her lip. "She's the sweetest person I know."

"I happen to know your wife," Catra says against her neck, "and there's nothing sweet about her."

Adora tucks Catra's hair behind her ear, and she knows the way Catra softens at her touch is safe and real. "Then I guess you don't know my wife that well."

Catra takes her hand, pulls it down to pretend to bite it. "I know where you sleep," she murmurs into Adora's hand. "So maybe you shouldn't try me."

Adora grins, because she knows what Catra's doing. Her face warms in anticipation. "Or what?"

Catra stretches up, hums next to Adora's ear, "You know exactly what, princess."

It's not the same as when their relationship was new. It didn't feel like they needed many words, then, but now they talk before, during, after. Catra leads, most of the time. She remembers exactly how Adora's body works, and tries to tell Adora what she wants instead of falling back into what she thought Adora wanted. Adora was tentative at first, second-guessing her every move, but it's easier when Catra directs her. The first time they tried again ended in tears, and sometimes it still does, but it happens less and less. They have many ways to say *stop*, and even more to say *keep going*.

"Can't wait," Adora whispers back, and Catra shivers once, inching closer.

Around them, Glimmer and Bow spin in something that doesn't match the tempo, and Scorpia and Perfuma step in a waltz that does. Lonnie and her boyfriends linger over their plates, talking. Hazel tries to teach Angella a dance that must be of her own design, with Summer and Izzy calling out ideas and Naomi trying not to laugh from her seat. Lonnie's mom leans over to whisper something to Naomi and they lose the battle to keep straight faces. Entrapta has crept forward, and she asks Summer something Adora can't hear.

Adora had thought about her own wedding once, when she was eleven and her classmate Tamara's mother got married. Tamara talked about a big dress and a tall cake and a dance floor that probably wasn't a patch of grass. Adora had imagined all that for herself, with a man with a blurred-out face. Then she went home and gave Catra her pretzels from lunch while they did their homework on her bedroom floor, and Catra helped her keep the numbers in order when she did her long division problems, and Adora thought that she didn't want to have a wedding if Catra wasn't there.

"You okay?" Catra asks, because she knows Adora through to the core of her bones.

"Yeah," Adora says, a little choked. "I just - I love you."

Catra kisses her, deep enough for somebody - probably Lonnie - to whistle behind them, and Catra to shift as she glares at them. Catra's hair sticks to Adora's face when they separate. "I love you too," she says.

Later, they cut the cake that Glimmer made from a box and decorated with rainbow sugar crystals that glitter against the white frosting. Catra misses on purpose when she's supposed to put cake in Adora's mouth and tries to bite Adora's hand when she goes to feed her, eyes sparkling, and Adora had been wrong when she thought she couldn't love her any more than she already did.

Five years later

If Adora doesn't stop fussing with the comforter, Catra's going to scream. "It's fine," she says, taking Adora's hand so she doesn't touch it again. "First, this is the most perfectly centered dragon I've literally ever seen, and second, I don't think there's a kid on earth who gives a shit."

"Better get the profanity out of your system before they get here," Adora says.

"I know how to behave around a kid, Adora."

Adora's face softens. "I know, I'm sorry. I'm just - nervous."

The approval process to become foster parents took months. Classes, background checks, home studies. Dozens of stressed calls to Naomi, worrying about whether they had the right child safety locks and smoke detectors and emergency plans. But they passed all of it, and they got their first call this morning. *Elementary age,* the contact worker said, *you'll get a call later from their worker if you're interested in learning more*. Adora got coverage for her afternoon appointments and Catra told her reports she'd be out for the rest of the day, family emergency.

They'd talked about it for years, all through graduate school, all through Adora's first placements. It took that long for the fear to settle down to a hum. *We're going to do better than her,* Adora said before they submitted their application, sounding like she was trying to convince herself.

Low fucking bar, Catra said, *we'd better meet it.*

Now, Catra says, "It's not our job to be liked, but they're going to like you."

Adora shakes her head a little, but she's smiling. "They're going to *love* you." She brings her other hand to Catra's, fusses with her knuckles. Her eyebrows are drawn. "I know we've talked about this a million times, but-"

"You're never going to do or say anything remotely like her." Catra curls her fingers around Adora's jumpy hands. "But if you get fucking possessed or something, yes I'll stop you."

When Finn's social worker called, they were together, huddled around the speaker. She said that Finn was six, and the last placement broke down because they started stealing their foster

siblings' clothes and erupting on anyone who called them by their birth name. Their current foster family said that they loved Finn but they weren't equipped for a kid who said *I'm not a boy and I'm not a girl, I'm Finn*. The family said that wasn't what they'd signed up for. Catra managed to snarl silently.

"They've started struggling in school," their social worker said, "not paying attention, talking back, fighting other kids. Behavioral problems are some of the primary reasons that a placement gets disrupted, so I always want families to know about them ahead of time. Is that something the two of you think you can handle?

Adora squeezed Catra's hand hard enough to bruise. "Yes." They put a basket of cardboard tubes and Wrong Melog and some of Adora's fidgets in Finn's room, to hold them over until they learned what they liked and what helped them. They double-checked that they had the number of the best child psychologist in town, according to Angella.

Now, Adora shakes out her arms the way she does when they're antsy. "I'm just worried," Adora says, as if Catra couldn't see that from space. "They've dealt with enough. I want them to be okay here."

Catra puts her hands on Adora's shoulders, applying pressure when she strokes down. Twice, three times. "They don't need perfection. They need people they can trust to love them, and you've been that person your whole life."

The knock on the door is loud, and Melog scurries past them into their bedroom. Catra presses Adora's shoulders down one more time. "We can do this."

Finn squints at them, duffel bag over their shoulder. Their social worker starts to talk to Adora immediately, so Catra crouches in front of Finn. She knows better than to try to brush the flash of blonde hair out of his face. "Hi Finn," she says, "it's nice to meet you."

Some of the suspicion seeps out of their face when she uses their name. "Mrs. Fredrick said you have a cat," they say, almost shy, peeking past her.

"Yeah, Melog. They're probably hiding, they get nervous around new people, but by tonight I'm sure they'll love you."

Finn's eyebrows go up. "Is Melog a girl cat or a boy cat?"

"Neither, since they were born. The science is pretty cool, maybe we can talk about it sometime. Do you want to see if they're in your room?"

Melog isn't in Finn's room. Catra tells Finn that, after now, they have to give permission for anyone to come in. Finn scans over the toys in bins, books on shelves, and their eyes narrow at the clothes in the closet. Their fingers pick at the hem of the gray shirt they're wearing.

Catra says, "We didn't know what you liked or what size would fit you, so we got a bunch of things. Whatever you don't want, we can give to another family with a kid who might like them, and we can get you different things that you do like."

Finn reaches out, touches the shoulder of a purple shirt. "I can have any of these?"

"Any of these," Catra says. "I'm going to look for Melog and check on Mrs. Fredrick, okay?"

When Finn re-emerges from their room, they have jeans and the purple shirt. It has a pink dinosaur on it. "I love that shirt," Adora says when she sees them.

Finn plucks at the printing on the front. "It's a diplodocus," they say.

Adora's face goes bright, and she pulls out the book about dinosaurs that she bought for the child-sized bookshelf in the corner. Finn's worker makes her goodbyes, and Finn starts

showing Adora the different dinosaurs they can name, and Adora helps with the rest.

One of the first questions they were asked, when they first applied to foster, was *why.* Catra knows a lot of wrong answers to that question. It's a question she knows her friends have, too. Lonnie and her partners took in Kyle's nephew a year ago, and she sounds more exhausted every time they talk. Glimmer's pregnant, and Bow brings home a different baby gadget every week. Scorpia and Perfuma have a toddler with a pale mop of hair and no sleep schedule. Summer's adoptive family moved to Salineas, and she sent them her eight grade graduation announcement a month ago. The only person with the guts to ask out loud was Hazel, on their weekly call. She lives with her dad and stepmother now, and she invites Catra and Adora to all of her flute recitals.

Catra told the agency *because kids deserve high-quality care and I know they don't always get it.* Catra told Hazel *because there should be more good ones out there*. Watching Adora with Finn now, she knows those were only pieces of the puzzle. She slides to the floor next to her wife and Finn and asks if they know what a pterosaur ate.

After they put Finn to bed that evening, they review paperwork at the kitchen table. Adora glances towards the hallway at every sound, but Catra identifies the sob first. "You should try," Adora says. "I think both of us would overwhelm them, and you're calmer than me."

Finn's not in their bed. On the beanbag in the corner furthest from the door, lit by the nightlight, blonde hair sticks out of a bundle of blankets. "Hey," Catra says, quiet.

When Finn doesn't answer, she says, "New things can be scary, I know." She turns on the projector Naomi gave them when they passed their home study, auroras rippling rainbow on the ceiling. "Can I watch the lights with you?"

Catra can feel Finn watching her instead, as the lights fade through green, blue, purple, red. The worker didn't have any more information about Finn, as much as Catra and Adora had both asked. Catra has no idea what they'll need to be able to trust her, and maybe they never will, and maybe she's not cut out for this, and-

"Can you stay?" Finn asks, quiet. "Both of you?"

"Yeah," Catra says, blinking more than she thought she would. "We'll stay."

Adora brings in blankets and pillows for the floor, and they take turns reading until Finn's asleep. Catra drifts off with soft breathing in her ears and Adora's arm around her, rainbow shadows flowing softly overhead.

Chapter End Notes

Song from the wedding is Slow Dancing by Aly & AJ.

I promised a happy ending :)

When I started writing this fifteen months ago I didn't think it would ever be as long and intense as it became. Thank you for your support of the project I have been affectionately calling The Nightmare ❤️ Rest well and take care of yourselves, we're all going to make it.

End Notes

Thank you for reading ❤

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!